

CM renames Rohini West Metro Station, Begampur sports complex

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In an effort to honour the contribution of stalwarts, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday announced the renaming of metro stations, hospitals and other public places after these luminaries.

Now, Rohini West Metro Station will be known as 'Dr. Baba Saheb Ambedkar Hospital Metro Station'. In addition, the under-construction sports complex in Begampur (Rohini) will be named 'Atal Khel Parisar'

after former Prime Minister and Bharat Ratna Atal Bihari Vajpayee. A statue of the late Prime Minister will also be installed there.

The Chief Minister said Atal Bihari Vajpayee was a statesman in Indian politics who gave new direction to development, democratic values and national unity. Naming the sports complex after him, she said, would inspire the younger generation.

The Chief Minister said Bharat Ratna Dr. Bhimrao Ambedkar's contribution to the country's social and constitutional history is unparalleled.

led. She said institutions and public places associated with his name convey the message of equality, justice and social empowerment to society.

Rekha Gupta said the renamed public places reflect Delhi's diverse cultural identity, social consciousness and national heritage. She said the Government is committed not only to Delhi's development, but also to strengthening its historical and cultural identity.

A meeting of the State Names Authority (SNA), chaired by Chief Minister



and SNA Chairperson Rekha Gupta, was recently held at the Delhi Secretariat, where all the proposals were approved unanimously.

Senior officials, including the Chief Secretary of Delhi, the Secretary of the Urban Development Department, the Managing Director of

Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) and the Director of the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), attended the meeting.

The Chief Minister also informed that the proposal to name the under-construction hospital in Jwalapuri as 'Baba Ramdevji Maharaj Hospital' has been approved.

According to the Chief Minister, the meeting also considered a proposal to incorporate the area's local identity into the name of Dwarka Metro Station.

Approving the proposal, the Authority decided to

rename the station as 'Dwarka-Kakrola Metro Station'. The objective of this decision is to establish the geographical and social identity of the area more clearly.

The meeting also unanimously approved the proposal to rename Britannia Chowk in Shakurpur as 'Ashwini Chopra (Minna) Chowk'.

The Chief Minister said honouring personalities who have made significant contributions to society and public life is among the government's priorities, and such decisions help strengthen

collective public memory.

Rekha Gupta said Delhi is not merely the administrative capital of the country, but also represents the nation's cultural, social and historical consciousness.

She said it is the government's responsibility to honour inspiring personalities, local identity and national values through the naming of important public places and institutions in the capital. Such decisions, she added, help connect future generations with their history, heritage and inspirational figures.

CM HAILS SC'S ORDER ON SIR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday hailed the Supreme Court's order on the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, saying it demolished the agenda of the Congress and other opposition parties to cover up their political "incompetence" by spreading "lies and rumours" and resorting to "mud-slinging" of constitutional bodies.

Delivering a major victory for the Election Commission, the Supreme Court earlier in the day upheld its power to conduct the SIR of voter rolls and said the exercise "breathes life" into the constitutional mandate for fair elections.

Minor held for shooting teenager after argument

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

A 17-year-old Class 12 student is fighting for his life after allegedly being shot at point-blank range following a brief altercation at a restaurant in Delhi's Amar Colony area. Simultaneously, police detained a 16-year-old boy in connection with the incident.

The accused juvenile was arrested by the Crime Branch in the Okhla area early Wednesday, just hours after the shooting. Police recovered a pistol believed to have been used in the crime from his possession.

According to Delhi Police, the incident took place on Tuesday evening when the victim was dining with friends at a local eatery. During this time, a group of boys passed by, and one of them brushed



against the victim's chair, prompting an argument. A girl was also part of the victim's group.

Police stated that the group left the scene but returned within four to five minutes, after which one of the boys allegedly drew a pistol and fired a single shot at the teenager before fleeing.

A PCR call regarding the shooting was received at the Amar Colony police station. Local police teams, including the SHO and ACP, rushed to the location, but the injured

boy had already been taken to Moolchand Hospital. He was subsequently referred to the AIIMS Trauma Centre.

The victim, whose father runs a laundry service in Chattarpur Enclave, remains in a critical condition and is receiving treatment at AIIMS Trauma Centre, according to his uncle.

Police confirmed that only one bullet was discharged during the incident and that no other individuals were injured. Crime investigation teams examined the scene while multiple units reviewed CCTV footage and technical evidence to identify the accused and his accomplices.

The Crime Branch mentioned that the detained juvenile admitted during questioning that he was involved in the shooting following a heated argument with the

victim at the restaurant. The police stated that the accused, who lives in Okhla with his family, is also a Class 12 student.

The victim's uncle spoke to The Pioneer and claimed that the family has received minimal support from local police after the teenager was admitted to the hospital. The police have not followed up with the family since his admission. "The Mar Colony police are not helpful. We have not received a copy of the FIR, either," he said. Additionally, the victim's uncle was uncertain about the series of events that led to the shooting.

Police said efforts are ongoing to identify and apprehend the other boys who were present with the accused at the time of the incident.

Over half of MCD-allotted EV charging stations remain non-operational: Officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than half of the electric vehicle (EV) charging stations allotted under the MCD are yet to become operational due to delays in obtaining approvals from the Public Works Department (PWD), officials said on Wednesday.

According to official data, a total of 1,047 EV charging stations have been allotted across the city, including 185 at the civic body's parking sites and 809 at roadside locations. However, only over 460 stations have so far been made operational.

The officials said the remaining stations are facing delays primarily because of pending no-objection certificates (NOCs) from the PWD for road-



side sites and disruptions caused by anti-pollution measures under the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP).

"The major hindrance is related to PWD approvals for roadside locations. In several cases, permissions are pending, leading to delays in operationalisation," a senior official said. The official added that issues related to desired power load availability at certain sites have also contributed to delays, requiring coordination with power distribution companies (discoms).

Meanwhile, senior PWD officials denied knowledge of the pending NOC approvals referred to by the MCD, but said the department has been working on a broader plan to develop integrated EV infrastructure hubs instead of standalone charging points.

"We are not aware of the NOC approvals sent by the MCD. However, for a long time, the PWD has been planning against setting up EV charging units at isolated locations. Instead, the idea is to develop integrated infrastructure hubs where EV charging stations are clustered together along with facilities such as PUC centres, petrol pumps and refreshment areas, so that commuters can access multiple services at one place," a senior PWD official said.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Be it known that my clients Sanjay Paul and Vijay Paul both sons of Shri Madan Mohan Bharti alias M. M. Bharti son of Shri Milkhi Ram resident of D-11 Jangpura Extension New Delhi – 110014 have requested Supertech Realtors Limited to transfer Unit Number R203NEAST1507/Flat # 1507 in Project Supertech situated at Plot Number 3 Sector 34 Noida 201301 U.P. in their names since their father Madan Mohan Bharti, the original allottee of this unit, has left for his heavenly abode on 16th February 2018. If any body has any objection, he/she may contact Supertech Realtors Limited E Square C-2 Sector 36 Noida U.P. within 15 days of from the publication of this notice.
B S RANDHAWA (Advocate)

PUBLIC NOTICE
My client Vijay Bhola s/o Mr. Shri Ram Bhola R/o Second Floor, 7A/33, East Punjabi Bagh, Delhi 110026 declare that he and Ashok Bhola S/o Shriram Bhola (PAN AAEP66966G) R/o Delhi are partners in Shivam Industries (PAN ABDF59537) and in Shri Ram Industries (PAN AAUF58661) both firms at J-125, Sector 4, DSIDC, Industrial Area, Bawana, Delhi 110039. Due to long bad and ill relations with Ashok Bhola, my client will not be liable for any past or future loan (which he may take in the name of above firms) and other activities related to above firms by Ashok Bhola.
Parvash Kumar Tyagi, Advocate

JASCH GAUGING TECHNOLOGIES LIMITED
Regd Office: 502, NDM-II, NSP, Pitampura, Delhi – 110034
CIN: L33111DL2021PLC381513
Email: cs@jasch.biz; Tel: 0130-2216666

Audited Ind AS Financial Results for the quarter and financial year ended on 31st March 2026
The Board of Directors of Jasch Gauging Technologies Ltd ("the Company") at its meeting held on May 26, 2026, have approved the audited financial results of the Company for the quarter & financial year ended on 31st March 2026.
The results along with auditor's report have been posted on the Company's website at <https://jasch.net.in/> financial-results/ and can be accessed by scanning the QR code.
Place: Sonipat
Date: 26.05.2026
Jai Kishan Garg
Chairman & Managing Director
Note: The above intimation is in accordance with Regulation 33 read with Regulation 47(1) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations & Disclosure Requirements) Regulations 2015.

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER
PWD BUILDING
ASAM:: GUWAHATI-03

No. CEB/CS/TB-IV(B)/10/2026/03
PRESS NOTICE
The Chief Engineer, PWD (Building), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-03 on behalf of the Governor of Assam, invites fresh bid through Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode- I of contract for the work detailed in the table below, from eligible Firm/Contractor of repute having experience in similar nature of work. Details of bid may be seen at e-procurement portal i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in
The bidders must be enrolled with e-tendering web portal www.assamtenders.gov.in

Sl. No.	Name of work	Approx. Value of work(In Rs.)	Bid Security	Bid Processing Fee	Completion period
1.	Construction of Bhupen Hazarika Museum at Srimanta Sankardev Kalashetra, Guwahati, Assam on Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode-I	30,24,36,569.00	2% of Bid value for General category, and 1% of Bid value for Reserved category	30,000.00	18 (Eighteen) Months

Note:-
1. The value of work may change during uploading of DNIT for which no claim will be entertained.
2. The Press Notice will form a part of the Bidding Document

Sd/-
Chief Engineer, P.W.D. (Bldg.)
Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DIPR/C/PIO/68/28-May-26

SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd.
Corporate Off. : 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-Block, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051.
Regd. Off. : Commerzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN

POSSESSION NOTICE FOR IMMovable PROPERTY [(Appendix IV) Rule 8(1)]
WHEREAS the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. a Housing Finance Company (duly registered with National Housing Bank (Fully Owned by RBI)) (hereinafter referred to as "SMHFC") under Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002), and in exercise of the powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notice dated mentioned below under Section 13(2) of the said Act calling upon you being the borrowers (names mentioned below) to repay the amount mentioned in the said notice and interest thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers mentioned herein below having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrowers mentioned herein below and to the public in general that the undersigned has **Taken Possession** of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on me under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of the Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. The borrowers mentioned here in above in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with said property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of "SMHFC" for an amount as mentioned herein under and interest thereon.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of Secured Assets (Immovable Property)	Demand Notice Date & Amount	Date of Possession
1.	Lan.-s: 611539211512655 1. Shiva Jai Parkash S/o. Jai Parkash 2. Himanshu Jai Parkash S/o. Jai Parkash 3. Kailash Devi W/o. Jai Parkash	All The Piece And Parcel Of The Property House Cum Plot No-8c I.e. Old Property Id No-232c.227u.57, New Property Id No-1kg4qk8, Measuring 100 Sq Yards, Situated At Mauja Gobindpuri, Known As Krishna Colony, Block-C, Yamunanagar, Tehsil-Jagadhari, District-Yamunanagar, Within Mc Limits Of Yamunanagar As Per Transfer Deed Bearing Regd. No-7694 Dated 16-2-2023 Recorded In The Name Of Kailash Devi W/O Late Jai Parkash. Bounded as Under:-East-Street, West-House Surinder Saini, North-House Narender Kumar, South-House Kanta Sharma.	13.06.2025 Rs. 50,77,327.35/- (Rs. Fifty Lakh Seventy Seven Thousand Three Hundred Twenty Seven & Paise Thirty Five Only) as on 11.06.2025	25.05.2026

Place : Yamunanagar, Uttar Pradesh
Date : 25.05.2026
Sd/-
Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

ReNew Akshay Urja Limited
CIN : U40300DL2015PLC275651
Regd. Office : 138, Ansal Chambers II, Bikaji Cama Place, Delhi-110066
Corporate Office : ReNew.hub, Commercial Block-1, Zone-6, Golf Course Road, DLF City Phase-V, Gurugram, 122009, Haryana, Phone – 0124-4896 670/ 80
Statement of Financial Results for the quarter and year ended 31 March 2026

Particulars	Quarter ended 31 March 2026	Quarter ended 31 December 2025	Quarter ended 31 March 2025	Year ended 31 March 2026	Year ended 31 March 2025
	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)
Total Income from Operations	489	447	480	1,747	1,650
Net Profit for the year (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	270	229	271	879	764
Net Profit for the year before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	270	229	271	879	764
Net Profit for the year after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	201	168	219	653	592
Total Comprehensive Income for the year [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the year (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	201	168	219	653	592
Paid up Equity Share Capital	133	133	133	133	133
Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	4,956	4,758	4,304	4,956	4,304
Equity component of compulsory convertible debentures	1,144	1,144	1,144	1,144	1,144
Net worth**	6,234	6,035	5,581	6,234	5,581
Debt Equity Ratio *	1.82	1.92	2.00	1.82	2.00
Earnings Per Share (of Rs. 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)	8.79	7.35	9.59	28.57	25.93
1. Basic :	8.79	7.35	9.59	28.57	25.93
2. Diluted :	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
Capital Redemption Reserve *	300	314	306	300	306
Debt Service Coverage Ratio *	1.22	2.19	1.11	1.87	1.61
Interest Service Coverage Ratio *	3.81	3.12	3.58	3.29	2.81
Current Ratio *	7.17	7.93	7.68	7.17	7.88
Long Term Debt to Working Capital*	1.02	0.98	1.30	1.02	1.30
Long Term Debt to Total Assets Ratio*	0.34	0.36	0.40	0.34	0.40
Current Liability Ratio*	0.13	0.11	0.10	0.13	0.10
Debtor Turnover Ratio*	1.48	1.29	1.09	4.06	3.43

Disclosures pursuant to Regulations 52(4) and 52(8) Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015.
- Credit Rating: IND AA+ (CE)
- Change in credit rating : No
- Debt Equity ratio: mentioned above
- Debt Service Coverage Ratio: mentioned above
- Interest Service Coverage Ratio: mentioned above
- Outstanding redeemable preference shares (Quantity and Value): Not Applicable
- Net Worth ** (31 March, 2026) : INR 6,234 (31 March, 2025 : INR 5,581)
- Net profit after tax: mentioned above
- Earning per share: mentioned above
- Debenture Redemption Reserve (31 March, 2026) : INR 300 (31 March 2025 : INR 306)
- There are no material deviation in the use of proceeds of issue of Non Convertible Debentures from the objects stated in the offer document (Regulations 52(7A))

Notes :
1. Ratios have been computed as follows :
- Earning per share (Basic & Diluted) = Profit after Tax / Weighted average number of equity shares
- Debt Equity Ratio* = Debt (Amount due to Debenture Holders) / Equity (Equity share capital + share premium + quasi equity i.e. Short term borrowing but excluding unamortized fees)
- Interest Service Coverage Ratio = Profit before interest, prior period items, tax, extraordinary items and depreciation / (Total Interest Expense).
- Debt Service Coverage Ratio* = ((PAT based on Project Revenues realised (excluding non-cash adjustment, if any) + Depreciation + Interest (Interest, Guarantee Fees, other financing costs payable under Debenture and Project Documents)) / (Interest + Principal Repayment-Guarantee fee).
- Asset Coverage Ratio = (Total Assets) / Debt (Amount due to Debenture Holders)
- Current ratio= Current Assets / Current Liabilities
- Current Liability Ratio= Current Liabilities/ Total Liabilities
- Long Term Debt to Working Capital = Non-Current borrowing including current maturities of Non-current borrowings/ (Current Assets - Current Liabilities (excluding current maturities of Non-Current borrowings))
- Total Debts to Total Assets Ratio = Total outstanding debts/ Total Assets
- Debtors Turnover Ratio = Revenue from operations /Average Trade Receivables
- As per Debenture Trust Deed dated 20 September, 2017.
** Networth represents issued subscribed and paid up capital plus reserves and surplus. Reserves and Surplus includes Capital reserve, General reserve, Debenture redemption reserve, Securities premium account and Profit and loss account balance.
2. The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarterly financial results filed with the National Stock Exchange under regulation 52 of the Listing Regulations. The full format of the quarterly financial results is available on the website of the Stock Exchange.
3. The company is in the business of development and operation of solar power. There is only one segment (business and or geographical) in accordance with the requirements of IND AS - 108 "Operating Segments".
4. For the other line items referred in regulation 52(4) of the Listing Regulations, pertinent disclosures have been made to the National Stock Exchange and can be accessed on the URL – <https://www.nseindia.com/companies-listing/corporate-filings-announcements>
5. The above financial results of the Company for the year ended March 31, 2026 have been approved by the Board of Directors of the Company at the meeting held on May 26, 2026. The statutory auditors of the company have carried the Audit for financial results of the Company for the year ended March 31, 2026.

For and on behalf of
ReNew Akshay Urja Limited
(Sd/-) Parul Agrawal
Managing Director, DIN : 08452687
Place : Gurugram
Date : 27 May, 2026

फ़ससएसआइ
fssai
Food Safety and Standards Authority of India

स्वास्थ्य एवं परिवार कल्याण विभाग
MINISTRY OF HEALTH AND FAMILY WELFARE

Attention
Food Business Operators (FBOs)!
Have you filed your Annual Return yet?

The portal for filing Annual Return (Form D1) for the Financial Year 2025–26 is now OPEN on

FoSCoS
Food Safety Compliance System

Applicable to:

- Manufacturers (including repackers and relabellers)
- Exporters (Manufacturer)
- Importers

Last Date for Filing: 31st May 2026

Non-compliance:
Delay in filing will attract a penalty of ₹100 per day and may also lead to suspension of license.

Navigation Path for Filing Annual Return:

- Step 1: Visit <https://foscos.fssai.gov.in>
- Step 2: Login to Food Businesses using your FoSCoS credentials
- Step 3: Click on Fill Annual Return
- Step 4: Select Year (2025–26) and proceed
- Step 5: Fill and submit Form D1

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The portal for filing annual returns by FY 2025-26 has been opened from 15th May, 2026.

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CBC 17163/13/0001/2627

SIR in city to begin on June 30, final electoral roll on October 7: CEO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the voters list will begin in Delhi with door-to-door visits by booth-level officers from June 30 in a transparent manner.

Addressing a press conference, Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Ashok Kumar on Wednesday said from June 20 to June 29, training of booth-level officers (BLOs) and printing of enumeration forms and other papers will be underway as the in-house activity for the SIR.

Around 25,000 personnel, including 13,000 BLOs, will take part in the mega exercise. No documents will be

required to be attached to the enumeration forms, Kumar said. Stressing that the aim of the SIR was to ensure that no eligible voter is left behind and no ineligible person is a voter, Kumar said that only those under the ASDDF category — absent, shifted, dead, duplicate or foreigners — will be removed from the voters' list.

There are checks and balances at every step of the verification process, and political parties will be involved through booth-level agents (BLAs). All the information will be shared through the website of the CEO's office, he said.

Awareness activities will be carried out, and special

camps will be set up to help voters submit their enumeration forms, Kumar said.

As a pre-revision exercise, mapping of the electors of the year 2002 is underway, Kumar said. Mapping of 62.44 lakh voters has been done (42.5 per cent) out of the total 1.45 crore voters as of May 26, 2026, said the Delhi CEO. The voters will be provided two copies of the enumeration forms, one of which will be filled out and returned to the BLOs. The voters will also have the facility to submit completed enumeration forms online.

The BLOs will visit households thrice. If any house is locked and nobody is to be found, they will leave behind



an enumeration form there. If any voter fails to submit his/her enumeration form, the BLO concerned will make an enquiry from local voters and report him/her as absent, shifted, or dead, as the case may be.

The exercise will cover all voters aged 18 years and

above by the qualifying date of October 1. During SIR, over 13,000 BLOs will conduct house-to-house enumeration. Every existing voter will be provided an enumeration form (in duplicate) to be filled out by them and return one copy to the BLOs, the CEO's office said.

Door-to-door visits by BLOs will start from June 30 and conclude on July 29, after which the draft electoral roll will be published on August 5. The final electoral roll after the SIR will be released on October 7.

After the enumeration, if any discrepancies are found in the filled-out enumeration forms of the voters, they will be issued notices by the

electoral registration officers (EROs). Voters can use one of the 12 types of documents if required to prove any claim.

Voters can also appeal against the decision of the EROs with the District Election Officers (DEOs) and further to the CEO's office.

Those whose names appear in the electoral rolls of 2002 will just need to submit filled-out enumeration forms. In case any voter's name is not there in the 2002 voters' list, he or she can use the details of any of their parents or relatives.

Voters who settled in Delhi after 2002 will have to submit their details (relative name, state name, assembly constituency name, consti-

ty number, part number, serial number) from the voter list of 2002/2003/2005 of their parent state.

Two types of booth-level agents (BLAs) of political parties will be closely associated with the SIR work. BLA-2 will work in tandem with the BLOs in the field to ensure submission of enumeration forms. Each BLA-2 is authorised to submit 50 enumeration forms per day as well as 10 appeals per day after publication of the draft electoral roll.

Also, the political parties will appoint BLA-1 in each of the 70 constituencies. The CEO's office will also conduct training of the BLAs, Kumar added.

Water crisis to persist as Wazirabad Barrage level stays low

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Residents across several parts of Delhi may continue to face disrupted water supply for the next few days as the water level at the Wazirabad barrage remains far below the normal mark, even after Haryana released additional Yamuna water to the national Capital.

The disruption in water supply has already started affecting several localities in North, West and parts of South Delhi. As the city reels under severe heat, the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) on Wednesday reported a shortfall of around 100 MGD against the government's overall water production target.

The water level at the barrage stood at nearly 669.5 feet on Wednesday, sharply lower than the required 674.5 feet needed for smooth operations at key treatment plants. The shortage has already reduced drinking water production in multiple parts of the city.



People gather around a water tanker to fill their empty containers amid scorching summer heat in New Delhi PTI

According to officials, the Haryana government has said that 979.5 cusecs of water have been released via the Carrier Line Canal (CLC) and Delhi sub-branch (DSB) of the Delhi Jal Board (DJB), the water supply has not improved.

"It does not solve our problem because we need water in the Wazirabad pond

through the Yamuna river. The water in the two canals has seen some increase, but that will take around three days to reach the plants," a senior DJB official said.

"Until the water levels return to normal, the water treatment plants are likely to operate below capacity," he added.

According to Delhi gov-

ernment officials, talks are underway with the neighbouring Haryana government to increase the raw water supply. According to officials, Delhi's biggest concern remains the low pond level at Wazirabad, which directly affects the functioning of major water treatment plants.

The shortage has particu-

larly hit the Wazirabad and Chandrawal water treatment plants, impacting several areas in North, West, and parts of South Delhi.

The Wazirabad plant usually produces around 131 million gallons per day (MGD), while Chandrawal has an average output capacity of 94 MGD. Officials said production at these facilities has dropped by nearly 25 to 30 per cent because of the low raw water availability.

DJB's overall average production capacity ranges between 990 and 1000 MGD of drinking water, including the tubewells. As per current estimates, approximately 70-100 MGD of overall water production has been reduced due to problems with low pondage levels at Wazirabad.

Among the areas likely to face continued water supply disruption are Civil Lines, Kamla Nagar, Shakti Nagar, Karol Bagh, Pahar Ganj, Hindu Rao Hospital zone, NDMC areas and parts of Delhi Cantonment along with nearby localities.

CM directs departments to complete budget-related projects within timeline

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday directed all government departments to complete projects and welfare schemes announced in the Budget within fixed timelines, warning that delays and negligence would not be tolerated.

The directions were issued during a high-level virtual review meeting attended by senior officials and department heads. The meeting focused on the implementation of Budget announcements, progress of development works, and preparedness for the upcoming monsoon season.

The Chief Minister stressed that departments failing to properly utilise Budget allocations could face funding cuts in the next Budget cycle. "The government's responsibility does not end with announcements. Every scheme must reach comple-



tion and deliver results on the ground," the Chief Minister said during the review meeting held through video conferencing from Jan Seva Sadan. The virtual meeting was organised as part of the government's Work From Home arrangement. Officials reviewed the status of several infrastructure and welfare projects across departments.

The Chief Minister directed all departments to speed up the implementation of schemes and ensure strict adherence to timelines. She said public welfare projects should not suffer because of

administrative delays.

Monsoon preparedness emerged as a major focus during the meeting. The Chief Minister instructed civic and engineering departments to complete cleaning and desilting of drains before the onset of rains. She said prevention of waterlogging remains one of the government's top priorities and warned officials against any laxity in flood-control measures.

Officials were also asked to improve coordination among agencies responsible for drainage management and civic maintenance.

DDA to develop parking facilities to accommodate around 1 lakh vehicles

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) is set to develop parking facilities to accommodate around 1 lakh vehicles. Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday chaired a high-level meeting, attended by all seven Members of Parliament (Lok Sabha) of the national Capital along with the senior officials of the Delhi Development Authority (DDA).

Various issues related to the city's inclusive development in line with the aspirations of the people and ground realities were discussed, with every MP elaborating upon issues of civic import.

"DDA over the next one year would identify more than 3,000 vacant land parcels to be utilised for surface parking across the city. Of these 232 vacant DDA plots, which will accommodate about one lakh vehicles, are ready to be put up for tender.

Of the 232 plots, 30 are located in the Rohini Zone, 23 in the South Zone, 53 in the North Zone, 98 in the Dwarka Zone and 28 in the East Zone. These will go a long way in addressing the parking woes as well as easing traffic congestion in the capital.

The LG reiterated his earlier directions that all DDA parks shall compulsorily remain open between 06:00 AM and



10:00 AM, and every park that had an entry fee would allow visitors to access and use these parks free of cost during the above-mentioned hours in the morning.

During the meeting, all the Members of Parliament (MPs) identified unauthorised occupation and encroachment as one of the biggest civic issues in the city, officials said.

"MPs assured of full cooperation with the authorities in dealing with them. Issues related to parking, traffic, encroachments, utilisation of vacant DDA lands and accessibility to and maintenance of DDA parks were discussed at length," DDA officials added.

Students protesting DU's decision to hold exams on Eid-Ul-Azha

Students protest DU's decision to hold exams on Eid-Ul-Azha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Students protesting Delhi University's decision to conduct examinations on Eid-Ul-Azha were allegedly dragged, manhandled, and beaten by security personnel outside the university's examination branch on Wednesday, with AISA claiming hundreds of security guards had been deployed at the premises to prevent demonstrators from entering the building. However, the DU Proctor denied that any scuffle took place.

AISA vice-president Ananya, speaking at the protest, said students who had come to demand "dignity and sensitivity" on a gazetted holiday were met with force instead.

"We will continue our protest until our demands are met," she said. A student delegation that subsequently met DU Proctor Manoj Kumar Singh received no relief.

Singh maintained that there had been no man-



handling. "They were trying to enter the building, so they were just asked to leave. The university's decision remains the same; the exams scheduled for Thursday will be held as scheduled," he said.

The protest followed a decision by Delhi University to proceed with scheduled examinations on May 28, the same day officially declared a gazetted holiday for Eid-ul-Azha.

The controversy was triggered by an Office Memorandum issued on May 25, bearing number Gen-II/128/2026/Holidays/3036,

in which the university revised the Bakrid holiday from Wednesday, May 27, to Thursday, May 28, in line with a central government notification.

The same memorandum simultaneously stated that examinations would continue as scheduled on May 28. The contradiction drew immediate criticism from students, teachers, and Opposition politicians.

Several members of the Delhi University Teachers' Association wrote to Vice Chancellor Yogesh Singh requesting the postponement of the May 28 examinations.

Police on high alert ahead of Eid-Ul-Azha



Delhi Police personnel patrol near Jama Masjid ahead of Bakra Eid (Eid Ul-Azha) in New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police has intensified security arrangements across the national capital ahead of Eid-Ul-Azha, deploying additional forces, flag marches, anti-riot vehicles and social media surveillance to ensure peaceful celebrations.

Police said special focus is on sensitive areas across Delhi, where elaborate deployment and coordination exercises are underway.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Northeast) Rahul Alwal said that around 1,100 police personnel, along with 23 additional companies, have been deployed across the district.

"In view of the sensitivity of the area ahead of Eid-Ul-Azha, we have made elaborate security arrangements across northeast Delhi. The security arrangements will remain in force from the night," he said.

From 5 am onwards, police will be deployed at all major namaz sites and sensitive locations, including areas near temples, Alwal said.

"We have identified multiple picket points, Quick Reaction Teams (QRTs), and intensified motorcycle patrolling to ensure swift response in any situation," the DCP said.

He said ACPs and SHOs have been continuously holding meetings with Aman Committees and local community leaders over the last two to three weeks to ensure communal harmony during

the festival. "We have also kept anti-riot equipment, including Vajra vehicles, on standby as part of the security arrangements," Alwal said.

He said police are coordinating closely with the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), Delhi Jal Board and the electricity department for deploying tankers and support vehicles at various points.

"We will ensure that no sacrifice is carried out in the open and that animal waste is not dumped on roads or public places. Strict action will be taken against anyone found violating the guidelines," he said.

Meanwhile, police in north Delhi carried out a flag march in several sensitive localities, including Sadar Bazar, Eidgah, Quresh Nagar, Qutub Road and Bara Hindu Rao.

DCP (North) Raja Banthia said the exercise aims to ensure peaceful celebrations and spread awareness about the guidelines issued for the festival.

"Namaz should not be offered on main roads and animal sacrifice should not be carried out openly," he said.

"We have held meetings and communicated these guidelines to members of all communities. They have assured us of full cooperation in ensuring that the directions are followed," Banthia said.

He said around 15 to 20 companies of police personnel will be deployed in the district on the day of the festival.

Over 7.72 lakh Ayushman Bharat cards issued in city

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Wednesday said that under the Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB PM-JAY), a total of 7,72,129 Ayushman Bharat health cards have been issued in the city, including 2,90,475 cards under the Vaya Vandana Scheme (VVS) and 4,81,654 under the Non-VVS category, extending healthcare coverage to senior citizens and eligible families.

The scheme is further strengthening healthcare support for Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB PM-JAY), under which citizens are eligible for up to ₹10 lakh cashless healthcare coverage. This includes ₹5 lakh coverage



under the Central Government's AB PM-JAY scheme along with an additional ₹5 lakh health cover provided by the Delhi Government, ensuring stronger financial protection and wider access to quality treatment for beneficiaries including senior citizens.

Under the scheme, 46,963 beneficiaries have availed treatment so far, while 34,715 claims worth ₹86.22 crore have been settled, providing financial protection and reducing out-of-pocket healthcare expenses for beneficiaries.

Delhi draft B&B policy proposes 8 rooms, 16 beds limit, silver-gold categories; makes CCTV mandatory

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Residential properties with up to eight rooms and 16 beds may soon operate as Bed and Breakfast units in Delhi under a draft policy proposing Silver and Gold categories, mandatory CCTV cameras, police verification and compliance with safety and hygiene norms.

The policy introduces two categories — Gold and Silver with classification based on room size, furnishings, sanitation standards, guest amenities and safety arrangement, a senior official said.

As of 2023, more than 2,200 rooms at 432 houses across the national capital were registered under the Delhi Government's 'Bed and Breakfast' scheme

since its launch.

For Gold Category establishments, guest rooms must have a minimum area of 120 square feet and include facilities such as wardrobes, study tables, televisions, filtered drinking water, proper ventilation and cooling arrangements including fans or air-conditioners wherever necessary, he said.

Bathrooms in the Gold Category would require western-style toilets, running hot and cold water, ventilation systems, proper drainage and enhanced toiletries, he said.

Silver Category establishments would have comparatively relaxed standards, including a minimum room size of 100 square feet along with clean bedding, cooling facilities, filtered water and



dedicated or attached bathrooms.

The official said that the draft Delhi Bed and Breakfast Policy 2026, put up for public feedback by the Department of Tourism, seeks to overhaul the existing framework for neighbourhood-based accommodation by simplifying registration rules and introducing detailed standards for hygiene, infrastructure, safety and guest services.

The draft policy empha-

sised on guest safety and operational standards. All registered B&B units would be required to maintain guest registers, conduct police verification and comply with foreign guest reporting norms.

Safety measures such as fire extinguishers, first-aid kits, emergency contact displays and functional door locks have also been made mandatory. CCTV cameras, where installed, would only be permitted at entrances and common areas, he explained.

The proposed rules further require daily cleaning of guest rooms, bathrooms and common areas, proper waste segregation, adequate ventilation and hygienic preparation of food wherever meals are provided, he said.

IN FOCUS



Otters are seen at Sarthana Nature Park on the occasion of World Otter Day in Surat, Gujarat

Union Govt approves major ED restructuring plan

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Centre has approved a substantial reorganisation of the Enforcement Directorate (ED), including an expansion of its workforce across various cadres, in a significant development aimed at enhancing the agency's operational capabilities. This decision, authorised by a sanction order issued by the Department of Revenue under the Ministry of Finance, seeks to bolster the ED's capacity to effectively manage the growing number of cases related to money laundering and economic offences.

The most notable changes are within the executive cadre. The number of additional directors of enforcement has more than doubled from 10 to 24, while the number of joint directors will increase from 28 to 49.

Deputy Directors will rise from 148 to 267, and Assistant Directors from 255 to 531. Enforcement officers will see an increase from 355



to 606, and assistant enforcement officers from 425 to 803. The positions of director and special director remain unchanged at one and seven, respectively.

The legal cadre has also experienced significant growth. The number of additional directors (prosecution) has increased from one to seven, deputy legal advisers from seven to eighteen, and assistant legal advisers from eighteen to thirty-six. Additionally, a new adjudication wing is being established to expedite proceedings under the Prevention of Money Laundering

Act (PMLA). This wing will include two additional directors (adjudication), three joint directors, five deputy directors, and ten assistant directors. The position of Special Director (Adjudication) is retained at one.

Within the system's cadre, the position of system analyst remains, now placed at a higher pay level. The number of scientific technical assistants remains at eleven, with an upgraded pay scale. The ministerial cadre will see the creation of a new post of internal financial advisor. Assistant Directors (Official

Language) will increase from three to six, Superintendents from twenty to thirty, and Assistants from fifty-seven to sixty-five. Other ministerial positions, such as senior translators, upper division clerks, and lower division clerks, will remain unchanged. In the security cadre, the number of senior sepoy will increase from 209 to 273, while the number of sepoy remains at 70.

Among support staff, senior private secretaries will rise from one to four, and stenographer grade-I posts will increase from twenty to forty-four. The number of private secretaries, stenographers grade II, drivers, and multitasking staff remains largely unchanged.

The expenditure for the expanded cadre will be financed by Enforcement, with approval from the competent authority. Senior officials have stated that the notable increases—particularly at the deputy director, assistant director, and enforcement officer levels—will enable the agency to process a larger volume of cases

concurrently, reduce delays in investigations and prosecutions, and facilitate faster filings of charges and more rapid progress in high-profile cases.

The expansion of the legal cadre, including additional prosecution directors and legal advisers, is expected to strengthen the ED's courtroom presence, improve conviction rates, and enhance overall legal efficiency.

Furthermore, the creation of the adjudication wing will expedite the resolution of pending PMLA cases, resulting in faster property attachments and penalties. The increase in ministerial and support staff will streamline administrative processes and internal coordination, allowing investigators to focus more intently on enforcement activities. This move by the Government comes at a time when investigations into financial crimes and money laundering are rising steadily, underscoring the need for an expanded workforce to ensure timely and effective enforcement.

UP's CBN unit seizes 8,800 narcotics tablets

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

The Uttar Pradesh unit of the Central Bureau of Narcotics (CBN) has seized 8,800 NRx tablets and 1,269 bottles of Codeine Phosphate syrup, and arrested one person during an operation near Haryana's Sonipat, officials said on Wednesday.

Deputy Narcotics Commissioner Praveen Bali told PTI that the operation was conducted on Tuesday jointly by officers of the Bareilly Division of the UP

unit of CBN and the Delhi Cell of CBN Headquarters, Gwalior, under the Centre's "Nasha Mukht Bharat Abhiyan". Acting on specific intelligence inputs, the CBN team intercepted a car on the Meerut-Kharkhoda highway near Sonipat and apprehended a person allegedly transporting narcotic prescription medicines without valid documentation, Bali said. During the search, officials recovered 2,600 tablets of Clonazepam, 6,200 tablets of Tramadol and 1,269 bottles of Codeine from the vehicle, he said.

Chennithala rejects BJP tie-up claim over ED raids

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala on Wednesday denied allegations that the ED searches at residences linked to Marxist veteran Pinarayi Vijayan were part of a "Congress-BJP operation," and claimed instead that the CPI(M) had an understanding with the saffron party.

His cabinet colleague, K Muraleedharan, said the party does not trust the Enforcement Directorate and does not take its investigations seriously. "So, let the searches go on," he told



reporters. Chennithala, speaking to reporters, said the CPI(M) has to explain "why its bond with the BJP had failed", leading to the ED action. He also rejected the CPI(M) claim that the

raids followed a meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister VD Satheesan a day earlier. The minister said a meeting between the PM and the Kerala CM was necessary for the state and part of routine Government work. "Pinarayi Vijayan met the PM so many times when he was CM," he pointed out, adding there was no need to connect the meeting with the searches.

Chennithala termed the CPI(M) allegation that the searches were an outcome of an arrangement between the Congress and BJP a "fixed refrain." "There is no

need for that. Everyone knows what the Congress, BJP and CPI(M) stand for. All I want to ask is what happened to the people who entered into partnerships. They- the CPI(M) and BJP- had a partnership. The biggest connection was between them. They need to tell people how that partnership ended and why," he claimed.

Later, Muraleedharan said the Congress does not agree with everything the ED does.

"We have no links with the ED. Now that we are in power, I am sure the ED will enter the secretariat as well. We do not trust the agency,

and we do not take its investigations seriously," he said. On CPI(M) workers and activists taking to the streets to protest against the searches, he said it was not out of love for the former Kerala CM.

"Now that all departments, including the police, are under us, it is a good opportunity for them to damage Government property in the name of protests. Otherwise, why would someone throw stones at a police vehicle over the NEET issue, on which both the Government and the opposition hold the same view?" he asked.

Sri Ganganagar hottest at 48.2 degrees Celsius, as heatwave grips north India

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Northern India continued to sizzle under blistering heat on Wednesday, with Rajasthan's Sri Ganganagar recording the highest temperature in the country at 48.2 degrees Celsius, according to the Indian Meteorological Department (IMD).

The IMD classifies a heatwave in the plains if the maximum temperature exceeds 45 degrees, while temperatures above 47 degrees are categorised as a severe heatwave.

Sri Ganganagar's recorded temperature was 5.5 notches above normal, while several other regions in the desert state witnessed mercury hovering around 46-47 degrees Celsius. Pilani was the second hottest place in the state at 47 degrees Celsius,



Woman covering herself while walking amid heatwave at the Sangam in Prayagraj

PTI

followed by Bikaner at 46.6 degrees, Chiru and Jaisalmer at 46.4 degrees each, Phalodi at 46.2 degrees, and Kota at 45.4 degrees.

In Uttar Pradesh, Banda district emerged as the hottest place in the state at 47.8 degrees Celsius, fol-

lowed by Prayagraj at 46.4 degrees, Jhansi at 46 degrees, Orai at 45.6 degrees, Kanpur (IAF) at 45.2 degrees and Deomali at 45.1 degrees.

Temperatures in neighbouring Delhi, Haryana and Chandigarh also hovered between 45 and 46 degrees

Celsius. Maharashtra's Vidarbha region witnessed marginal relief compared to previous day, although temperatures continued to remain around 45 degrees Celsius. Brahmapuri, which has been registering record-breaking temperatures, saw

the mercury settle at 46 degrees Celsius.

Meanwhile, the meteorological centre in Dehradun issued an orange alert for several districts in Uttarakhand, forecasting heavy rain, thunderstorms, hailstorms, and squalls over the next few days.

According to the weather forecast, an orange alert is in place for May 28 for Uttarkashi, Rudrapur, Chamoli, Bageshwar and Pithoragarh districts. These areas are likely to experience thunderstorms accompanied by lightning, hailstorms, and gusty winds reaching speeds of 40 to 50 kmph, gusting up to 60 kmph.

The remaining districts of the state are also expected to witness isolated thunderstorms, lightning, and winds blowing at 40 to 50 kmph.

NAGPUR DEATHS: COPS SAY EXTREME TEMPERATURE MAY BE CULPRIT	
Nagpur: Amid scorching summer in Nagpur, where the temperature has crossed 46 degrees Celsius, the deaths of 17 people in the last three days at various places, including five at the railway station on Wednesday, are under scrutiny, with police suspecting heat exposure as the likely cause. The deceased include persons found near station premises, on roadsides, beneath flyovers, near markets, gardens and public spaces. Most of them appeared to be homeless or living in vulnerable conditions, according to police. Police suspect that extreme heat and prolonged exposure may have contributed to	several of the fatalities. "Many victims appeared to be homeless or travelling in difficult conditions. The medical reports will confirm the exact causes behind fatalities, but heat exposure is suspected in many cases," a senior Nagpur Police officer said. Police have registered accidental death cases in all incidents and are awaiting post-mortem reports to determine the exact causes of death. On May 24, three unidentified men were found unconscious in Pachpaoli, Imamwada and Hudkeshwar areas of Nagpur city. Another body was recovered from a garden near the Aradhana bus stop in Wathoda. (PTI)

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Siddaramaiah set to exit

Senior Congress MLA and Chairperson of the Administrative Reforms Commission in the State RV Deshpande confirmed that Siddaramaiah had decided to resign. The former minister, who met Siddaramaiah at his residence, said that when some MLAs insisted he should not resign, the CM replied that he had given his word to the high command and would respect it.

"I was with the CM. He said, 'I have decided to resign.' I did not question him about why he was resigning. We tried to persuade him to continue," Deshpande said.

On Wednesday, supporters of Siddaramaiah gathered outside his official residence protesting amid intense speculation that he may step down. Police deployed outside his official residence, Kaveri, whisked away the protesters in buses as they shouted slogans.

Supporters accused Congress high command of engineering a crisis, pointing out that the party's dominance in Karnataka rests on Siddaramaiah and his support base. They also raised slogans against the Congress leadership, expressing displeasure over the move for a CM change. AICC General Secretary in charge of the State, Randeep Singh Surjewala, urged the media not to speculate on the issue. He said the Congress is capable of deciding its leadership matters and would inform the public whenever any decision is taken.

ED raids on Pinarayi trigger protests

The raids were carried out while eight central security personnel guarded the premises. Hearing about the raids at the CPI(M) veteran's residence, party workers and activists from its allied organisations gathered outside Vijayan's rented house and staged a protest.

As the ED officials and central security personnel who took part in the raid left his home, the situation escalated, with protesters surrounding and blocking their hired vehicles and throwing stones and bricks at them, badly damaging the

windshields, other windows and exterior rear-view mirrors. The large number of protesters, shouting slogans against the ED and the Centre, kicked the vehicles, banged their fists and sticks on the windows and windshields, and even threw rotten eggs at them.

One of the drivers of the vehicles sustained an injury. The ED officials then went to the Thampanoor police station to lodge a complaint against the protesters. Police and central security personnel struggled to control the crowd as the vehicles, which also had a female official on board, were targeted during the incident. Later, Police arrested for CPI(M) workers for attacking the ED officials..

Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala said that the Home Department and the Kerala Police had no prior information about the Enforcement Directorate (ED) raid. "We were not informed, and police assistance was not sought. The ED used central forces to carry out the raids," he said.

The BJP strongly condemned the attack on ED officials, calling it an assault on the rule of law. In a post on X, BJP state president Rajeev Chandrasekhar said, "Violence is the last refuge of the corrupt." Attacking officials on duty and obstructing an investigation is not a political protest. It is an assault on the rule of law, the BJP MLA said. He alleged, "As usual, the Congress-led state Government is keeping quiet to protect its political twin, the CPI(M).

He further added that the BJP-NDA would ensure that the investigation is not derailed.

Earlier, angry CPI(M) workers hurled helmets, plastic bottles and stones at security personnel deployed outside Vijayan's house while ED searches were underway inside.

Vijayan alleged that the ED searches at his premises were part of a targeted crackdown on opposition leaders across the country. Speaking to reporters after ED officials concluded hours-long searches at his house at Bakery Junction, Vijayan said such actions would not weaken him or the CPI(M).

"This is only the beginning. Nobody should harbour the illusion that such actions can intimidate or weaken us," he said.

The veteran CPI(M) leader alleged that the BJP-led Centre has been using central agencies

against opposition leaders since it came to power, and claimed that the action against him was also part of that strategy.

The ED carried out the raids a day after the Kerala High Court dismissed a petition filed by Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited and its top officials challenging an Enforcement Directorate (ED) money laundering probe linked to alleged financial irregularities involving Vijayan's daughter, Veena T, and her software firm Exalogic Solutions.

In a judgment delivered on May 26, Justice T R Ravi ruled that the ED was legally empowered to continue its investigation under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), even before the filing of a formal FIR or final report by the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO).

The company had approached the court seeking to quash the ED's Enforcement Case Information Report (ECIR), summons issued to its officials, and related proceedings. It argued that the ED lacked jurisdiction because no scheduled offence existed when the probe began. The case traces back to Income Tax raids conducted in January 2019 at the company's offices and the residences of senior executives. Later, the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ordered an SFIO investigation into the company's affairs following a complaint filed by BJP leader Shone George. During the hearing, the ED informed the court that the SFIO had since filed a complaint in April 2025 alleging offences under the Companies Act, including fraud provisions that qualify as scheduled offences under the PMLA.

As the raids were progressing at various locations, CPI(M) leaders and workers held protest marches in various districts across the state. CPI(M) leader K N Balagopal alleged that the ED's "politically motivated witch-hunt targeting Comrade Vijayan" was part of a broader political agenda aimed at weakening the CPI(M) and the Left.

Responding to the CPI(M)'s charge, BJP leader V Muraleedharan said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi had "better things to do" than strike any deal with the Congress to target the CPI(M), which he said had limited national presence.

Govt pushes AI to power PDS

State Governments were facing difficulties in bearing the transportation cost of foodgrain to PDS shops.

This cost will be supported under the scheme wherein FPS dealers' remuneration will also be enhanced, Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw told reporters after the Cabinet meeting.

"Right from selection of beneficiaries to movement of foodgrains, to getting proactive feedback from citizens, to reducing transportation distance — all those activities have been approved," Vaishnaw added.

SARTHAK-PDS merges two existing programmes — assistance for intra-State foodgrain movement and FPS dealer margins and the SMART-PDS modernisation scheme — into a single scheme to curb leakages.

The scheme will deploy AI to weed out duplicate and ghost beneficiaries, forecast demand, track vehicles, optimise routes and handle grievance redressal.

Under the new scheme, the Government projects logistics cost reductions of 15-50 per cent from the scheme, with annual savings of Rs 280 crore and a 36 per cent reduction in carbon emissions from shorter transport routes.

The scheme further plans deployment of Machine Learning (ML), Natural Language Processing (NLP) and Blockchain to modernise PDS operations. Key deliverables include standardised architectures and unified databases for real-time monitoring, analytics systems, and State Command Control Centres for data-driven oversight. ISO-certified process frameworks will also be put in place to ensure transparency, security and operational sustainability.

"The Government has a commitment to the people of the nation — a dignified life by ensuring access to food and nutritional security through the availability of adequate quantities of quality foodgrains," read a Government release. Vaishnaw was categorical that SARTHAK-PDS does not replace the existing PDS architecture but is designed to bring structural reform

across the delivery of foodgrains, logistics, transportation, material handling and grievance redressal.

SC rejects challenge to SIR

"We are equally satisfied that, in its object and design, the impugned SIR bears a direct nexus to the constitutional goal of a free and fair election. Free and fair elections do not rest merely upon the mechanics of polling. They equally depend upon the integrity, accuracy and purity of the electoral roll which forms the foundation of the democratic process," the court said.

The bench also made it clear that Aadhaar is not proof of citizenship, justifying the ECI stand to not treat it as a primary document to establish statutory eligibility for voting. The court reaffirmed its earlier order and directed the ECI to treat Aadhaar as an "additional 12th document" for identity verification in Bihar's revised rolls.

The bench separately dealt with the validity of the documentation regime prescribed by the Commission as part of the enumeration process. The verdict said the ECI was entitled to classify documents on the basis of their evidentiary value in establishing statutory conditions such as residence and eligibility. The verdict said the choice of proposed documents for verification of electoral rolls and their evidentiary standards necessarily falls within the discretionary domain of the Commission which may not be substituted subject to reasonableness. The bench noted that unlike a passport or a birth certificate, a ration card is not "conclusive proof of citizenship" and is often susceptible to misuse. The court had framed the SIR challenge into four questions. First, whether the SIR was consistent with the constitutional and statutory mandate of the ECI? Second, if the means adopted by the ECI bear a reasonable nexus with the objectives sought to be achieved? Third, whether the measures undertaken were necessary and no other alternative existed? Fourth, whether a fair balance has been maintained between the importance of achieving the stated objective and the limitation imposed upon constitutional rights.

PM Modi urges citizens to take precautions amid heatwave

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

'Nautapa (nine-day intense heat period)' unrelenting fury across vast swathes of the country has prompted Prime Minister Narendra Modi to appeal to the citizens to take all precautions and take care of the elderly and children. It is the first time a prime minister has reached out to the people battling the vagaries of the weather. The seriousness of the situation also figured in the cabinet meeting here on Wednesday, with the prime minister directing the union ministers to ensure that their respective ministries and departments take necessary steps to mitigate the impact of the prevailing heat wave conditions.

In a series of posts on X, the prime minister said that children, the elderly and those working outdoors are especially vulnerable to extreme heat, and no one should ignore the warning signs of



heat exhaustion, as it can quickly turn dangerous and may even lead to heatstroke. "Different parts of India are witnessing soaring temperatures and the challenges that come with it. This heat is harsh on all of us, and I urge you all to take as many precautions as possible," he said.

Modi urged everyone to stay hydrated, carry water whenever stepping out and also offer a glass of water to others, as such kindness goes

a long way in such weather. "Watch for signs of heat exhaustion like dizziness, nausea or extreme fatigue. If someone around you feels unwell, weak or develops a headache, it is best to help move them to a cool and shaded place immediately," he said.

Modi also urged citizens to help those affected by the heat and ensure that they get water, ORS, etc., which give them relief. "In such weather, timely care and attention go

a long way," he said. The prime minister also urged the citizens to call and check on elderly parents, grandparents and loved ones whenever possible during the heatwave. "Remind them to stay hydrated, avoid stepping out in peak afternoon hours and take rest whenever possible," he said.

Modi also appealed to people to remember birds and animals amid the harsh weather. "In this extreme heat, let us also remember the birds and animals around us. A small bowl of water kept outside your home, balconies, terraces, shops or offices can become a lifeline for a thirsty bird. May compassion guide us in these difficult days," he said.

After that, at the Cabinet meeting, PM Modi directed all Union Cabinet ministers to ensure that their respective ministries and departments take necessary steps to mitigate the impact of the prevailing heatwave conditions across the country.

SC verdict on SIR raises more questions than answers: Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Wednesday said that although the Supreme Court acknowledged the constitutional validity of the SIR (Special Intensive Revision) of electoral rolls, its verdict raised more questions than it answered.

The Congress disagreed with the verdict and said legal sanction could confer prima facie legitimacy to the SIR, but it could not cure the "malice in implementation".

Congress senior spokesperson Abhishek Singhvi said the issue was always a matter of substance and intent but never of form, and the party had questioned the mode, manner, timing and style in which it was carried out by the Election Commission.

"The Supreme Court has indeed acknowledged the constitutional validity of SIR, but in giving as many answers as the apex court has, it has



Congress senior spokesperson Abhishek Singhvi

also raised just as many questions," he told reporters at a press conference.

Singhvi raised several shortcomings on the part of the Election Commission in conducting the exercise, which were challenged in the Supreme Court, and lamented that it was unfortunate that the Supreme Court made no comments on them.

"The SIR is always a matter of substance, never merely a matter of form. The issue was never about the power to conduct SIR. What was being questioned was the mode, manner, timing, and style in which it was being carried out," he said.

Nation Focus



PM, CONGRESS PAY TRIBUTE TO NEHRU ON DEATH ANNIVERSARY

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Congress leaders on Wednesday paid tributes to former Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru on his 62nd death anniversary. "Paying homage to former Prime Minister Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru on his death anniversary," Modi said in a social media post.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and former party chief Rahul Gandhi paid floral tributes to Nehru at his memorial at Shanti Van.

In a social media post in Hindi, Rahul Gandhi said, "A humble tribute to the country's first Prime Minister, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, on his death anniversary. Laying the strong foundations of modern India, he dedicated his entire life to building an inclusive, harmonious, and progressive nation."

(PTI)



PRADHAN, K RADHAKRISHNAN ASSESS NEET-UG READINESS

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Wednesday held a meeting with former ISRO chairman K Radhakrishnan to assess preparedness for the NEET-UG 2026 re-exam, scheduled to be held on June 21.

Radhakrishnan is also chairman of a high-powered steering committee, which is tasked with monitoring implementation of recommendations on the National Testing Agency (NTA), according to an official statement.

Pradhan and Radhakrishnan reviewed measures being taken to strengthen examination security and surveillance systems.

(PTI)

₹1,150 cr cocaine seized off Mundra coast; 3 held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad/New Delhi

In one of the biggest drug hauls in recent times, 115 kgs of cocaine worth over ₹1,150 crores was seized in a joint operation by the Gujarat police and the Indian Coast Guard (ICG), officials said on Wednesday.

They said an international trafficking network was busted during the operation on May 25-26, and the contraband was recovered from a vessel off the Mundra port. Three foreign nationals were also apprehended, officials said. Giving details, they said

ed from the national capital's Dwarka area two other foreign nationals who were supposed to take the delivery, he said. Search was on for another suspect, also a Tanzanian national, who jumped into the sea during the operation, the DGP added.

GPS devices, satellite communication equipment and AirTags were also seized from the consignment bags, indicating the contraband may have been electronically tracked during transit, officials said.

The Anti-Terrorist Squad and the Coast Guard jointly carried out the operation following specific intelligence

CBI arrests two more in NEET-UG paper leak case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has apprehended two additional individuals in connection with the NEET-UG 2026 question paper leak, increasing the total number of arrests to thirteen, the agency announced on Wednesday. Among those detained is Dr Manoj Shirure, a physician based in Latur, who allegedly assisted three students, including the son of a coaching centre proprietor, in obtaining Chemistry questions from the accused, PV Kulkarni. The other individual detained is Tejas Harshadkumar Shah, a



Physics instructor at Dr Abhang Prabhu Medical Academy in Pune, who is alleged to have procured the leaked Physics questions from the accused, Manisha Havaladar.

The investigation into the sequence of events and the

conspiracy underlying this case remains ongoing.

The CBI has conducted searches at 49 locations across various regions and has seized multiple incriminating documents, laptops, and mobile phones. These items are currently being

analysed in detail. The investigation was initiated on May 12, 2026, following a written complaint from the Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education, concerning the alleged breach of the NEET-UG 2026 examination questions. In response, the CBI formed special teams, conducted searches nationwide, and arrested and interrogated numerous suspects.

To date, the agency has arrested thirteen suspects from Delhi, Jaipur, Gurugram, Nasik, Pune, Latur, and Ahliyanagar. The investigation continues, with various specialised teams working concurrently.

US bound Air India flight returns; 22% domestic flights cut

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

After being airborne for nine hours, a San Francisco-bound Air India plane, carrying around 230 passengers, returned to the national Capital due to a technical issue on Wednesday. The wide-body aircraft's (VT ALL) traffic collision avoidance system (TCAS) was not working properly.

The aircraft, which had left Delhi at 3.09 am, returned to Indira Gandhi International Airport just after noon. A B777 burns about 8-9 tonnes of fuel every hour, depending on wind flows and other factors.

At a time when oil prices are on fire, and the rupee touches new life lows on a daily basis, this was one technical snag the loss-making airline could have done without.

According to data available on the flight-tracking website FlightRadar24, the aircraft remained airborne for nine hours. The plane reportedly began diverting back to Delhi after flying for over three hours while passing through Chinese



airspace. In a statement, the airline said: "AI 173 from Delhi to San Francisco on May 27 has returned to Delhi due to a technical issue in accordance with the laid down procedures. The aircraft landed safely and will undergo technical inspection in line with Air India's safety standards".

"We regret the inconvenience caused to the passengers and are making alternative arrangements to fly them to their destination as soon as possible... our ground teams are providing

all necessary assistance to the passengers, including refreshments, hotel accommodation or rescheduling as opted by them. The safety and well-being of passengers and crew remain Air India's highest priority," the airline said.

In another development, Air India has temporarily cut 22 per cent of its domestic flights as the loss-making airline grapples with the impact of the high fuel prices.

The decision comes two weeks after the Tata Group-

owned airline announced a 27 per cent reduction in international flights amid airspace curbs, as well as costlier jet fuel, which have pushed the operational costs higher for overseas sectors.

Air India operates around 4,400 weekly flights. Out of them, about 3,600 are domestic, and 800 are international services.

"In continuation of our previously announced adjustments to select international services between June and August 2026, we have temporarily rationalised operations on certain domestic routes during the same period, with a reduction in frequencies on select routes," Air India said in a statement on Wednesday. The sources said 20-22 per cent of the domestic flights would be reduced.

Based on around 3,600 weekly domestic flights, the 22 per cent cut would result in a reduction of more than 790 weekly services.

The airline said these adjustments are driven by the sustained impact of high fuel prices on overall operations.

CPI opposes panel on demographic shift, terms it divisive



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Communist Party of India (CPI) on Wednesday strongly condemned the Union Government's decision to constitute a high-level committee to examine alleged "unnatural demographic changes" in the country. Terming the move a dangerous attempt by the BJP-led regime to deepen communal polarisation, the Left party alleged that the initiative aims to strike fear among minorities and marginalised sections.

In a sharply worded statement, the CPI Central Office stated that the exercise is a direct continuation of the politics behind the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA), the proposed National Register of Citizens (NRC), and the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Defence ministry invites private sector to build AMCA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The defence ministry, for the first time, has opted for the private sector for a major defence development project, inviting it to partner in building a next-generation fighter jet under the ambitious Advanced Multirole Combat aircraft (AMCA). The cost of the proposed deal is more than 15,000 crores.

Once it is inducted, India will join an exclusive list of countries with fifth-generation fighters. As of May 2025, only the US (F-22 and F-35), China (J-20) and Russia (Su-57) have these.

Meanwhile, kick-starting the selection process, the ministry on Wednesday issued a request for proposal (RFP) or tender to the three contenders, including Tata Advanced Systems, Larsen and Toubro and Bharat Forge. The AMCA is rated to be the nation's biggest indigenous aerospace programme. The



Government is fully funding the ₹15,000 crore project to build the AMCA prototype.

The Government plans to build five prototypes of the Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA) at a new greenfield facility in Puttaparthi, Andhra Pradesh.

This move is historic as it opens fighter jet manufacturing to the private sector in India and promises faster development. It also strengthens India's push for self-reliance in cutting-edge aerospace technology.

While Larsen and Toubro has partnered with Bharat

Electronics Limited, Bharat Forge has reached an understanding with BEMIL. Interestingly, state-run aerospace major Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL) has been kept out of the process, sources said.

India has been focusing on the ambitious AMCA project to develop the medium-weight deep penetration fighter jet with advanced stealth features to bolster its air power capability. AMCA, along with the Tejas light combat aircraft, is planned to be the mainstay of the Indian Air Force.

After the three companies

submit their responses to the RFP, the selection process for the project is likely to be completed in four to five months.

The selected private defence major will work with the Aeronautical Development Agency (ADA), an entity that operates under the defence ministry, for developing the prototypes of the aircraft.

The contract award is expected to be completed by January-March 2027, with the first prototype flight expected between 2028 and 2032. It may enter service after 2035 with series production at the new facility.

The AMCA is likely to be a single-seat twin-engine jet with advanced stealth coatings and internal weapons bays like those on US and Russian planes - the F-22, F-35, and Su-57. It is expected to have an operational ceiling of 55,000 feet and carry 1,500 kg in weapons in internal bays, with 5,500 kg more externally. The AMCA will likely carry a further 6,500 kg in fuel.

Govt expenditure on health triples to ₹3.85 lakh crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Government expenditure on healthcare has nearly tripled over the last decade to ₹3.85 lakh crore in 2022-23, while out-of-pocket spending by households on treatment has declined significantly, according to the National Health Accounts (NHA) estimates released by the Union Health Ministry on Wednesday.

The report showed that Government health expenditure increased from ₹1.30 lakh crore in 2013-14 to ₹3.85 lakh crore in 2022-23, stating higher public investment in the health sector.

The share of Government health spending in the country's Gross Domestic Product (GDP) rose from 1.15 per cent in 2013-14 to 1.43 per cent in 2022-23. According to the new GDP series with base year 2022-23, the figure stands at 1.48 per cent.

The ministry said the increase in public spending



has contributed to a substantial decline in out-of-pocket expenditure incurred by households on healthcare.

According to the report, out-of-pocket expenditure as a share of total health expenditure fell from 64.2 per cent in 2013-14 to 43.4 per cent in 2022-23, indicating reduced financial burden on people seeking treatment.

The report also highlighted that the share of Government health expenditure in total health expenditure increased from 28.6 per cent in 2013-14 to 43.7 per

cent in 2022-23. "In per capita terms, Government Health Expenditure increased nearly 2.7 times from ₹1,042 in 2013-14 to ₹2,786 in 2022-23," the ministry said in a statement.

The NHA estimates noted that Government spending on healthcare saw a major rise during the COVID-19 pandemic period, with health expenditure reaching 1.84 per cent of GDP in 2021-22 due to emergency response measures, implementation of Emergency COVID Response Packages (ECR-P-I and II) and the nationwide vaccination pro-

gramme. During the pandemic period, out-of-pocket expenditure as a share of total health expenditure declined further to 39.4 per cent, the report said.

The share of Government health expenditure in total health expenditure has increased by almost 15 percentage points, from 28.6 per cent in 2013-14 to 43.7 per cent in 2022-23. This shift underscores the important role of public financing in the health system and signals that policy efforts are moving in the right direction — towards a more affordable, equitable and accessible healthcare system for all, the statement said.

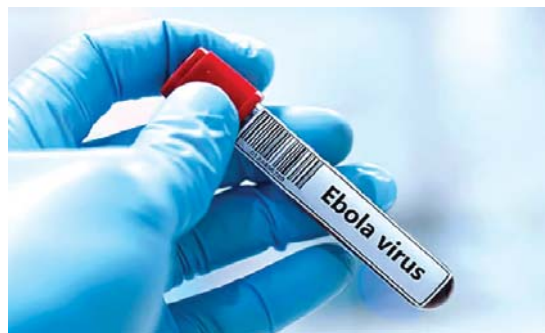
Reducing the burden of out-of-pocket expenditure on households has been a key priority for the Government, pursued through various health schemes and a sustained commitment to Universal Health Coverage (UHC), the statement said.

States Focus



ODISHA: RS BYPOLL ON JUNE 18 AFTER SAMANTARAY'S EXIT

The Election Commission on Wednesday announced that the bypoll to a Rajya Sabha seat from Odisha that has been vacated by Debashish Samantaray will be held on June 18. Samantaray, who was elected to the Rajya Sabha on a BJD ticket in 2024 and was to continue till 2030, resigned both from the membership of the Upper House of Parliament as well as from the party on Monday. He joined the BJP the next day. The poll panel, in a statement, said a formal notification for the by-election will be issued on June 1, and the last date of filing of nominations is June 8. Scrutiny of nomination papers will be held on June 9, and candidates can withdraw their nomination on June 11. "The voting for the lone Rajya Sabha seat will be held between 9 am and 4 pm on June 18 if there is more than one candidate in the fray. The counting of votes will be conducted the same day at 5 pm," an official said. (PTI)



UGANDAN WOMAN SUSPECTED OF EBOLA TESTS NEGATIVE

A 28-year-old woman from Uganda, suspected of showing symptoms of the Ebola virus, has tested negative, Karnataka Minister Dinesh Gundu Rao said on Wednesday. According to officials, the woman, who had arrived from an Ebola-affected region, was moved from a hotel to the state-run Epidemic Diseases Hospital here on Tuesday after she developed mild symptoms such as body aches. Her blood samples were collected and sent to the National Institute of Virology in Pune for testing. The woman was placed in isolation at the hospital for observation and is otherwise in good health, sources said. (PTI)

AIADMK factions patch up after fortnight of rift in TN

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

After remaining divided for about a fortnight, the AIADMK factions patched up on Wednesday, with the rebel camp claiming there was never a split in the party but only "difference of opinion" that saw some MLAs led by the Shanmugam-Velumani duo defying party chief Edappadi K Palaniswami and side with the TVK Government during the confidence vote.

The rebel MLAs led by former State minister SP Velumani called on party chief Palaniswami at his Greenways Road residence here and expressed their support for the AIADMK general secretary, a party source said. However, CV Shanmugam was conspicuous by his absence, but Velumani claimed he was with them.

Shortly after calling on Palaniswami, Velumani met



Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker JCD Prabhakar.

Speaking to reporters, Velumani denied having engineered a split in the AIADMK. Also, he refuted a charge by Palaniswami supporters that his group voted in favour of the TVK Government during its May 13 floor test, aspiring for high positions in the Government.

Earlier, about 13 legislators, including senior leader KC Veeramani, accompanied Velumani. Shanmugam, who was conspicuous by his

absence, had, along with Velumani and other legislators, demanded that the party support the TVK Government.

However, Velumani said Shanmugam was also with them. "We came from Shanmugam's office (before meeting Palaniswami). So, we are all united," he said.

Shortly after meeting the AIADMK chief, Velumani, accompanied by former minister Dr C Vijayabaskar, legislators supporting him, and senior leaders, including Agri SS Krishnamurthy from

the Palaniswami camp, called on Speaker Prabhakar and submitted a letter stating that they would function as one party in the Assembly.

Vijayabaskar withdrew his earlier letter requesting the Speaker to recognise him as party whip.

The Speaker said he would announce his decision on Thursday regarding the letter submitted by the AIADMK members.

"There is no split in the AIADMK, as was projected in the media. There was only a difference of opinion, and it has been set right," Velumani told reporters after meeting the Speaker. He said following the defeat in the April 23 Assembly election, he and others had sought to convene a meeting to review the party's performance and analyse the reasons for the defeat. A section of them took a stand in the Assembly to support the TVK Government.

30 lakh women beneficiaries ineligible: Suwendu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Wednesday said that around 30 lakh beneficiaries of 'Lakshmir Bhandar', a financial assistance scheme for women introduced by the previous TMC Government, were ineligible as they were either non-Indians or their names were permanently deleted from the voter list.

Adhikari introduced a form for the 'Annapurna Bhandar' scheme, as announced by the BJP Government to provide ₹3,000 per month for eligible women in the State. Addressing a press conference at the State administrative headquarters, Nabanna,



Adhikari said "approximately 30 lakh beneficiaries" were receiving Lakshmir Bhandar assistance despite being ineligible as their names had been permanently deleted from the voter list, or they had not applied to a SIR-linked tribunal or for citizenship under the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) for

inclusion. He said that the CAA applicants and those who have appealed to an SIR-linked tribunal after adjudication for entry on the voter list would, however, be eligible for the 'Annapurna Bhandar' scheme. Adhikari said that the BJP had promised in its manifesto to introduce the 'Annapurna

Bhandar', replacing the erstwhile Mamata Banerjee Government's 'Lakshmir Bhandar'.

Under the 'Lakshmir Bhandar' scheme, women in the general category used to get ₹1,500 per month, and ₹1,700 for the SC/ST category.

"Our first notion was that the 'Lakshmir Bhandar' list was verified," Adhikari said.

The chief minister said that his Government introduced a form on Wednesday for filling out by the applicants, while stating that verification of these will be done under the guidance of Women's Welfare Minister Agnimitra Paul and the leadership of the State's chief secretary and the finance secretary.

UPSC RELEASES PRELIMS ANSWER KEY

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) on Wednesday released the provisional answer key for the Civil Services (Preliminary) Examination, 2026.

It is for the first time that the provisional answer key has been released by the Commission after the completion of the preliminary exam.

Candidates can submit their representations, if any, until 6 pm on May 31 through the dedicated online portal, "Online Question Paper Representation Portal (QPREP)", available at upsonline.nic.in, the UPSC said in a statement.



Representations are required to be submitted by indicating the correct answer key according to the candidate's understanding, along with a brief explanation and supporting documents from three authentic sources, it said.

"The release of the provisional answer key reflects UPSC's commitment to greater transparency, fairness and integrity in the examination process while providing candidates an opportunity for informed and constructive participation," the statement said.

The civil services examination is conducted annually by the Commission in three stages — preliminary, main and interview — to select officers of the Indian Administrative Service (IAS), Indian Foreign Service (IFS) and Indian Police Service (IPS), among others.

TMC MLA Dilip Mondal arrested in Puri over provocative remarks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

A TMC MLA from West Bengal's South 24 Parganas district was arrested in Odisha's Puri for his alleged provocative remarks during a victory procession, police said on Wednesday.

Bishnupur MLA Dilip Mondal was reportedly staying at a hotel in Puri when a police team traced and arrested him.

He was being taken to Kolkata on a transit remand, a senior officer said.

The arrest comes days after a video of Mondal went viral on social media, in which he was heard purportedly issuing threats to workers and supporters of West Bengal BJP and making provocative remarks.

According to the allegations, Mondal had said, "For 15 years, I showed a lot of restraint and kept things peaceful. But that will not continue anymore."

He had also allegedly



made a statement invoking Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, saying, "Ask your chief minister who Dilip Mondal is".

The police had initiated a search operation after a complaint was lodged over the remarks allegedly made during a TMC victory rally on May 11. A case was registered against him over charges related to provocation and threatening workers of the opponent party, sources said.

As part of the investigation, the police had earlier conducted searches at two properties linked to Mondal in Pailan, on the southern fringes of Kolkata.

Kakoli Ghosh resigns from all TMC posts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The faultlines within the TMC after its Assembly election drubbing burst further into the open on Wednesday as senior MP Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar quit all organisational posts and launched a political broadside, invoking corruption allegations, the RG Kar row and the growing grip of I-PAC over the party machinery.

The resignation of the four-term Barasat MP — once among the party's most recognisable faces and national president of its women's wing — came barely a day after she attended Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari's administrative review meeting in Kalyani, defying what party sources said was an instruction from the TMC leadership to stay away.

The rapid-fire sequence of events over the last 72 hours has amplified whispers of drift and factional unease within the ruling party, where electoral setbacks are increasingly finding expression through public displays



of discontent. In a letter addressed to TMC State president Subrata Bakshi, Dastidar sought to be relieved of all organisational responsibilities, including her role as chairperson of the All India Trinamool Mahila Congress.

However, Dastidar has not resigned as the Lok Sabha MP from Barasat and continues in Parliament, indicating that her move, at least for now, stops short of a complete political rupture with the party.

But the letter carried the weight of something larger, less a resignation note and more a pointed indictment of the party's internal climate. "My conscience is deeply

disturbed," she wrote, referring to allegations surrounding the ration scam, recruitment irregularities and "financial and administrative improprieties" which, according to her, had generated "anger and distrust" among ordinary people.

An alumnus of RG Kar Medical College, Dastidar also referred to the rape and murder of a doctor at the institution and allegations of an attempted cover-up, saying the episode had "personally shaken" her.

In perhaps her most politically loaded remark, she took a swipe at a fellow TMC MP without naming him, in an apparent reference to Kalyan Banerjee.

Amit Shah orders 360-degree security for border areas

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

In a coordinated effort to enhance border security and promote grassroots development, Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation Amit Shah issued explicit directives during a high-level security review meeting held in Bikaner, Rajasthan, on Wednesday. The meeting underlined the importance of reinforcing border districts between India and Pakistan through a comprehensive 360-degree security framework that involves citizens, State Governments, and security agencies.

Central to these directives is the mandate to fully implement all Government welfare

to access benefits such as housing under the *Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana*, health insurance under *Ayushman Bharat*, financial inclusion via the *Pradhan Mantri Jan-Dhan Yojana*, and agricultural support schemes. The objective is to bridge developmental gaps, improve living standards, and foster security among residents facing unique challenges due to their proximity to international boundaries.

This initiative forms part of a broader strategy to align development with security concerns. Saturation aims to reduce vulnerabilities that could be exploited for infiltration, smuggling, or radicalisation. Enhanced governance through VVP-II will focus on last-mile service delivery,



schemes in border villages, along with the effective utilisation of the national cyber-crime helpline '1930' to address increasing digital threats.

Addressing senior officials from border districts, Shah emphasised the need for result-oriented actions to ensure that no eligible beneficiary in frontier areas is excluded from flagship central and State schemes. These include programmes under the Border Area Development Programme (BADP), the Vibrant Villages Programme (VVP-II), and various social welfare initiatives focused on infrastructure, health, education, and livelihoods. Complete saturation involves engaging every household in border villages

infrastructure development, and economic support to local populations. Shah also called for a detailed study of crime sources, networks, and patterns, particularly regarding drug trafficking, narcotics smuggling, and economic offences, to develop long-term preventive strategies. District authorities have been tasked with ensuring legal and financial compliance among banking institutions, verifying large businesses, and scrutinising funding sources to dismantle mule accounts, counterfeit companies, and forged documents often linked to cross-border crimes.

Equally important is Shah's emphasis on combating cyber-crimes, which have become a contemporary threat.

Monsoon further advances in Arabian Sea, Bay of Bengal: IMD



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The monsoon has missed its expected onset date of May 26 in Kerala but has further advanced into some more parts of the southwest and southeast Arabian Sea, Lakshadweep area and Bay of Bengal, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Wednesday.

The IMD had earlier estimated that the monsoon would arrive in Kerala on May 26 with a model error of ± 4 days.

The monsoon usually sets over Kerala around June 1, marking the beginning of the monsoon season (June to September) in the country.

Last year, the onset of monsoon happened on May 24, according to the department.

J&K celebrates Eid-ul-Azha with prayers for global peace

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jammu

Amid tight security arrangements, Eid-ul-Azha was celebrated across Jammu and Kashmir on Wednesday, with large congregations of Muslims offering prayers at mosques and Eidgahs.

Eid-ul-Azha, which commemorates the devotion and sacrifice of Prophet Ibrahim, was observed with religious spirit across the Union Territory.

The largest congregation was witnessed at the Eidgah on Residency Road in Jammu, followed by significant gatherings at Mecca Masjid Bathindi and Jamia Masjid Talab Khatakan. Devotees in large numbers participated in special prayers held early in the morning.

Following the Eid prayers, worshippers performed the traditional ritual sacrifice of animals, including sheep, goats, and cattle, symbolising faith, devotion, and submission to the will of God.

Religious leaders extended Eid greet-



ings to the people and prayed for peace, well-being, and prosperity across Jammu and Kashmir and the world.

Security forces maintained strict vigilance across sensitive locations to ensure peaceful celebrations.

Sunni Islamic scholar and Shahi Imam of Jamia Masjid Khadike Talab, Mufti Inayatullah Qasmi, extended Eid greetings to the people of Jammu and Kashmir, praying for peace, prosperity, and well-being across the region and the world.

93% of Bihar households now have tap water: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

More than 93 per cent of families in Bihar have been provided with tap water connections, with the number of beneficiary households rising from 2.66 lakh in 2016 to 1.87 crore in 2026, the State Government said on Wednesday.

Addressing a press conference, Public Health Engineering Department (PHED) Minister Sanjay Kumar Singh said tap water connections in left-out hamlets, especially Mahadalit colonies, would be ensured within the next three months.

He said the Government has set a target of covering 2.02 crore families with water connections. Singh said the Government has also taken several measures to deal



with the prevailing heat-wave conditions.

"A total of 475 water tanks and several water ATMs have been deployed to ensure water availability in vulnerable areas. Control rooms are also active in this regard. A total of 1.13 lakh hand pumps were repaired in rural areas during 2025-26," he said.

PHED Principal Secretary Rajesh Kumar admitted that

86,000 hand pumps are still defunct, but said the department was working on a "war footing" to repair those.

Singh said the Government has decided to set up 100 water ATMs in the ongoing fiscal year, which will also be operational during events such as Shravani Mela.

He said the department has also set up an NABL-accredited state-level labora-

tory, 38 district-level laboratories and 75 sub-divisional laboratories for regular water quality testing.

Multi-parameter Field Testing Kits (FTKs) and H2S vials have also been made available at every panchayat level, he added.

"The data so generated is registered on the Centre's Water Quality Management Information System (WQMIS) portal, enabling continuous monitoring and reporting," Singh said.

"The department is also relying on IoT-based real-time monitoring of water availability through the Payjal App," he said.

The minister said the Centralised Grievance Redressal Cell (CGRC) is fully operational to address complaints related to drinking water supply.

Assam Assembly passes UCC Bill

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The Assam Assembly on Wednesday passed the UCC Bill that seeks to put in place a common legal framework to govern marriage, divorce, succession and live-in relationships irrespective of religion, even as the opposition demanded that it be sent to a select committee. With the passage of the proposed legislation, Assam became the third State, after Uttarakhand and Gujarat, to pass a Uniform Civil Code Bill. Goa also has one common civil law, which continued from its erstwhile Portuguese colonial period. After a day-long discussion on the 'The Uniform Civil Code, Assam, 2026 Bill', Speaker Ranjeet Kumar Dass asked Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma to move it for passage. Dass rejected the Opposition's demand that the Bill be sent to a select committee for wider consultation, prompting them to move to the Well of the House and keep on shouting till the Bill was passed. As the opposition did not move the amendments it had raised, the Speaker put

the Bill for voice voting, amid continuous slogans of 'Bharat Mata Ki Jai' and 'Jai Shree Ram ' by the ruling bench. "I declare that the Bill is passed," he said after the ruling members voted in favour of it. As soon as the Bill was passed, it was welcomed by a thunderous applause. Aiming for a common set of laws on a range of personal matters like marriage, divorce, succession and live-in relationships irrespective of religion, the Assam Government had on Monday tabled a Bill on the Uniform Civil Code, seeking to ban polygamy and make registration of live-in relationships compulsory. The Bill, however, said that it will not be applicable to any person belonging to the Scheduled Tribes and residing in Assam. It proposed several punitive measures, including seven years imprisonment for bigamy or polygamy, and three months in jail for not registering a live-in relationship. "There can't be a better start to our five-year tenure than passing the UCC in the first assembly session of our



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma arrives to attend the session of the 16th State Legislative Assembly in Guwahati on Wednesday PTI

new Government. Prices of gas can decrease and increase, but no Government can return the dignity of women if it's lost once. If the BJP had not won this time, lakhs of women wouldn't be able to get the shield of security," Sarma said. Earlier during the discussion on the Bill, he claimed that the Congress was the first to advocate a Uniform Civil Code way back in 1925, and the Opposition party is no longer secular and has become a representative of one particular community. Sarma said the proposed legislation is based on the

foundation of the Constitution's Article 44, not on any BJP or RSS ideology as alleged by the opposition bench. He justified the exclusion of tribals from the ambit of the proposed legislation, claiming that they already have many customary laws for ages on such personal matters. "Tribals don't support polygamy, give equal rights to girls and don't recognise live-in relationships. They, in a way, have been implementing the UCC for ages. Self-regulation is the best regulation. So, we don't want to impose it on the

tribals," Sarma said. "The UCC has a long history. It was first demanded by Congress in 1925. It was also suggested in 1937 by Jawaharlal Nehru. That same Congress is opposing it from the angle of the Quran and Shariat angle, not from the Hindu or Christian or tribal angle," Sarma said. "The Congress is opposing the UCC. Their assembly composition proves that they are not representing all castes, creeds, and religions, but they represent only one specific community. The Congress doesn't represent Assam's geography," he added. The opposition members, on the other hand, termed the Bill on Uniform Civil Code as "BJP's political agenda" and sought wider consultation among all stakeholders before the passage of the proposed legislation. They also said it would hurt the rights of a certain section of society and alleged that bringing in the UCC is a diversionary tactic from the main issues like unemployment, flood and the condition of Government schools, among others.

Rahul alleges OSM contract scam; CBSE denies charges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Wednesday rejected an allegation that it had awarded a contract to Coempt Edutech, saying the claim was "erroneous, misleading and not based on facts." The board said the contract was indeed awarded to Coempt Edutech, but dismissed the allegations against the firm. The response came after Congress leader Rahul Gandhi alleged irregularities in the CBSE's On-Screen Marking (OSM) system and demanded an independent judicial probe and an investigation by a Special Investigation Team (SIT) into the matter. "CBSE rejects the allegations regarding the award of contract to Coempt Edutech. It is erroneous, misleading and not based on facts," the board said in a reply to Rahul on X. It said the contract was awarded after following due procedure under the General Financial Rules. "CBSE has followed the



General Financial Rules protocols scrupulously in the awarding of the contract to the agency. CBSE floated the RFP for Digital Evaluation of Answer books for Board Exams 2026 on the Central Public Procurement portal on August 28, 2025 and awarded the contract to the qualified bidder," the board said. Earlier in the day, Rahul demanded an independent judicial probe as well as an SIT to unearth the truth behind the "entire scam", and asked why a firm that had a murky past in Telangana handed the contract to the Board. Gandhi said CBSE students and their parents are traumatised, but Prime Minister

Narendra Modi "has nothing to say." In a video put out on his social media accounts, Gandhi said unbelievable details are emerging about the Class 12 CBSE exam. "COEMPT, the company that did the On-Screen Marking (OSM) for your exam, was actually called Globarena. Globarena has carried out this scam twice before in Telangana, once in the board exam in Telangana in 2019 and after that again in Telangana in 2023. The same OSM-based errors were responsible for the death by suicide of 23 young Indians in Telangana," the leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha said.

Goa club fire case: ED attaches ₹11 cr property

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi/Panaji

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has attached immovable property valued at ₹11.01 crore in connection with an ongoing investigation into the illegal operation of the "Birch by Romeo Lane" nightclub at Arpora, Goa. A fire at the nightclub in Arpora, Goa, on December 6 last year resulted in the deaths of 25 people, including five tourists. The brothers Saurabh and Gaurav Luthra, who ran the club, had fled India; however, they were traced and detained in Thailand, then deported back to India. The ED has attached properties under the provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002. The federal probing agency began an investigation based on FIRs registered by the Goa Police at Juna Police Station and Mapusa Police Station against Saurabh Luthra and



others under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023. The FIRs relate not only to the major fire incident, which caused the death of 25 persons and injuries to many others, but also to offences involving forgery of documents, including fake and fabricated No Objection Certificates (NOCs) and other statutory documents used for obtaining regulatory approvals. Investigation under PMLA revealed that eGS Hospitality Goa Arpora LLP was operating

the establishment without the necessary statutory approvals, including a Fire NOC. The partners of the establishment had allegedly submitted forged documents, including a fake Health NOC and a fake Police Clearance Certificate, to acquire licences and present the illegal establishment as legitimate. Further investigations revealed that the partners, in collusion, knowingly continued commercial operations despite the expiry of the mandated approvals, which

had expired on 31 March, 2024, and were not renewed; nonetheless, the establishment continued to operate. The investigation also uncovered that the establishment generated a total revenue of approximately Rs 29.78 crore during the period from FY 2023-24 to FY 2025-26, up to 6 December 2025, which is identified as Proceeds of Crime under the provisions of PMLA. Searches conducted on January 23, 2026, at various premises belonging to the entity resulted in the seizure of digital devices and the freezing of bank accounts amounting to approximately ₹59 lakh. Earlier, a Provisional Attachment Order amounting to approximately ₹17.45 crore had been issued in connection with the case. With the latest attachment and freezing, the total amount attached or frozen now stands at approximately ₹29.05 crore, the agency stated.

India's first Rock Check Dam inaugurated in Ladakh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jammu

An innovative Rock Check Dam, the first of its kind in India, aimed at achieving long-term water and agricultural sustainability in Ladakh, was inaugurated by Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena at Upshi in Leh on Wednesday. The Rock Check Dam, built over the River Indus, 44 km from Leh, at an altitude of 11,400 feet, has been conceptualised as an eco-friendly, cost-effective and sustainable remedy to Ladakh's water crisis. This rock check dam has been built using large rocks, sourced from the riverbed and the surroundings, to hold the water in the river. LG Vinai Kumar Saxena has named the project "Sindhu Jal Samriddhi Abhiyan (SJSJA)" that aims at augmenting the water level by creating rock check dams at specific locations of the river, particularly the narrow passages where tapping the river water is relatively easier and more effective. The location of the check dam is identified in consultation with the villagers/locals. The Lieutenant Governor has directed the Irrigation & Flood Control Department to construct three more such check dams



within a month on experiment basis. In many parts of Ladakh, the Indus River becomes too shallow. As a result, standard motors and pumps fail to lift water from the river to the uphill fields. This is where these rock check dams would play a crucial role. These check dams would create a big pondage area storing ample water for use during the peak sowing season. Because the rocks have been sourced directly from the riverbed, there is no use of cement or concrete in the construction of this check dam. This makes it a completely eco-friendly project. The LG said that the Sindhu Jal

Samriddhi Abhiyan would help improve irrigation facilities, strengthen water security and support sustainable agriculture in remote villages. "It is another innovative and eco-friendly project, aimed at achieving long-term water security in Ladakh after the successful launch of Project Him Sarovar. The Rock Check Dam has been conceived as a model of sustainable water and agricultural security, while preserving the fragile ecological character of Ladakh's ecosystem. The initiative has received encouraging response from villagers," LG Saxena said.

Use tech to boost citizen trust: Jitendra Singh to IAS trainees

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Union Minister Jitendra Singh on Wednesday told a group of civil servants that technology must be used not merely for efficiency but also for improving trust between citizens and institutions. Interacting with trainee officers of the 2024 batch of the Indian Administrative Service (IAS), he said modern governance no longer functions through rigid hierar-

chies and one-way communication. Singh, the Minister of State for Personnel, encouraged the officers to remain open-minded learners throughout their careers, saying the ability to adapt, unlearn and evolve is now more valuable than static knowledge. He said the nature of administration has changed significantly in the last decade with greater emphasis on transparency, responsiveness and citizen participation. Referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's philosophy of "maximum governance, minimum



leadership responsibilities and changing public expectations from civil servants. He encouraged them to maintain neutrality, remain accessible to citizens and focus on meaningful public outcomes rather than visibility. Describing India@2047 as a national mission rather than merely a milestone, Singh said the officers of this generation would become the principal drivers of India's rise in the coming decades. He urged them to approach public service with humility, discipline and a larger sense of national purpose.

TNCM Vijay meets PM Modi; raises Mekedatu dam row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi/Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay met Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday and discussed matters concerning the State, including the Mekedatu dam issue, fishermen arrests and the Tamil invocation song row. In addition, Vijay also met Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and handed over a memorandum to prioritise funding for ports, national highways, railway projects and industrial corridors that are crucial for Tamil Nadu's development. This was Vijay's maiden official visit to the national capital after assuming office. His meeting with the PM and Sitharaman comes days after his party TVK secured an upset win in the April 23 Assembly polls, defeating Dravidian heavyweights DMK and AIADMK and forming its Government with the support of allies, including VCK. The CM raised the issue of the Tamil Thai Vazhthu (invo-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi being greeted by Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay during a meeting in New Delhi PTI

cation) song, as a controversy had broken out over the sequence of playing it third — after Vande Mataram and the National anthem in the swearing-in ceremony of his Government, as well as the expansion of his cabinet. In a letter addressed to PM Modi, Vijay said, "At the outset, I wish to affirm that the Government and people of Tamil Nadu hold the National Anthem and the National Song in the highest esteem."

"Tamil Nadu has consistently upheld the dignity and decorum associated with all national symbols and remains deeply committed to the unity, integrity and constitutional values of India. I would also like to bring to your kind notice the long-established position of Tamil Thai Vazhthu in the public life of Tamil Nadu," he said in the letter. For several decades, it has traditionally been rendered at the commencement of

Government, educational, cultural and public functions across Tamil Nadu, and the practice has also been formally recognised by the Tamil Nadu Government, he said. "Following the issuance of the above Ministry of Home Affairs order, Lok Bhavan has adopted the sequence of Vande Mataram, National Anthem and thereafter Tamil Thai Vazhthu. The placement of Tamil Thai Vazhthu subsequent to the National Anthem has led to widespread public concern and opposition from various sections of society in Tamil Nadu, as it departs from the long-standing and officially recognised practice followed in the State." "It is submitted that Tamil Thai Vazhthu occupies a unique position in Tamil Nadu as the State invocation song symbolising the linguistic heritage, cultural identity and collective sentiments of the people of the state. Traditionally, it has always occupied the opening position in official functions as a mark of respect, pride and glory to the Tamil language and culture," the CM added.

Demographic shift not limited to border areas: MHA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The demographic changes due to illegal migration are not limited just to border areas, but their impact has extended, "affecting urban centres, industrial corridors, tribal regions, and other socially and economically sensitive areas," said a Government notification. The notification issued by the Union Ministry of Home Affairs on the constitution of a High-Level Committee on Demographic Changes (HLCDC) under Justice Prakash Prabhakar Naolekar, a retired Supreme Court judge, said "extensive challenges" have arisen from demographic changes due to illegal immigration. Union Home Minister Amit Shah had announced the formation of the committee to assess demographic changes across India



due to "illegal immigration and other unnatural causes". Headquartered in New Delhi, the committee will also include the Census Commissioner, along with retired IAS officer Durga Shankar Mishra, ex-IPS officer Balaji Srivastava and Dr Shamika Ravi as members and will submit its report in a year. "The joint secretary (foreigners-I), Ministry of Home Affairs, will serve as the member secretary of this committee," Shah had said on Tuesday.

Mizoram plans ₹2,289 crore hydropower project on Tuivai river

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Aizawl

The Mizoram Government is planning to set up a 132-mw hydropower project on the Tuivai river in Saitual district near the Manipur border to boost electricity generation amid rising power demand in the State, officials said on Wednesday. Chief Minister Lalduhoma chaired a high-level review meeting to expedite the proposed Tuivai Hydroelectric Project, which is estimated to cost ₹2,289.50 crore and is expected to be completed

within five years. Power Minister F Rodingliana and senior officials of the Power and Electricity Department attended the meeting. The Detailed Project Report (DPR) has been completed, and the proposal is now ready for the tendering process, officials said. The State Government is exploring the implementation of the project under the Public-Private Partnership (PPP) model, they added. According to the 20th Electric Power Survey, Mizoram's peak power demand stands at 182 MW



Chief Minister Lalduhoma

and is projected to rise to around 213 MW by 2030. Although the State has an installed power generation capacity of 50.20 MW, actual

production remains significantly lower, with only around 10 per cent of Mizoram's total electricity requirement currently being

met through local generation, officials said. The State Government spends nearly ₹649.54 crore annually on power purchases, excluding transmission charges, making expansion of local power generation a priority area, they said. The Tuivai Hydroelectric Project was initially surveyed by the Central Water Commission in 1992 with a proposed generation capacity of 210 MW. However, as part of the proposed dam area extended into neighbouring Manipur, the project was redesigned

and re-surveyed. A revised DPR has now been prepared with a reduced generation capacity of 132 MW. The review meeting also decided that the annual financial requirements for implementation of the project would be examined in consultation with the Finance Department. Besides the Tuivai project, the meeting reviewed the progress of the ongoing Tuirini Hydroelectric Project and the implementation of works under the Revamped Distribution Sector Scheme (RDSS).



Editor's
TAKE

The Quad speaks: Is
Beijing listening?

The Quad meet in Delhi was a reminder that the group has a potential to take on China and is a force to reckon with in Indo-Pacific

When the foreign ministers of Quad countries – the United States, India, Japan, and Australia – met in Delhi, they sent a message to the world, – Quad is here to stay and will be proactive in defending the cause it stands for – to keep Indo Pacific free from power play. Some had been declaring the Quad’s demise, pointing to the fact that its national leaders haven’t met since 2024. Critics often question its relevance in a world where ideology and persuasion is waning fast. Yet the very convening of this ministerial – on Indian soil, in the shadow of a recent Trump-Xi summit – proved that the Quad is a potent force. The timing of the New Delhi meeting follows US President Donald Trump’s visit to China and is widely understood as a signal that US engagement with Beijing does not diminish Washington’s commitment to the Indo-Pacific Quad framework. India’s decision to host the meet underscored urgency over protocol. It is no denying that the Quad has always been diplomatically coy about naming its primary concern. The grouping does not describe itself as an anti-China alliance, instead framing its purpose around constructive regional contributions. However, the China variable remains the unspoken organising principle behind nearly every agenda it takes up. This meeting was no different. While the closure of the Strait of Hormuz was on the agenda, the top priority was China.

The agenda was substantive – confirm cooperation in critical minerals and emerging technologies – two domains where China’s dominance poses risks. Supply chain resilience, maritime security in the Indo-Pacific, and the governance of next-generation technologies rounded out the strategic priorities. For Australia, Japan, and India, the task is to continue investing in their national security as the most effective way to ensure Washington that they are powerful in their own right and capable of countering China and do not depend on the United States. This is no small thing. Both India and Japan carry unresolved territorial disputes with Beijing – the Galwan shadow still lingers over the Himalayas, and Chinese vessels continue to test nerves around the Senkaku Islands.

The biggest takeaway of the Delhi meeting was that the US has not abandoned the Indo-Pacific. As part of the summit debrief, the potential sale of US weapons to Taiwan likely featured, and Rubio was expected to receive private support from his Quad colleagues. This is quiet but consequential diplomacy – the kind that is vital for balance of power. The Quad entered 2026 carrying the weight of a full year of Indian chairmanship that concluded without the Leaders’ Summit it was meant to produce – a gap whose strategic cost is real, since prolonged silence carries a reputational cost. It was thus a necessary course correction.

The way forward is clear, if demanding. The Quad must move from signalling to delivery – on critical mineral supply chains, on maritime domain awareness, on semiconductor and AI governance. A Leaders’ Summit must follow. China will not be deterred by meetings alone; it responds to capability, cohesion, and credibility. Quad has the mettle but it must show it.

The Rupee’s real worth: Time for
a new narrative?

India is the world’s third-largest economy. Its currency deserves to be judged by what it builds and buys – not by an exchange rate inherited from history



VIVEK AGGARWAL | SHAH FAESAL

India stands today as the world’s third-largest economy in purchasing power terms, posting growth rates among the highest globally, with record foreign exchange reserves and equity markets at historic highs. Across a world riven by geopolitical conflict, supply-chain fractures, and shifting alliances, India has demonstrated macroeconomic resilience that most nations can only aspire to.

And yet, a curious paradox persists. Every time the rupee moves – from 85 to 87 to 90 against the dollar – headlines speak of “decline”, citizens express alarm, and a narrative of weakness takes hold. This perception is not merely inaccurate. It is damaging to the economic confidence that sustains growth itself.

A civilisation that understood value
long before the \$ existed

India’s monetary culture dates back to ancient times. The subcontinent was minting coins as early as the 6th century BCE, with the silver punch-marked karshapana circulating across the Gangetic plains. When Pliny the Elder wrote in the first century CE that Rome was hemorrhaging fifty million sesterces annually to India for spices, textiles, and precious stones, he was not describing charity - he was describing a trade surplus. Gold coins minted in India were widely trusted for their purity and were used extensively in trade and commerce.

A civilisation with this monetary depth cannot reduce the worth of its currency – or the confidence of its people – to the daily movement of a bilateral exchange rate. The true strength of a currency lies not in how many units equal a dollar, but in the productive capacity, institutional resilience, and civilisational confidence that stand behind it.

The fallacy of exchange rate
absolutism

The fundamental error in public discourse is



LET THE RUPEE BE JUDGED BY WHAT IT BUILDS, WHAT IT BUYS, AND WHAT IT ENABLES FOR A BILLION PEOPLE STRIVING TOWARDS PROSPERITY. THAT IS ITS TRUE VALUE – AND THAT IS THE STORY INDIA MUST HAVE THE CONFIDENCE TO TELL

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treating the nominal exchange rate as an absolute verdict on currency strength.

The Japanese yen trades at roughly 155 to the dollar; the South Korean won at over 1,500. Are these failing economies? Japan is the world’s fourth-largest economy, while South Korea is a technological powerhouse. Exchange rates reflect historical denomination choices and monetary policy - not economic weakness.

What matters is purchasing power within the domestic economy. The World Bank’s International Comparison Program places India’s GDP at approximately \$18 trillion in PPP terms - third globally, behind only the United States and China. One rupee buys considerably more in India than its dollar-equivalent would in America. The Big Mac Index by The Economist is often cited as a popular indicator suggesting that the Indian rupee is undervalued against the US dollar, based on the lower price of McDonald’s burgers in India compared to the United States.

The strategic advantage of a
competitive currency

A rupee that is not artificially strengthened serves a vital function: it maintains export competitiveness. Remittances reached a record \$135.4 billion in FY2024-25. A stronger nominal rupee would reduce the rupee value of these inflows, directly diminishing earnings for millions of families. Export sectors from pharmaceuticals to textiles to software benefit from a competitive exchange rate. This is not an argument for a persistently weaker rupee, but for a currency strategy aligned with India’s own economic

conditions and national interests, ensuring exchange-rate policy serves India-first monetary priorities.

The path forward

Internationalising the rupee through bilateral trade settlement, and advancing the digital rupee through India’s CBDC initiative, offer pathways to reduce dependence on dollar-clearing. Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi’s recent call for Indians to choose made-in-India products, moderate gold imports, and favour domestic tourism is not merely a patriotic appeal – it is sound economic policy. Gold imports are a major drain on foreign exchange; every rupee spent on domestic tourism circulates within the national economy rather than financing outflows.

India holds unparalleled potential in heritage tourism. With 44 UNESCO World Heritage Sites and living traditions spanning millennia, it offers experiences unavailable anywhere else on earth. The recently inscribed ‘Maratha Military Landscapes’ add to a portfolio of globally unique experiences that can strengthen both economic activity and the currency’s underlying domestic demand base.

Atmavishwas as economic policy

For an economy growing at record rates with historically low inflation, the currency exchange rate is a data point, not a destiny. Let the rupee be judged by what it builds, what it buys, and what it enables for a billion people striving towards prosperity. That is its true value – and that is the story India must have the confidence to tell.

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The Arsenal way: Fair play, patience and glory



KUSHAN MITRA

2ND OPINION

I have to credit the arrival of cable television in India for my enduring love and passion for Arsenal Football Club, or ‘The Arsenal’, as some might choose to call it. And the joy that has erupted across the world at this storied football club winning their first English Premier League title in 22 years has been unprecedented.

And it is the sheer spread of the support, from the rich boroughs of London to the slums of Kampala, Uganda, from extreme left-wing politicians like Jeremy Corbyn to right-wing economists like Niall Ferguson, from New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani to Barron Trump. Few national football titles have ever brought so much happiness to so many disparate people.

Even in India, the small cohort of Arsenal fans I associate with share extremely different opinions on politics and



economics. Some work in government, some are top corporate leaders, but we were all sending each other ‘Congratulations’ messages after the club won its title. I feel

some of it was a release, after two decades of sometimes being in the doldrums and sometimes pretending before imploding, or what commentators called ‘bottling it’. This one felt deserved.

And why deserved? Not just because, under their manager Mikel Arteta, they have become an extremely strong team, a physical side that plays well off the ball and is deadly at set-pieces, but because of something else, I feel. Arsenal did not manipulate the books, despite being owned by one of the richest sports empires in the world under Stan and Josh Kroenke. This is unlike the massaging of the Financial Fair Play rules by teams like Chelsea and especially the Abu Dhabi-owned

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Manchester City, although these charges are yet to be resolved. Arsenal played fair, and that will show, as the team will likely close this year with over a billion pounds in revenue, making them one of the most valuable and profitable sports teams in the world.

And that is why fans across the world love Arsenal, because they have played fair. They could have also thrown money at the problem and washed off the sins of an oligarch or oil tycoon. They did not; they played within the rules, they funded their stadium with their own money, and they sold their best players to stay afloat. Many of their current stars, particularly England striker Bukayo Saka, as well as Brazilian striker Gabriel Martinelli, are home-grown talents who rose through the ranks. In fact, the youngest ever EPL winner is 16-year-old schoolboy Max Downman, a rising star of the Arsenal academy brought into the first team. They revived the faltering careers of some, like team captain and Norway midfielder Martin Ødegaard. They spent judiciously; yes, they did spend a lot on England midfielder Declan Rice, a record sum. But this is an organic team like no other in

global football. Many other teams, and indeed even columnists on cultural issues, are just shocked at the level of joy and happiness Arsenal have brought. It certainly made me a very happy person.

The writer is Director and the Printer & Publisher of The Pioneer

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE AMID GLOBAL
UNCERTAINTY AND VOLATILITY

The Nifty 50 continues to face volatility and downward pressure amid escalating geopolitical tensions in the Middle East, a weakening rupee, and elevated crude oil prices. The benchmark index recently slipped below the 24,000 mark due to profit booking and mixed global cues, underlining the importance of informed investing and disciplined money management during uncertain times. Lingering tensions between the US and Iran have heightened concerns over global supply chains and shipping routes. As a result, crude oil prices have remained elevated. Since India is one of the world’s largest oil importers, higher crude prices fuel inflationary pressures and widen the current account deficit.

At the same time, the Indian

rupee has touched fresh lows against the US dollar, making imports more expensive and weakening overall economic sentiment. Global uncertainty, coupled with strong economic data from the US, has also triggered sustained selling by foreign institutional investors, leading to liquidity outflows from Indian markets.

Investor sentiment remains cautious due to fears of prolonged inflation, high borrowing costs, and uncertainty over future interest rate cuts by the Reserve Bank of India and the US Federal Reserve. In such a climate, market participants are advised to closely monitor sector indices, live index movements, and market data through platforms such as NSE India and BSE India.

JAYANTHY CK MANIAM | MUMBAI

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Cockroach Janata Party under legal scanner

The growing popularity of the ‘Cockroach Janata Party’, created by Abhijeet Deepke, has sparked controversy over the alleged manipulation of figures and the commercialisation of serious public issues. In a petition filed before the Supreme Court, Advocate Raja Choudhary has sought an investigation into what he describes as the seemingly unconstitutional activities of the party. According to the petition, the movement has attempted to exploit serious court proceedings by turning them into a “viral spectacle” on social media platforms. While the initiative reportedly began as a satirical response to issues affecting the youth, critics argue that it has gradually transformed discussions on unemployment, public grievances, and political participation into matters of controversy and sensationalism.

Concerns have also been raised regarding the repeated use of references to the judiciary in online campaigns. Legal experts believe that such actions could invite stricter scrutiny from authorities. The matter may even fall within the Central Government’s jurisdiction to examine whether the party’s ‘X’ (formerly Twitter) account poses concerns related to public order or national security.

YUGAL KISHORE SHARMA | FARIDABAD

Pope Leo XIV’s warning on the AI race

Pope Leo XIV’s encyclical raises concerns that go beyond theology. It highlights how corporate giants increasingly shape the development, deployment, and regulation of artificial intelligence. When technological progress moves faster than the wisdom needed to govern it, the benefits are often concentrated among the powerful, while the risks are borne by the wider public. What is needed is not resistance to technology, but stronger accountability. Independent oversight bodies, mandatory transparency from AI developers, and legal frameworks that hold companies responsible for foreseeable harms are essential. Several democracies have already begun taking meaningful steps in this direction.

India, too, stands at a crucial moment where present policy choices will have long-term consequences. A regulatory approach focused only on rapid AI adoption, without addressing concerns such as data governance, algorithmic bias, and labour displacement, may prove short-sighted.

The Pope’s warning is not anti-technology. Rather, it is a reminder that prudence and progress are not opposites – and treating them as such would be a serious mistake.

SM JEEVA | CHENNAI

Legacy of the Saxophone Colossus

The passing of legendary jazz saxophonist Sonny Rollins at the age of 95 marks the end of an extraordinary era in world music. Widely regarded as one of the greatest innovators in jazz history, Rollins transformed the genre through unmatched improvisation, fearless experimentation, and deeply reflective artistry. Iconic albums such as Saxophone Colossus, Tenor Madness, and Freedom Suite inspired generations of musicians across the globe.

His journey reflected humility and the belief that artistic excellence must be accompanied by personal growth and self-discovery. In 1968, he took a break from his successful music career and travelled to Mumbai in search of spiritual understanding and inner peace, which he found in Powai. Among his many honours were the Grammy Lifetime Achievement Award, the National Medal of Arts, and the Kennedy Center Honors for his contribution to American culture. Despite retiring in 2014 due to pulmonary fibrosis, Rollins remained an immortal symbol of creative restlessness and intellectual curiosity.

In an era dominated by fleeting trends, the legacy of Sonny Rollins stands as a reminder that true greatness comes from discipline, courage, and reinvention.

VIDYASAGAR REDDY KETHIRI | KANPUR

Dubare tragedy: The dangerous illusion of ‘tamed’ elephants

The tragedy raises urgent questions about the continued use of captive elephants for tourism, festivals, and processions in the name of tradition, even as shrinking habitats, broken elephant corridors, and rising human interference intensify conflict between humans and wildlife



BK SINGH

This week's tragedy at Dubare elephant camp in Kodagu district, deep inside Karnataka's Western Ghats, questions the decision of the authorities to permit tourists to bathe captive elephants in the flowing waters of the Cauvery river. This camp is located deep within forests dominated by the movement of wild elephants. All captive elephants in this camp were not born in captivity; many were captured from the wild and later tamed in such camps. It is not fair to conclude that tamed elephants have shed all their wild characteristics and fully obey the command and control of their masters - mahouts and kavadis. There have been instances in the past where elephants have killed their masters - mahouts and kavadis. There have also been instances where elephants did not obey the commands of the mahout and ran amok, inflicting casualties and death among crowds.

Captive elephants are often subjected to torture by mahouts using iron ankushes, which can cause bleeding and septicaemia. The footpads of elephants are frequently injured from walking on paved roads. Though camps have treatment facilities under the supervision of veterinary doctors, bleeding from earlobes and footpads is often neglected, and the elephants continue to suffer.

Let me examine in this piece how far we are justified in taking elephants for processions during special occasions and marriages where large crowds gather, and how far we are justified in continuing age-old traditions where tourists are permitted to pour water and rub the elephants' bodies while standing beside them. On several occasions, I have personally failed to convince the Karnataka government not to use captive elephants during Mysuru Dussehra. The argument advanced was: why discontinue traditions?

Captive elephants were extensively used in dragging timber logs across hilly terrain in forestry operations in the past. The Forest Department maintained elephant camps for such operations. However, maintaining these camps was always costly, which restricted their expansion. As forestry operations have now been scaled down and tree felling in hilly terrains prohibited in the interest of conservation, these camps have largely lost their relevance.

Now, bureaucrats and politicians see these camps as permanent centres for training wild elephants that stray out of forests, damage crops and property, and threaten human lives. Earlier, the Karnataka Forest Department carried out khedda operations to capture only a few elephants needed for logging operations. However, with the advent of safer tranquillising techniques, more and more wild elephants are being captured. The department often comes under public pressure to capture elephants straying into villages. The argument advanced is that the elephant population in the wild is increasing due to conservation, and the excess population must therefore be brought into captivity. Wild elephants involved in conflicts, when translocated several hundred kilometres away into another elephant habitat, have often returned to their original homes within weeks, strengthening the argument for bringing such elephants into captivity.

In an era when elephant habitats are continuously fragmenting and shrinking owing to the expansion and widening of linear infrastructure, diversion of forests for mining, industries and development projects, and unauthorised encroachment on forest land, wild animals — especially elephants — are left with little option but to migrate in search of food, shelter, and water, thereby straying into human settlements.

The spread of invasive species and forest fires has also degraded elephant habitats. Palatable plant species and bamboo forests have suffered extensive damage, forcing elephants to move out of forests regularly. Elephant corridors that once provided migratory routes have been occupied by humans. Human settlements and cultivation inside forest pockets have expanded, to the detriment of conservation.

Captive elephant camps like Dubare are them-



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DUBARE CAMP ALSO HAS TOURIST LODGES RUN BY THE STATE-OWNED JUNGLE LODGES AND RESORTS (JLR). ONE OF THE ACTIVITIES OFFERED TO TOURISTS IS BATHING THE CAMP ELEPHANTS, WHILE ANOTHER IS JEEP SAFARIS THROUGH NEARBY FORESTS TO VIEW WILD ANIMALS. IT HAS ALSO BEEN FOUND THAT THE ENTIRE CAMP AND JLR PREMISES LIE WITHIN A CORRIDOR HISTORICALLY USED BY WILD ELEPHANTS

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selves islands of human activity within forests. As part of their daily routine, camp elephants are released into forests during the daytime, where they interact with wild elephants. Fights between captive and wild elephants are reported regularly. There have even been instances where captive elephants were killed by wild tuskers. Aggression is a natural part of elephant behaviour and cannot always be controlled by a mahout's ankush. Sometimes, the animals can surprise us.

About a decade ago in Karnataka's Kalaburagi district, an elephant in a procession kicked its mahout in full public view. The kick was mild and the mahout survived the scare. Feeling insulted, the mahout attempted to attack the elephant with an ankush. The elephant became even angrier and kicked him with such force that he fell nearly 20 feet away and died. Elephants killing their mahouts is not uncommon, and such incidents have been reported from across the country.

Within a herd, stronger elephants are also known to target weaker members. This is what happened at Dubare earlier this week. A tusker attacked a makhna (another male elephant without tusks) while tourists were permitted to bathe the herd. The hostility had likely built up over time, and on that fateful day, the tusker chose to attack the makhna in full view of tourists. The makhna collapsed onto a female tourist bathing it, crushing her to death. The tusker continued attacking the makhna until the mahout managed to calm it down. Despite the best treatment provided at the camp, the makhna died the following day.

Dubare camp also has tourist lodges run by the state-owned Jungle Lodges and Resorts (JLR). One of the activities offered to tourists is bathing the camp elephants, while another is jeep safaris through nearby forests to view wild animals. It has also been found that the entire camp and JLR premises lie within a corridor historically used by wild elephants. Blocking this corridor has disrupted elephant movement and intensified human-elephant conflict.

There are other forest pockets in Kodagu that have been granted for coffee estates. These estates too obstruct elephant corridors. More than 10,000 acres of coffee estate owned by Tata lie within this corridor. The entire estate is fenced, diverting elephants into human settlements and aggravating conflict. Sometimes elephants break through the fencing and enter the estates, threatening workers' lives. Even the narrow roads inside coffee estates are covered by drooping coffee branches on both sides, limiting visibility. Estate management must ensure better visibility and safer movement.

This is a vicious cycle. As wild elephant movement is obstructed, incidents of conflict increase, and every human death places additional pressure on the Forest Department to capture the elephants involved and bring them into captivity. The continued operation of such elephant camps and JLR facilities is not in the interest of conservation.

Such elephant camps should be downsized in a phased manner, and corridors must be restored by removing fencing in Tata Coffee estates and around JLR properties. Tourists should not be allowed near camp elephants, and under no circumstances should close interactions be permitted. Tourist viewing areas should instead be cordoned off, allowing visitors only to observe elephants bathing in the river from a safe distance.

Yogi Adityanath: Calling a spade a spade in politics



YOGESH KUMAR DUBEY

Many a time, I cast my eyes on the Indian political realm as a scholar of English literature. Just as a seasoned English professor can instantly recognise Francis Bacon's measured prose, Shakespeare's poetic style, or George Bernard Shaw's sharp satirical bite from a single sentence, I have grown used to identifying the familiar rhythm of our political leaders' speeches over decades.

That rhythm is predictable: defensive, roundabout, and deliberately evasive. Whether it is Congress, the Samajwadi Party, the BSP, or any other party, the script remains largely the same — "The people will decide", "This is a conspiracy", "Everything will be fine", or "An inquiry will be conducted". The language is soft, safe, and wrapped in layers of political correctness, designed to dilute the question rather than answer it.

Then came Yogi Adityanath in 2017, and the entire tradition of political language was shattered. Yogi introduced a direct, unvarnished, and often blunt style that is rarely heard from the chief ministerial pulpit. He says what he thinks, with minimal embellishment and almost no diplomatic coating. This approach has won him fierce admirers and equally fierce critics.

The most memorable example remains his interview on Aap Ki Adalat with Rajat Sharma. When asked about the death of gangster Mukhtar Ansari, any conventional politician would have taken refuge in standard lines: "The matter is under investigation", "We respect the court", or "We have done nothing wrong". Instead, Yogi replied with characteristic bluntness: "He had to die anyway." He added that a man responsible for many murders cannot escape his fate forever. The sentence instantly became part of political folklore — hailed by some as refreshing candour and condemned by others as insensitive.

This is not an isolated incident. Yogi's entire linguistic pattern stands apart. On the bulldozer action against mafia properties, he repeatedly declared: "The bulldozer will run on mafia properties, not on the huts of the poor." He famously said, "Criminals will either go to jail or meet the Lord." While issuing a 24-hour ultimatum to land mafias, he warned that anyone who grabs the land of the poor would face the bulldozer with no mercy. In the same breath, he added, "We do not perform the aarti of criminals."

Even before becoming Chief Minister, his speeches carried the same sharpness. He once remarked about the Ram Temple, "When no one could stop the disputed structure from being brought down, who will stop the temple from being built?" On cow slaughter and pollution in the Ganga, he asked pointedly whether



animal blood flowing into the river did not count as pollution. On encounters, his standard response has been: "If a criminal fires at the police, the police will certainly retaliate."

These examples illustrate the linguistic revolution Yogi has brought to Indian politics. Traditional leaders weave intricate webs of words; Yogi strikes with them. The results are visible: crime rates in Uttar Pradesh have declined significantly, according to government data; major gangsters like Atiq Ahmed and Mukhtar Ansari have been neutralised; and the mafia ecosystem has been shaken. Infrastructure projects, expressways, and investments have moved forward alongside the bulldozer drive.

Yet this very language has also generated deep controversy and polarisation. Critics argue that it creates fear among minorities, heightens communal tensions, and erodes the courteous traditions of Indian democracy. They see it as majoritarian rhetoric that prioritises strongman imagery over inclusive governance.

I remain conflicted about this change. On the one hand, I admire the rare transparency — finally, a leader who rises above wordplay and speaks plainly. Such candour is uncommon in Indian politics. On the other hand, I worry whether this bluntness is further dividing society.

Yogi Adityanath's no-nonsense, plain-speaking style has redefined Indian politics in a fundamental way. Ordinary citizens love this language because it contains no deception and no false promises. They feel they have finally found a leader who can place a criminal in the dock without looking at caste or religion. Yogi's directness reassures the public that the rule of law is being applied in its true spirit - justice will be the same regardless of the offender's community.

This new idiom has become a model not just for Uttar Pradesh but for national politics. The question is no longer whether political language should be soft or harsh, but whether it is honest and effective. Yogi has proved that the courage to call a spade a spade can itself become a powerful political force.

The author is an Associate Professor at the University of Delhi. He writes regularly on political and social issues

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Great Nicobar: Between strategic destiny and environmental responsibility



KRIPA NAUTIYAL

The renewed controversy surrounding the ₹81,000 crore Great Nicobar holistic development project, triggered by Rahul Gandhi's recent visit to the island, has once again brought into focus a larger national dilemma: how should India balance environmental concerns with strategic imperatives in an increasingly contested Indo-Pacific region? The debate is both necessary and healthy in a democracy. However, what is worrying is the manner in which some sections are attempting to portray the project solely as an ecological disaster while completely ignoring the island's immense strategic and economic significance for India's future maritime posture.

Having spent nearly five years in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands during my service years, I have often wondered why such a strategically located territory — situated near one of the world's most critical maritime chokepoints — remained underutilised for decades. Great Nicobar is not merely another remote island. It is India's southern sentinel at the mouth of the Malacca Strait, through which a substantial portion of global trade and nearly three-fourths of China's energy supplies transit every year. Any nation with long-term strategic vision would naturally seek to develop critical infrastructure in such a location. The proposed

project includes an international container transshipment terminal at Galathea Bay, a dual-use military-civil airport, power infrastructure, and an integrated township. Critics see environmental destruction; strategic thinkers see India finally awakening to maritime realities that regional powers have understood for decades.

One does not have to travel far to witness how geopolitics shapes island development. The Indonesian archipelago, located close to Great Nicobar, has undertaken extensive maritime and infrastructure expansion to secure its strategic interests and economic future. Across Southeast Asia, nations are rapidly building ports, logistics hubs, and surveillance infrastructure to strengthen their position in the Indo-Pacific competition. India cannot afford strategic hesitation while others consolidate influence around us.

This is particularly important in the present geopolitical environment, where maritime competition in the Indian Ocean Region is intensifying. The Andaman and Nicobar Islands provide India with a natural strategic advantage unmatched by any other regional power. To neglect this advantage would be strategically irresponsible.

At the same time, it would be equally irresponsible to dismiss genuine ecological and tribal concerns. Great Nicobar is ecologically fragile, falls in Seismic Zone V, and hosts rare biodiversity, including the endangered leatherback turtle. The Shompen and Nicobarese tribal communities possess unique cultural identities that deserve the highest degree of protection and sensitivity.

I have personally been fortunate to interact with the friendly and dignified Shompen tribals during



several visits to Great Nicobar. Their simplicity, self-sustaining lifestyle, and deep connection with nature leave a lasting impression on any visitor. Development cannot and should not become an excuse for cultural erasure or insensitive displacement. However, it is equally important not to romanticise isolation in a manner that permanently condemns such regions to underdevelopment and strategic irrelevance. History shows that large infrastructure projects inevitably involve some degree of displacement or ecological alteration. The real test of governance lies in how responsibly and humanely these challenges are managed. If rehabilitation becomes necessary, it must follow internationally accepted norms and ensure livelihood security, cultural continuity, healthcare, education, and dignified resettlement. Environmental safeguards too must remain scientific, transparent, and continuously monitored. Development and conservation need not always be opposing forces if approached with accountability. At the same time, opposition to the Great Nicobar project also reflects a larger lack of

strategic vision. In today's world, maritime infrastructure, island territories, logistics hubs, and surveillance systems are central to national security. India cannot afford to remain strategically constrained in the Indo-Pacific region. I am reminded here of a deeply unfortunate episode from my own professional experience concerning Narcondam Island. Based on operational recommendations, the government had approved the installation of a radar system on this strategically located island as part of our maritime domain awareness and static sensor chain.

The proposal had received clearance from the Ministry of Defence because of its immense importance for maritime surveillance. However, in 2012, under pressure from certain environmental groups and NGOs, the proposal was rejected by the Environment Ministry on the grounds that the island's hornbill population might face regenerative issues due to radar installation in a very small corner of the island. Consequently, the radar had to be shifted elsewhere, leading to significant maritime surveillance gaps in a strategically sensitive region.

This episode remains a classic example of how excessive bureaucratic caution and narrowly framed environmental objections can sometimes undermine national security interests. Some experts believe that non-approval of this radar was due to pressure from certain external powers through some voluntary groups. Environmental protection is undoubtedly essential, but strategic blindness can prove equally dangerous.

India today stands at a crucial strategic crossroads. The Indo-Pacific is rapidly emerging as the epicentre of global power competition. China's

maritime expansion, port acquisitions, dual-use infrastructure projects, and naval outreach across the Indian Ocean are no longer speculative concerns; they are visible realities. In such an environment, strengthening the Andaman and Nicobar Islands is not an option but a necessity.

The Great Nicobar project should therefore not be viewed through the simplistic binary of "development versus environment". It must instead be approached as a national mission requiring balance, scientific planning, transparency, environmental sensitivity, and strategic clarity. Constructive criticism is valuable. Alarmism that paralyses national initiatives is not. India's strategic planners must ensure robust ecological safeguards, protect tribal rights, and minimise environmental damage. Yet the nation must also recognise that opportunities of this magnitude are rare, and countries rise by anticipating future geopolitical realities.

Great Nicobar offers India a major opportunity to strengthen maritime security, expand regional influence, generate employment, and project power responsibly in the Indo-Pacific. Debate must continue, but with strategic maturity rather than emotional absolutism. National development, environmental stewardship, and tribal welfare are not mutually exclusive. With political will and careful planning, India can achieve all three together.

The author is a retired Additional Director General of the Indian Coast Guard and has served in the Andaman and Nicobar region for five years in various capacities, including Commander of the entire region

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Delhi HC gives nod to four-way kidney swap transplant

The Delhi High Court has given its nod to a multi-way swap kidney transplant in which four patients with chronic renal disease would receive the organ from each other's close relatives.

Justice Purushendra Kaurav said that the decision of a private hospital's authorisation committee as well as the appellate authority under the Union Health Ministry to reject the proposal was contrary to the intent of the Transplantation of Human Organs and Tissues Act, 1994.

Observing that a restrictive interpretation of the law would defeat its purpose to provide access to life-saving transplants, the court directed the hospital's authorisation committee to expeditiously approve the four-way transplant subject to medical and ethical protocols.

The court passed the order on May 26 on a petition by eight individuals – four recipients and their willing close-relative donors who had positive "cross-match results" that made the swap possible. It was proposed that each donor would give a kidney to a compatible recipient in the chain, enabling all four patients to receive the organ.

The authorisation committee, however, rejected the proposal in February on the grounds of non-exhaustion of near-relative donor evaluation, absence of express statutory provision for multi-pair swaps and the lack of exceptional clinical justification. It was also stated that the possibility of financial inducement cannot be ruled out in such a scenario.

The Appellate Authority also upheld the rejection in April, holding that Section 9(3A) of the Transplantation of Human Organs and Tissues Act only permits two-way swaps. The petitioners, represented by advocates Gayatri Virmani and Disha Gupta, contended that Section 9(3A) was an enabling provision that facilitated swap transplants in cases of biological incompatibility among willing near relatives.

Advocate Sumit Nagpal, who represented the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, sought time to file a response to the petition, saying it concerned a significant issue. The four recipients who belonged to different parts of the country – Delhi, Bihar, Nagaland and Jammu & Kashmir – were suffering from end-stage chronic kidney disease, and the proposed four-way kidney swap transplantation, they claimed, was the only viable option to save their lives. (PTI)



SC seeks Centre, NCERT reply on CBSE's 3-language rule plea

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday agreed to examine a plea challenging a CBSE policy mandating the study of three languages, including at least two native Indian languages, for Class 9 students beginning July 1.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi issued notices to the Centre, CBSE and the NCERT and sought their



replies within two weeks.

According to a recent circular issued by the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), the study of three languages, including at least two native Indian languages, has been made compulsory for Class 9 students beginning July 1.

The move is part of the CBSE's alignment of its scheme of studies with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE) 2023.

Time-stamping on VVPAT slips technical matter in ECI's domain: SC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday left to the Election Commission of India (ECI) to take a decision on a plea seeking a direction to the poll panel to modify VVPAT guidelines so that each slip displays the precise time at which a vote was cast.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi said the PIL for recording the precise time of vote on Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail



(VVPAT) slips for better electoral transparency and verifiability was a technical matter and falls within the ambit of the poll panel.

"It seems that the issue

raised by the petitioner concerns electoral integrity. However, the prayer sought by the petitioner, namely, whether such a measure is feasible, is a technical issue falling within the domain of the EC," the bench said, disposing of the plea.

The bench directed the registry to forward the plea to the EC, which in turn could consider it.

According to the PIL, time-stamping on VVPAT slips would improve transparency, verifiability and auditability of the electoral process.

Collegium recommends 4 HC chief justices, V Mohana as SC judge

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court collegium on Wednesday recommended the elevation of chief justices of four high courts and senior advocate V Mohana as judges of the apex court.

According to a statement uploaded on the top court's website, the collegium, headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, held its meetings on May 22 and May 27.



It has recommended the elevation of Chief Justice of Punjab and Haryana High Court Sheel Nagu, Chief Justice of Bombay High Court Shree Chandrashekhar, Chief

Justice of Madhya Pradesh High Court Sanjeev Sachdeva, Chief Justice of the High Court of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh Arun Palli and Mohana as judges

of the top court.

The apex court presently has 32 judges, including the CJI. Two sitting judges of the top court are set to retire next month.

Delhi HC denies bail to mother-in-law in dowry death case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has refused to grant bail to a mother-in-law in a dowry death case following the death by suicide of her 19-year-old daughter-in-law eight months after the wedding.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma observed that a young life was lost under tragic circumstances and harassment had allegedly reached a stage where the deceased believed that the only escape from the conduct of her husband and in-laws was to take her own life. The deceased was found hanging in her matrimonial home in

November 2024. Her family complained that the husband and the in-laws subjected her to physical and mental harassment for not fulfilling their demand of Rs 3 lakh as dowry. The recording of a call between the deceased and her brother a few hours before she took her life revealed that the husband used abusive and threatening language against her, tore her clothes after a quarrel and threatened to parade her naked on the streets.

Dismissing the bail plea by the mother-in-law on May 25, Justice Sharma said since the forensic report on a conclusive cause of death was still awaited and material witnesses were yet to be exam-



ined before the trial court, releasing the present accused was not in the interest of justice, especially when there was a possibility of influencing the witnesses.

"The present case reflects a disturbing reality of society where, even today, a young

girl aged about 19 years is alleged to have been driven to commit suicide because her parents were unable to fulfil an unlawful demand of Rs 3 lakh allegedly raised by her in-laws, including the present applicant, merely on account of her marriage

into their family," the court observed.

"A young life has been lost under tragic circumstances. The material collected during the investigation, including the audio conversation between the deceased and her brother wherein she is heard crying and narrating the incident of being threatened with being paraded naked, when read together with the allegations of persistent harassment on account of non-fulfilment of dowry demands, lends seriousness to the allegations levelled against the applicant," it further said.

The mother-in-law claimed that the call recording between the deceased

and her brother clearly reflected that she was disturbed because of a quarrel with her husband over an Instagram chat with another girl and not due to any alleged demand for dowry. It was also said that the mother-in-law was neither present at the time of the quarrel nor at the time when the deceased allegedly died by suicide.

Justice Sharma, however, asserted that according to the Supreme Court, in cases involving the alleged dowry death of a young bride within a short span of marriage, courts must exercise greater caution and undertake careful scrutiny of the surrounding circumstances.

SC refuses ex-NCLAT member's plea to practise before tribunal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday refused to entertain a plea filed by former National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) technical member challenging a regulation that prohibits former tribunal members from practising before the National Company Law Tribunal and the NCLAT.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi told petitioner Vijai Pratap Singh that the issue pertains to "independence of



judiciary" and the prayer cannot be allowed.

"You have to think about independence of judiciary. You have been a member of the tribunal. It is a super special tribunal. Imagine you appear before another member who was working when you were there.

SC sets aside NCLAT order which rejected Amazon's appeal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday set aside the NCLAT's June 2022 order which had rejected US e-commerce giant Amazon's appeal against an anti-trust suspension of its investment deal with Future Group.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta also set aside the Competition Commission of India's (CCI) December 17, 2022 order which had levied a ₹202 crore penalty on Amazon and suspended its



deal with Future.

"In view of the findings recorded above, the appeal is allowed. The impugned judgement dated June 13, 2022 passed by the NCLAT and order dated December 17, 2021 passed by the CCI are set

aside," Justice Nath said while pronouncing the verdict.

The top court said if any amount was deposited or recovered from Amazon pursuant to these orders, the same be refunded within eight weeks.

Byju's founder sentenced to jail in Singapore, says order is 'procedural'



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A Singapore court sentenced Byju Raveendran, founder of Byju's, to six months in jail for contempt of court over alleged non-compliance with disclosure orders, but the entrepreneur said the ruling was "procedural" and that he plans to appeal.

The ruling marks the most serious legal setback yet for the founder of Byju's, once one of India's most valuable startups, which has been battling investor disputes, debt litigation and operational turmoil following a sharp post-pandemic downturn.

The court ordered Raveendran to surrender himself to authorities, pay legal costs of Singapore dollar 90,000 (USD 70,500) and

produce documents relating to his ownership of Beear Investco Pte, a Singapore entity that held shares in an affiliated company.

It was not immediately clear whether Raveendran was in Singapore at the time of the order. His lawyers said they are contemplating an appeal against the decision and applying for a stay of the order.

The case was brought by a subsidiary of Qatar Investment Authority, which invested in Byju's during a funding round as the company was grappling with layoffs and mounting financial pressure.

The contempt proceedings add to broader legal battles surrounding Byju's, including ongoing litigation in the United States where lenders are seeking to recover losses tied to a USD 1.2 billion term loan.

Trial in Manipur ethnic violence cases needs to be expedited: SC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday said that the ongoing trial in the 2023 Manipur ethnic violence needs to be expedited and sought a status report from authorities.

Ethnic violence in Manipur broke out on May 3, 2025, after a 'Tribal Solidarity March' was organised in the hill districts. The protest was held against the Meitei community's demand for Scheduled Tribe (ST) status. The violence claimed over 260 lives and left thousands of people displaced.

On Wednesday, a bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi noted that, according to a SIT report, chargesheets had been filed in 207 cases against more than 400 accused.

The bench was hearing a plea of CBI against the grant of bail by the Gauhati High Court to two accused, Arun Khundongbam and Nameirakpam Kiran Meitei, who allegedly gangraped the victims and paraded them naked. "We are of the view



that the ongoing trial needs to be expedited. We have asked the CBI and others to provide legal aid counsel who are well-versed in Manipuri to counsel the victims...The status of the ongoing trial must be filed in the next hearing," it said.

At the outset, the bench said that the matter was to be heard regarding the issue of providing legal aid to victims' families and that it would not interfere with other issues.

Referring to a CBI report, the bench said that 20 chargesheets had been filed and trials had commenced in 16 cases, while, according to the SIT status report, chargesheets had been filed in 207 cases against over 400 accused.

The bench also noted that, according to a report filed by former IPS officer Dattatray Padsalgikar, the law and order situation in the state was "precarious" on April 7 and 18 this year with some incidents of violence and the state police were stressed.

The bench also said that the victims' faith in the system was of key importance and that "confidence-building measures" with them were needed.

On September 8, 2025, the Gauhati High Court granted bail to the two accused on the grounds that they had been in custody for two years while charges were yet to be framed, and termed it to be "unjustified prolonged incarceration".

CJI thanks outgoing SC judges Justices Maheshwari, Mithal for dedicated service

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Wednesday paid a glowing tribute to outgoing Supreme Court judges Justices J K Maheshwari and Pankaj Mithal, and thanked them for their years of dedicated service.

Both Justice Maheshwari and Justice Mithal will retire during the partial court working days (June 1 to July 12) in the apex court.

While Justice Maheshwari

is set to retire on June 28, Justice Mithal will demit office on June 16.

The CJI was speaking at a function organised by the Supreme Court Advocates-on-Record Association (SCAORA) to bid farewell to Justices Maheshwari and Mithal. "They (Justices Maheshwari and Mithal) showed us that authority need not create distance and that high offices need not separate a person from the places and values that shaped him," the CJI said.



"On behalf of my colleagues on the bench, on behalf of the institution, on

SC upholds 28% GST on online gaming with retrospective effect

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday upheld the government's retrospective levy of 28 per cent GST on online gaming companies and observed that such imposition was constitutionally valid.

A bench comprising Justices J B Pardiwala and R Mahadevan said online gaming platforms are not mere intermediaries but are to be treated as suppliers amenable to the Goods and Service Tax (GST) regime on



levies and taxes. "Online gaming activities, including fantasy sports and other games played on digital platforms, involving staking upon uncertain outcomes, constitute betting and gambling for the purpose of GST framework," the bench said.

"The levy of GST on the supply of actionable claims arising from betting and gambling is constitutionally valid and does not transgress Articles 366(12) and 366(12A) of the Constitution," the apex court said in its judgment.

The top court also upheld the validity of laws enacted by the Tamil Nadu and Karnataka governments which banned online games played for stakes, including games of skill such as rummy and poker. GST authorities in October 2023 issued show cause notices to online gaming companies for tax evasion. The government amended the GST law, making it mandatory for overseas online gaming companies to register in India from October 1, 2023 onwards.

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Rise Infraventures FY26 revenue grows 46 per cent

Real estate consultant Rise Infraventures on Wednesday said its revenue rose 46 per cent to ₹120 crore during the 2025-26 fiscal on higher brokerage income from the sale and lease of housing and commercial properties.

The company's revenue stood at ₹82 crore in the 2024-25 financial year.

Established in 2021, Gurugram-based Rise Infraventures facilitates the sale of housing and commercial properties on behalf of real estate developers. It is also into leasing of office and retail spaces.

"We facilitated the sale of properties worth ₹4,840 crore during the 2025-26 fiscal as against ₹3,856 crore in the preceding year," Rise Infraventures founder and CEO Sachin Gawri told reporters here.

He said the Gurugram property market contributed more than 50 per cent to the total value of properties transacted during the last fiscal.

The company has a presence in six cities, including Gurugram, Noida, Bengaluru and Mumbai, with 300 employees.

Gawri said the company would expand its business into more cities in India. It is also looking to enter the Dubai market once the situation stabilises in the West Asia region.

Rise Infraventures has set a target to achieve ₹200 crore revenue this fiscal, he said, adding that the company is also looking at scaling up with more services. On the overall market conditions in Delhi-NCR, he said the demand has stabilised after rising sharply between 2022 and 2025.

Gawri said the housing prices in the primary market (first sale) would not fall despite global uncertainties, rather would rise at a slower pace. (PTI)

US team to visit India from June 1-4 for trade talks

The US team is visiting India from June 1-4 to finalise the details of the interim trade pact and take forward negotiations under the broader bilateral trade agreement on various areas such as market access, non-tariff measures, and customs facilitation, a government official said on Wednesday.

India and the US issued a joint statement on February 7, agreeing on a framework for an interim trade agreement on reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade.

The framework reaffirmed the countries' commitment to the broader India-US bilateral trade agreement (BTA) negotiations.

Following that, the Indian side visited Washington DC on April 20-23, 2026, for an in-person round of meetings with their US counterparts.

"To carry forward the discussions, the US team led by the Chief Negotiator will be visiting India from June 1-4, 2026. It is proposed to finalise the details of the interim agreement and take forward the negotiations under the broader BTA on multiple areas such as market access, non-tariff measures, customs and trade facilitation, investment promotion, economic security alignment," the official said. (PTI)

CCPA acts on illegal online sale of explosives and chemicals on e-commerce platforms

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) has initiated regulatory action against the unauthorised online listing, advertisement, and sale of hazardous chemicals and explosive substances on digital platforms, and issued eight notices to e-commerce entities, the regulator said on Wednesday.

The action was initiated following inputs regarding the online listing and sale of regulated substances on platforms, including IndiaMART, Justdial, Sigma-Aldrich India, Dial4Trade, and ExportersIndia.

The notices seek details on seller information and licensing compliance, buyer verification mechanisms, quantities sold, import details, and applicable regulatory approvals.

Substances flagged include ammonium nitrate, gun

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | MAY 28, 2026

ONGC bets on gas-led growth as premium prices lift profit

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

State-run oil and gas producer ONGC said it expects natural gas to become an increasingly dominant and profitable part of its business as new high-priced gas production ramps up and domestic demand continues to rise.

Speaking at an investor call, ONGC chairman and CEO Arun Kumar Singh said the company now produces and sells more gas than oil, with gas contributing higher earnings because of favourable pricing reforms and lower handling costs.

"New well gas" production from newly drilled wells that

receive pricing linked to 12 per cent of crude oil prices - accounted for roughly 20 per cent of gas volumes last year and is expected to rise to 25-30 per cent this year before climbing further over the next few years.

"At crude prices of around USD 90 a barrel, new well gas realises nearly USD 10.8 per million British thermal unit in the domestic market," he said, adding that India was among the highest-paying gas markets globally for such production.

The company said older gas fields priced at lower administered rates were gradually being replaced by higher-priced output from new wells, improving overall

profitability. ONGC expects gas production growth of 7-8 per cent annually, driven by projects including the Daman field development project, the DSG block and ramp-up at the KG-98/2 deepwater block. Singh said four wells under

the Daman project had already been opened, with total gas production expected to rise progressively as additional wells come online.

ONGC, he said, was executing projects worth about Rs 33,000 crore in western off-

shore fields aimed at sustaining and increasing production. Western offshore assets account for around 60 per cent of ONGC's oil production and 70 per cent of gas output.

It has recently expanded its partnership with BP plc for production enhancement projects across western offshore assets, after earlier assigning Mumbai High redevelopment work to the company.

Singh said production at the company's KG-98/2 block in the Bay of Bengal had faced geological challenges but added that it now had "full handle" on the issues and expected output stabilisation measures to improve performance.

ONGC also highlighted improving prospects at its overseas unit, ONGC Videsh Ltd (OVL).

The company said production from Russia's Sakhalin project had recovered to near pre-Ukraine-war levels, while Mozambique LNG development was progressing rapidly, with first LNG targeted around 2028.

It also expects higher output from Venezuela operations under the current US administration, subject to licensing approvals.

Beyond hydrocarbons, ONGC said its renewable energy portfolio was nearing 3 gigawatts through acquisitions and ongoing expansion under ONGC Green Ltd.

Rupee rises 2 paise to 95.68 against USD

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee settled on a flat note, higher by 2 paise at 95.68 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday, as renewed tensions between the US and Iran and delays in negotiations kept investors cautious.

Forex traders said a strong American currency and weak domestic markets also pressured the rupee. Attention has shifted toward the upcoming RBI Monetary Policy Committee meeting scheduled between June 3 and 5,

they said. At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.60 against the US dollar, and touched an intra-day low of 95.79 against the American currency.

At the end of Wednesday's close, the rupee was quoted at 95.68 (provisional), down 2 paise from its previous closing. On Tuesday, the rupee depreciated 44 paise to close at 95.70 against the US dollar.

"We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias on renewed tensions between the US and Iran and concerns over military action in the Middle East.

India toll growth to ease 5-7% on West Asia conflict: Crisil

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's toll collection growth is likely to moderate to 5-7 per cent in the current fiscal as the West Asia conflict and geopolitical uncertainties are weighing on freight movement and industrial activity, rating agency Crisil said on Wednesday.

According to Crisil, the percolating economic impact of the West Asia conflict and a consequent deceleration in commercial traffic is likely to result in an on-year moderation in toll collection by 150-200 basis points (bps) this fiscal.

Crisil noted that the marginal underperformance is temporary and is likely to be recouped next fiscal, due to relatively higher toll rate hikes compelled by inflationary pressures.

To be sure, the rating agency said the toll rate hike in a fiscal year is based on the Wholesale Price Index (WPI) inflation of the previous year.

This underscores the resilience of toll road assets through economic cycles. Healthy operating performance and controlled leverage should keep the credit profiles of toll road operators stable, it said.

Crisil Ratings deputy chief ratings officer Manish Gupta said, "traffic growth, a function of economic expansion, is estimated at 2-4 per cent in the near term. The modest WPI inflation of last year will limit toll rate hikes this fiscal year, and consequently, toll collection will grow 5-7 per cent."

However, next fiscal toll rates may see a steeper increase due to higher WPI

inflation, expected this fiscal amid the West Asia conflict. This will drive toll collection growth to 8-10 per cent next fiscal, Gupta added.

According to the rating agency, commercial traffic remains the backbone of toll collection, typically contributing 75 per cent.

Freight movement is closely linked to industrial output, construction activity

and mining, which may be impacted amid the West Asia conflict — as reflected in sequential degrowth in fastag toll collections in March and April.

Crisil said that significant weakening in the macro-economic environment amid the West Asia conflict, particularly affecting commercial traffic, will warrant close monitoring.

MFI portfolio dips 9% in April on pvt banks' cautious stance: Report

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The microfinance industry's outstanding portfolio declined by 9 per cent in the year to April 2026 due to heightened caution among private banks, a credit information company said on Wednesday.

In what can bring some cheer to the industry battling a host of challenges on asset quality for over a year, assets unpaid for over 30 days declined to 2.5 per cent in April 2026 from 6.4 per cent in the year-age period.

The report by Equifax said the overall portfolio declined 9 per cent to ₹3.34 lakh crore in April.

The number of active loans

moderated sharply by 21 per cent to 10.28 crore, indicating a preference for lending larger amounts in the industry. The non-bank lenders showed a better asset-quality trend, and the same cohort also witnessed industry-beating performance on loan outstandings, which were down by 4 per cent in the

period, the report said.

The market share of NBFC-MFIs grew to 43 per cent from 39 per cent in the year-age period and the same for NBFCs grew to 14 per cent from 12 per cent.

Small finance banks maintained their 15 per cent market share during the same period, it said.

Stock markets decline for 2nd day on selling in energy, banking shares; Sensex down 142 points

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty closed lower in a volatile trade on Wednesday as investors remained cautious amid conflicting geopolitical signals from the West Asia and fresh foreign fund outflows.

The 30-share BSE Sensex declined 141.90 points, or 0.19 per cent, to settle at 75,867.80, with 20 of its constituents ending higher and 10 with losses. During the day, it hit a high of 76,224.68 and a low of 75,748.21, gyrating 476.47 points.

The 50-share NSE Nifty skidded 6.55 points to end at 23,907.15. Among 30 Sensex firms, HDFC Bank, Infosys, ITC,

Hindustan Unilever, Reliance Industries and ICICI Bank were the major laggards.

Power Grid, Eternal, NTPC and Tata Steel were the major gainers. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark,

dropped 3.24 per cent to USD 96.35 per barrel. Indian equity markets ended largely subdued as investors adopted a wait-and-watch approach amid conflicting geopolitical signals from the Middle East.

Tax relief, import curbs can shield India from war crisis: Report

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India needs to undertake measures such as tax moderation to boost export competitiveness, targeted import curbs on non-essential and demerit goods, and time-bound enforcement of trade-remedy measures to shield itself from the impact of the West Asia crisis, a report said.

The global economic landscape faces a profound stress test and geopolitical volatility in West Asia is driving structural cost-push inflation across essential sectors — energy, agriculture, and manufacturing, according to a report by Think Change Forum.

"The traditional fiscal response — relying on open-

ended subsidies to buffer these shocks — is no longer sustainable. It creates a moral hazard by shielding firms from global volatility through perpetual subsidies, the policy disincentivises the structural efficiency and vertical integration necessary for global competitiveness," it said.

This report proposes a strategic pivot — replacing blunt subsidy-led interventions with a precise, three-pillar framework of structural tax moderation and defensive trade alignment.

By dismantling inverted duty structures, calibrating tariffs dynamically, and restricting non-merit luxury

imports, India can secure its domestic industrial base while maintaining fiscal discipline, it said, adding that this is a transition from reactive relief to proactive macro-economic fortification.

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi recently emphasised, it said, reducing the import of non-essential goods is no longer an austerity measure — it is a cornerstone of national security and foreign exchange resilience.

India's merchandise imports touched USD 774.98 billion in 2025-26 against exports of USD 441.78 billion, creating a trade deficit exceeding USD 333 billion, as per the data released by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry.

Israeli forces kill new Hamas leader in Gaza

WAFAA SHURAF/ MELANIE LIDMAN ■ Deir Al-Balah

Israel said on Wednesday that it targeted and killed the new leader of Hamas' military wing during airstrikes in Gaza City less than two weeks after it killed his predecessor.

Israel's Defence Minister Israel Katz and the Israeli military said the strikes, which were carried out on Tuesday, killed Mohammed Odeh.

Family members of a man called Mohammed Odeh said he was killed in the strike, but did not confirm he was the leader of the military wing. Hamas has not commented. Katz called him "one of the architects" of the



October 7, 2023, attacks that triggered over two years of war in Gaza and said it was the fourth time Israel has killed the head of Hamas' military wing since that massacre. Izz al-Din al-Haddad, the previous head, was killed on May 16. At least three

people were killed and 12 injured in Tuesday's strike, which took place on the eve of Eid al-Adha, a major Muslim holiday.

"We pledged to eliminate everyone who led the October 7 massacre and this is what we will do: they are

all bound to die, everywhere," Katz wrote on X on Wednesday. "We pledged that Hamas will not hold civilian or military rule."

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who is preparing for elections in the fall, also threatened that Israel will target everyone involved in the October 7, 2023, attack.

A grim Eid in Gaza

The attack came as Muslims prepared for Eid al-Adha, normally a joyous time of family gatherings and large meals.

The holiday once again is subdued this year in Gaza, where the vast majority of people remain displaced and live in tents or temporary shelters after a devastating

war. Around 90 per cent of Gaza's more than 2 million people have lost their homes, according to UN estimates, with most of them now sheltering in huge tent camps with rat infestations and pools of sewage. They are dependent on aid to survive.

Eid al-Adha, or "Feast of Sacrifice," is an Islamic holiday celebrated by millions of Muslims across the globe. The four-day holiday, which begins during the Hajj pilgrimage, is also known for being a joyous occasion during which families gather, and children are given new clothes and gifts.

"This is not Eid ... we're dead," said Mahmoud Sager, a displaced man from Khan

Younis, who described people as being distressed by the ongoing human suffering and killings in the territory.

In Khan Younis and Gaza City, amid destroyed buildings, including a ruined mosque, people gathered for Eid prayers with few signs of celebration beyond a few clusters of balloons lining one street. Tahrir al-Khatib said the joy that accompanies Eid has been silenced in Gaza. "There's no Eid.

My children were killed. Eid is only for the people who lost no one," said Ayda Al-Banna, a displaced woman from Gaza , who prayed Eid Fragile ceasefire holds in Gaza A ceasefire reached between Israel and Hamas last October remains fragile. (AP)

Climate change major challenge for Himalayas: Nepal President



SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Sustainable tourism, responsible mountaineering and conservation of the Himalayan environment are the defining challenges of the day, Nepal's President Ramchandra Paudel said on Wednesday. Addressing the 'Everest Summiters Summit - 2026' organised in Kathmandu, Paudel said Mount Everest was not only a geographical identity of Nepal but also the pride, prestige and an invaluable natural heritage of the country. "The country's economy has benefitted from the tourism sector through the conservation, promotion, publicity and balanced use of these assets," he said.

Paudel stated that global warming, the impacts of climate change and the

accumulation of garbage in mountaineering areas have emerged as major challenges of the modern world.

"Addressing these issues and conserving the environment and biodiversity in the Everest region, while making mountaineering safe, sustainable and technology-friendly, requires additional efforts and cooperation from all sides," he said. He pointed out that conservation, promotion and balanced utilisation of Himalayan resources directly support Nepal's tourism industry and broader economic development.

Mukunda Prasad Niraula, secretary of the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, also expressed concerns about climate change and its impact on Mount Everest and other mountains of Nepal. (PTI)

5 found alive in flooded Laos cave; 2 still missing

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bangkok

Five villagers stuck in a flooded cave in central Laos for more than a week were found alive, rescuers said Wednesday, but two others are missing.

The villagers entered the cave in Xaisomboun province on May 19, but heavy rain triggered flash flooding that blocked the exit and trapped seven people, according to Lao and Thai rescue teams involved in the operation.

Bounkham Luanglath of the Lao organisation Rescue Volunteer for People, which has been working closely with local authorities in the rescue efforts, told said that



Metta Tham Rescue Kalasin, a rescuer is seen after removing people who have been trapped in a cave in Xaisomboun province, Laos

AP

five people were found safe and alive, but two more are still missing, and the search for them will continue.

"I'm still shaking. Our team made it happen," he said in a voice message. A video posted by a Thai rescue group involved in the mission appeared to show the moment divers emerged from the water and discovered the trapped villagers.

In the footage, the villagers, each wearing a headlamp, were sitting on a rock surrounded by floodwater. Other videos showed rescuers inside and outside the cave cheering, jumping around and hugging each other in joy after the discovery. Rescue workers from

neighbouring Thailand arrived at the site over the weekend.

The cave is located in a rugged, remote area in Xaisomboun province's in Vientiane.

Rescuers at the scene have detailed on social media the challenging mountainous terrain and heavy rain that have hampered their work.

Videos shared online by Thai rescuers showed that reaching the cave's entrance requires a steep hike of roughly 4 kilometres . The entrance is also steep and rocky, and barely wide enough for a single person at a time to climb through.

Spanish police raid PM Sanchez's party headquarters



JOSEPH WILSON ■ Barcelona (Spain)

Spanish police are searching the headquarters of the ruling Socialist Party as part of an ongoing investigation into possible financial wrongdoing, the Civil Guard said Wednesday.

The raid on the office in central Madrid is another blow to the party of Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez, whose Socialists have been hammered by a series of corruption scandals.

Hungary's parliament votes to remain member of ICC

JUSTIN SPIKE/ MOLLY QUELL ■ Budapest

Hungary's parliament voted on Wednesday to remain a member of the International Criminal Court (ICC), reversing a decision by the previous Government of Viktor Orban to withdraw from the global tribunal.

Orban's Government announced last year that Hungary would quit the ICC, the world's only permanent global court for war crimes and genocide, shortly after a state visit by Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu which went ahead despite an ICC warrant for his arrest over alleged war crimes in connection with Israel's war in the Gaza Strip. The ICC and other international organizations criticized Orban's Government for failing to detain Netanyahu. Orban accused the ICC of becoming a "political court."

Hungary's withdrawal has been set to take effect on June 2. The bill to reverse the decision, which was sub-

mitted on Monday by Prime Minister Peter Magyar, states that in order to maintain international peace and protect human rights "it is essential that those who commit the most serious international crimes be held accountable before an international judicial forum." It adds: "To this end, it is necessary to maintain Hungary's

participation in the Statute of the International Criminal Court."

The bill was passed largely along party lines, with 133 lawmakers from Magyar's ruling Fidesz party voting to approve, 37 votes against and five abstentions. The ICC's oversight body, the Assembly of States Parties, welcomed

Hungary's return. In a statement on Monday in anticipation of the vote, the organi-

zation said it "congratulates the Government of Hungary for this important decision."

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

The Chief Engineer/Const./RSP/NR, 901 B, Tower-I, 9th Floor, Konnectus Tower, DMRC Building, Ajmeri Gate, New Delhi-110002 for and on behalf of the President of India invites e-tender under Two Packet System for the under noted work:-

1

Full name of work : Construction of 3 ROB's (i) 2 Lane ROB in Lieu of Level crossing No. 60-C at Km 71/11-12 between Bhatratgarh-Kiratpur Sahib Railway Stations on SIR-DLPC Section of Ambala Division, (ii) 2 Lane ROB in Lieu of Level crossing No. S-78 (including LHS) at Km.410/23-25 on SLN-JUC Section of Firozpur Division and (iii) 2 Lane ROB in Lieu of Level crossing No. C-32 at KM 38/13-15 Nabha and Dhablan Stations on Ambala-Bathinda Section of Ambala Division of Northern Railway under the Road Safety Projects Unit (RSPU)/NR New Delhi.

2

Approx. Cost of work : Rs. 1,39,53,49,690.05/- Rupees Only (One Hundred Thirty-Nine Crore Fifty-Three Lakh Forty-Nine Thousand Six Hundred Ninety and Five Paise Only)

3

Completion period of the work : 18 months Period

4

Earnest Money to be deposited : Rs. 2,79,07,000.00/- Rupees only (Two Crore Seventy-Nine Lakh Seven Thousand Only)

5

Sale/availability of tender document on Rty. Website : Tender document will be available on IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in from 27.05.2026 to 23.06.2026.

6

Last date/Time of upload of tenders : Tender documents can be uploaded on IREPS website upto 23.06.2026, 11:30 hrs.

7

Date and time of opening of tender : Any time after 23.06.2026, 11:30 hours

8

Pre bid Conference : Date: 03.06.2026 Time: 11:30 Hrs. To 12:30 Hrs. Venue: Office of CAO/IRSP 9th Floor, Konnectus Tower, DMRC Building, Ajmeri Gate, New Delhi- 110002 and through online VC link (uploaded on IREPS).

No.: 24-W-09-2026-WA-DYCE-C-RSP

Dated: 27.05.2026

1805/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

M.P. BUILDING DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION

(An Agency of Govt. of M.P. Public Works Department)

16-A, CEDMAP Building, A.R.A. Hills, Bhopal (M.P.)-462011

Telephone No. : 0755-4853297, 0755-4853295

E-mail : einc-mpbdc@mp.gov.in, dgmhmpbdc@gmail.com

NIT No. : 4388/GM/MPBDC/CW/26/NIT-82/ Part-2

Bhopal, Dated : 27.05.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Madhya Pradesh Building Development Corporation Limited (MPBDC) Bhopal invites online tenders for the following works :-

1. Construction of 150 bedded Boys Hostel at Adhartal Dist. Jabalpur M.P. PAC : Rs. 952.31 Lakhs

2. Renovation Upgradation and New Construction work at Govt. P.G. College Dist. Seoni M.P. (2nd Call) PAC : Rs. 850.74 Lakhs

3. Construction of 50 bedded Boys and 50 bedded Girls Hostel at Sandipani School at Sagar Mandla Dist. Mandla M.P. (2nd Call) PAC : Rs. 367.76 Lakhs

4. Construction of Sports complex at Dist. Neemuch M.P. PAC : Rs. 530.61 Lakhs

5. Construction of Hockey Synthetic Turf ground at Mandideep Dist. Raisen M.P. PAC : Rs. 502.86 Lakhs

6. Integrated Sports Complex at Banda Dist. Sagar M.P. PAC : Rs. 634.79 Lakhs

7. Construction of Integrated Sports Complex at Dist. Chhindwara M.P. PAC : Rs. 607.61 Lakhs

8. Construction of sports stadium at bagh, Dist. Dhar M.P. PAC : Rs. 565.23 Lakhs

9. Construction of Integrated sports Complex at Dist. Alirajpur M.P. PAC : Rs. 534.857 Lakhs

10. Construction of Integrated Sports Complex at Dist. Mandla M.P. PAC : Rs. 534.85 Lakhs

11. Construction of Integrated Sports Complex and Synthetic Athletic Track at Dist. Mandsaur M.P. PAC : Rs. 479.69 Lakhs

12. Construction of Integrated Sports Complex and synthetic athletic track at Rajiv Gandhi Khel Parisar Dist. Bhind M.P. PAC : Rs. 479.69 Lakhs

13. Construction of Integrated Sports Complex at Hatta Dist. Damoh M.P. PAC : Rs. 431.72 Lakhs

14. Sports Complex at Batiyagarh Dist. Damoh M.P. PAC : Rs. 352.57 Lakhs

15. Construction of Boundary wall of Madhya Pradesh State Shooting Academy, Bhopal PAC : Rs. 350.97 Lakhs

16. Construction work of Indoor and Outdoor Sports Complex in Rajendra Nagar Ward No. 37, Bhopal. PAC : Rs. 265.43 Lakhs

17. Construction of Sports complex at Kolaras Dist. Shivpuri M.P. PAC : Rs. 237.44 Lakhs

18. Construction of Hockey Synthetic Turf at Dist. Umaria M.P. PAC : Rs. 479.69 Lakhs

19. Construction of boundary wall shed of Madhya Pradesh State Horse Riding Academy, Bhopal PAC : Rs. 103.93 Lakhs

20. Contract for Comprehensive Housekeeping & Sanitation Services (Two Shifts) : 08:00 AM to 04:00 PM and 02:00 PM to 10:00 PM) including Supply of Cleaning Materials and Machinery for a period of Two (02) Years. PAC : Rs. 32.98 Lakhs (NIT No. : 2879/GM/MPBDC/CW&MISC/26/NIT-80 Bhopal, Dated: 04.04.2026)

21. Photo Copy and Spiral Binding works. PAC : Rs. 13.91 Lakhs (NIT No. : 2879/GM/MPBDC/CW&MISC/26/NIT-80 Bhopal, Dated : 04.04.2026)

22. Providing, placing, installation and erection of furniture, AV system etc. for New Medical College and 500 bedded Hospital at Budni District Sehore. PAC : Rs. 1,324.54 Lakhs (NIT-82 : 3320/GM/MPBDC/CW/26/NIT-82 (PART-1) Bhopal, Dated : 17.04.2026)

Detailed NIT and tender documents can be viewed, downloaded and purchased online for from 01.06.2026 at 18:00 hrs. to 22.06.2026 at 15:30 hrs. for S.No.-01 to 05), 03.06.2026 at 18:00 hrs. to 24.06.2026 at 15:30 hrs. for (S.No.-06 to 19), 01.06.2026 at 18:00 hrs. to 16.06.2026 at 15:30 hrs. for (S.No.-20 to S.No.-21), 26.05.2026 at 18:00 hrs. to 16.06.2026 at 15:30 hrs. for (S.No.-22) from website www.mptenders.gov.in. PAC can vary at the time of uploading of tender document. Any amendment/corrigendum 'if any' will be published on website only, will not be published on newspapers.

M.P. Madhyam/126074/2026

MANAGING DIRECTOR

JASCH INDUSTRIES LIMITED

Regd Office: 502, NDM-II, NSP, Pitampura, Delhi – 110034

CIN: L24302DL1985PLC383771

Email: eskavee@gmail.com; Tel: 0130-2216666

Audited Ind AS Financial Results for the Quarter and Financial Year ended on 31st March 2026

The Board of Directors of the Company, in its meeting held on 26-05-2026, have approved the above financial results of the Company which, along with audit report, have been posted on the Company's website under the link https://www.jaschindustries.com/financial_results?id=4 and can also be accessed by scanning this QR code.

Place: Sonipat

Date: 26.05.2026

Note: The above intimation is in accordance with Regulation 33 read with Regulation 47(1) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations & Disclosure Requirements) Regulations 2015.

Jai Kishan Garg

Chairman

RAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Bhakta Mata Karma Complex, New Rajendra Nagar, RAIPUR (Chhattisgarh) 492006

Website : <https://rda.cgstate.gov.in>, Email : ceordaryp@gmail.com, Fax : 0771-2536188

NIT No. 10

Notice Inviting Tender

Dated : 26.05.2026

Online Bids are invited for the following of works upto 17.06.2026 at 3:00 PM

Sr. No.	System Tender No.	Name of work/Description of work	Type of Contract	Tender Amount	EMD Amount	Time Period	Tender Fee+ Processing Fee
1	191693	Construction of New RCC Drain in place of Existing Drainage System at Dr. Shyama Prasad Mukherjee Awas Yojana situated at Boriya Khurd, Raipur	Percentage Rate Basis in "Form-A"	Rs. 65,34,550/- (Excl GST)	Rs. 65,345/-	03 Months from reckoned date	Rs.10,000/- including GST + Rs. 311/- (Non Refundable) to be paid online

The details can be viewed and downloaded online directly from the Government of Chhattisgarh e-procurement portal <https://eprocg.state.gov.in>. More details of the tender and bidding process may be obtained from the above-mentioned portal.

NOTE : (1) All eligible/interested contractors are mandated to get enrolled on e-procurement portal. (2) Contractors can contact help desk for any clarification of their doubt regarding the process of electronic procurement system. Help Desk at Toll Free No. 1800-233-7188 or through Email ID ceordaryp@gmail.com, ceordaryp@gmail.com. Website : <https://rda.cgstate.gov.in>. (3) For more details, please download NIT details.

Executive Engineer

SANEH INDUSTRIAL INVESTMENTS LIMITED

Regd. Office: Delton House, 4801, Bharat Ram Road, 24, Daryaganj, New Delhi – 110002

CIN: L74899DL1980PL060079

Website: <https://saneh.in/>, E-mail: saneh1td@gmail.com Tel: 011-45795859

Audited Financial Results (Standalone & Consolidated) for the Quarter and Financial Year Ended March 31, 2026

The Board of Directors of the Company, at its meeting held on Wednesday, May 27, 2026, approved the Audited Financial Results (Standalone & Consolidated) of the Company for the quarter and financial year ended March 31, 2026 as per Regulation 33 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. In compliance with the Regulation 47 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 (as amended from time to time), the aforesaid Results are now being made available through Quick Response Code ("QR Code")

The results along with the Auditor's Reports thereon, are available on the website of the Company at <https://saneh.in/disclosures-under-regulation-46-of-sebi/quarterly-results/> and on the website of the stock exchange i.e. Calcutta Stock Exchange Limited at <https://www.cse-india.com/> respectively. The results can also be accessed by scanning the QR Code.

For and on Behalf of

Saneh Industrial Investments Limited

Sd/-

Vivek Gupta

Director

DIN: 00335916

Place: Delhi

Date: May 27, 2026

NEW OKHLA INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida G.B. Nagar, (UP)

Website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tender are invited from firms/contractors registered with UPLC Lucknow for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on NOIDA Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <http://etender.up.nic.in> Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.

(A)

1. 09/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27, Providing GI Octagonal Poles (replacement of old Rusted & Damage poles) on FNG Main Road Sector-140 to 141, Noida. Cost Rs. 79.76 Lacs.

2. 16/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27, Annual Maintenance and Repairing of 16Mtr./30Mtr. High mast in sector-80, 81, 83, 84, 85, 86, 87, 88, 89, 90, 145, 146, 147 and 148, Noida. Cost Rs. 48.89 Lacs.

3. 17/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27, Strengthening and Annual Maintenance of Internal Electrical works of 11 Nos. community centers With Govt. Primary School, Junior High School in Sectors- 82, 92, 93Super MIG, 93B, 105, 108, 110 and Villages - Gejha Tilpatbad & Hazipur), Noida. Cost Rs. 35.16 Lacs.

4. 18/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27, Providing Temporary Lighting Arrangement Different Occasion & Festival (Republic Day, Holi, Kavad Yatra, Independence Day, Chhatt Pooja, Diwali) and Providing LED Strip Light in area. of E/M-I, Noida. Cost Rs. 48.56 Lacs.

5. 19/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27, Shifting of 33 kv & 11 kv overhead line and double pole structure at Various location near A2 & A1 of Newly Constructed Bhangel Elevated Road, Noida. Cost Rs. 81.00 Lacs.

6. 08/GM/AO/Sr. M.(E&M)-II/2026-27/ET, Annual Maintenance of Community Center in Sector-11,12,62,63A, Hazratpur Wazidpur, Bahloipur, Chotpur, Nawada, Jhundpura & Chhijarshi, Noida. Cost Rs. 55.87 Lacs.

7. 03/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27, Providing Lighting arrangement on Newly Constructed Roads between Sector-166 and 163, Noida. Cost Rs. 58.73 Lacs.

8. 06/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27, Annual Maintenance of Street Light in Sector-161,162,163,164,165,166,167 & 168, Noida. Cost Rs. 37.82 Lacs.

9. 08/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27, Supply of 82.5 KVA DG set and Internal Electrification at CNC Furnace Building Hall Antim Niwas Sector-94, Noida. Cost Rs. 32.19 Lacs.

10. 11/GM(E/M)/Sr.M(E/M)-IV/2026-27, Electrical Maintenance Shaheed Bhagat Singh Park Sector-150 and Central Park of Sector-155, Noida. Cost Rs. 32.60 Lacs.

11. 12/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27, Providing Street Lighting arrangement on Ponds at Village-Sultanpur, Noida. Cost Rs. 35.93 Lacs.

12. 14/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27, Beautification work at Expressway Near Sector-14A, 15A Noida. Cost Rs. 36.20 Lacs.

13. 16/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27, Annual Maintenance of Street Light in Sector-149, 149A, 150, 151,151A, 152,153, Noida. Cost Rs. 64.11 Lacs.

Which can be uploaded by date: 10.06.2026 Upto 5.00 PM. pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date: - 11.06.2026 at 11.00 AM.

(B)

1. 05/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27, Providing Lighting arrangement in Water tank T-Point to Advent Road Sector-142, Noida. Cost Rs. 48.53 Lacs

Which can be uploaded by date: - 03.06.2026 Upto 5.00 PM. pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date: - 04.06.2026 at 11.00 AM.

Office Sector-5

General Manager (E&M) NOIDA

CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

PROSPECT

LIC launches revamped Jeevan Sathi policy



LIC on Wednesday launched a revamped Jeevan Sathi plan, which offers a combination of savings and protection. New Jeevan Sathi single premium and New Jeevan Sathi Limited premium were launched by LIC CEO and MD R Doraiswamy. Both are joint life plans that cover a married individual, along with his/her spouse, in a single policy, LIC said in a statement. The minimum basic sum assured is ₹3,00,000. While there is no upper limit, the maximum basic sum assured will be subject to acceptance decision as per board-approved underwriting policy, it said. The minimum age at entry is 18 years, LIC said, adding that the maximum age at entry varies depending on the option chosen, as available under the two plans, by the policyholder.

Antarmanh Consulting hosts Human Sustainability Summit



Antarmanh Consulting hosted the Human Sustainability Summit at the Indian Habitat Centre, New Delhi, bringing together policymakers, HR leaders, trust and safety leaders, wellness leaders and mental health professionals to deliberate on the future of work, AI, ESG priorities and the growing need for human-centric workplace practices. The summit was led by Seema Rekha, Founder Director, Antarmanh Consulting, and featured keynote addresses by Dr Dnyaneshwar Mulay, Former High Commissioner of India to the Maldives alongside Dr GP Rao, Founder & Managing Partner, GPR HR Consulting LLP and Ravi Shankar Sankaran, Chartered Accountant CFO, SMS Group. The summit also featured recognition segments honouring leaders and organisations contributing towards workplace well-being, sustainability and people-centric innovation.

Indian Army Gajraj Corps hosts Sonitpur SAMVAD



TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

The Gajraj Corps successfully hosted a Military-Civil Fusion Seminar at Tezpur titled "Sonitpur SAMVAD" — an initiative aimed at reinforcing civil-military collaboration under the overarching vision of "Samoochik Prayas Se Rashtranirman" with the guiding principle of "Rashtra Sarvopari."

The acronym SAMVAD embodies the core pillars of the initiative: Samanvay, Aatmanirbharta, Mansik Dridhta, Vishwas aur Vikas — Amritkaal ka Lakshya, Dhyeya Sarvopari.

The seminar witnessed participation from senior representatives of the State Administration and key institutions, including the Vice Chancellor of Tezpur University, Inspector General SSB, Inspector General Sonitpur Range, Divisional Forest Officer, Deputy Inspector General of Police, Chairman of the Bar Council and Municipality, members of the medical fraternity of Tezpur, including management representatives from private hospitals, Principal of the Skill Development Centre Mangaldoi, Additional Deputy Commissioners of Tezpur and Missamari, along with several other important stakeholders.

Addressing the distinguished gathering, the General Officer Commanding (GOC), Gajraj Corps, highlighted JAI — Jointness, Aatmanirbharta and Innovation — as the guiding framework for building a secure, resilient and future-ready India in line with the national vision of ViksitBharat2047.

The GOC also emphasised the importance of coordinated action, convergence of institutional capabilities

Brigadier NC Khuman reviews training at 1 Assam Battalion NCC Camp

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nalbari



Brigadier NC Khuman, Group Commander, Guwahati Group, NCC, visited the Combined Annual Training Camp 34 being conducted by 1 Assam Battalion NCC at Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Nalbari, on Wednesday. The CATC-34 commenced on May 23 and will conclude on June 1, 2026.

The Group Commander was briefed by the Commanding Officer, 1 Assam Bn NCC on training activities being undertaken by over 520 cadets from schools and colleges across districts and the town of

Kamrup Metro, Nalbari, Baksa, Barma and Rangia. Cadets are undergoing training in drill, weapon handling, map reading, field craft, social service and community development during the 10-day camp.

Brig NC Khuman inspected training areas, witnessed presentations by cadets and interacted with them. He emphasised the role of NCC in building character, discipline and leadership among youth. "NCC is shaping nation builders. Use this camp to learn skills that will serve you and Bharat for life," he told the cadets.

Dr Ravindra Kumar Tyagi joins Power Foundation of India as DG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Dr Ravindra Kumar Tyagi has joined the Power Foundation of India as director general on Wednesday.

With over 35 years of distinguished experience in the power sector, Dr Tyagi brings deep expertise across power systems, transmission, asset management, engineering, business development, telecom, load dispatch, safety, and grid operations.

Prior to this role, he superannuated as Chairman & Managing Director of Power Grid Corporation of India

Limited and also served as Director (Operations) and Executive Director (North-Eastern Region).

An electrical engineer from Punjab Engineering College with an M.Tech in Energy Studies from the Indian Institute of Technology Delhi,

Dr Tyagi is also a Fulbright Scholar from Carnegie Mellon University.

A respected thought leader in the global power ecosystem, he has represented India in several international technical committees, authored over 50 technical papers, and contributed significantly to the development of global technical standards in transmission systems. His achievements include the prestigious 1906 Award for exceptional contribution towards IEC standards development and recognition from CIGRE as a Distinguished Member.

Recognising the early signs of heart disease can save lives



DR DK SATSANGI

Heart disease is increasing rapidly in India, yet a large number of people still ignore its early warning signs. During my years of surgical practice and clinical research, I have repeatedly seen patients reaching hospitals only when their condition has already become critical. In many such cases, timely diagnosis and early treatment could have prevented serious complications and even saved lives.

One of the biggest misconceptions is that heart disease affects only elderly individuals. In reality, serious cardiac conditions are also found in children and young adults.

Parents often overlook symptoms such as excessive fatigue during play, shortness of breath, bluish discoloration of the lips or fingers, recurrent cough, fainting episodes, or poor physical growth in children. These signs should never be ignored, as they may indicate an underlying congenital heart defect.

My research and surgical

experience involving complex and rare cardiac disorders have shown how dangerous delayed diagnosis can become. In one rare case, a young patient was found to have an unusual tumor inside the heart that initially appeared to be a routine cardiac problem.

Such cases remind us that persistent symptoms like breathlessness, chest discomfort, irregular heartbeat, dizziness, or unexplained weakness require proper medical evaluation rather than self-medication or neglect.

Work related to congenital conditions such as

Tetralogy of Fallot has also demonstrated that timely surgical intervention can completely transform a child's quality of life. Modern cardiac surgery today offers several effective treatment options, including cost-effective reconstructive techniques that can help patients even in resource-limited settings. What matters most is awareness and timely action.

Equally important is post-operative care. Many patients believe that treatment ends after surgery, but recovery depends heavily on following medical advice carefully. Fever, infection, breathing

difficulty, chest pain, or unusual weakness after surgery should be reported immediately. Ignoring these warning signs can lead to avoidable complications.

Lifestyle also plays a major role in protecting heart health. Regular health check-ups, maintaining healthy blood pressure and blood sugar levels, avoiding tobacco, reducing stress, exercising regularly, and following a balanced diet are simple but powerful preventive measures. Prevention remains far better than emergency treatment.

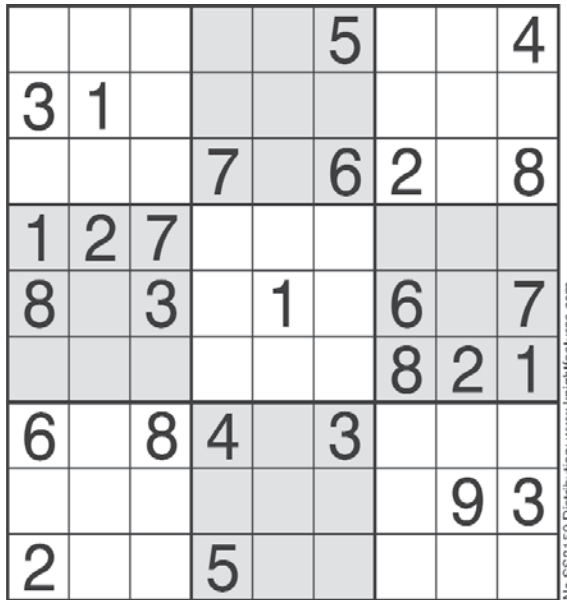
As a cardiac surgeon and researcher, I strongly believe

that awareness is one of the most powerful tools in modern healthcare. The human body often gives early warnings before a major cardiac event occurs. Listening to those signals and seeking timely medical attention can make the difference between life and death.

Heart disease should not be feared, but it should never be ignored. Early diagnosis, informed decisions, and timely treatment can save countless lives.

The author is the ex-director – professor & head of cardio thoracic surgery, GB Pant Hospital.

DAILY SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

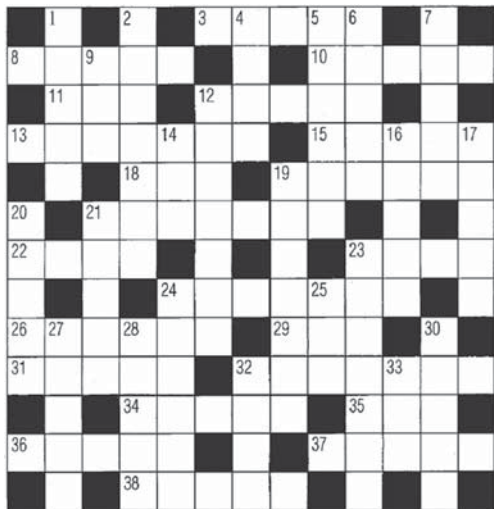
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (27.5.26)

3	5	1	7	6	8	4	2	9
4	7	9	3	2	5	6	1	8
2	6	8	1	9	4	7	5	3
6	4	7	5	1	3	8	9	2
9	3	5	4	8	2	1	7	6
1	8	2	9	7	6	5	3	4
8	9	6	2	5	1	3	4	7
7	1	4	6	3	9	2	8	5
5	2	3	8	4	7	9	6	1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD THURSDAY | MAY 28, 2026



- ACROSS**
- 3 Contact causing a painful cry at the treatment centre (5)
 - 8 Resentful: a bit grieved in any case (5)
 - 10 Chap who took a chicken round for his mum (2-3)
 - 11 This involves hot water and some steam (3)
 - 12 It's essential to most Latvians, possibly
 - 13 An animated character such as Homer
 - 15 Leslie, out of work, goes running (5)
 - 18 Express in a sharp utterance (3)
 - 19 Have another shot at photography (6)
 - 21 Professionally, a good match (7)
 - 22 The French hard-hearted king? (4)
- DOWN**
- 1 It's a caper when one has only a half ticket (5)
 - 2 The cover's a bit awry when the paper's torn (7)
 - 4 The immortal love racket (4)
 - 5 In the house, talk about the part of "Learn" (6)
 - 6 Though humble, he has a fortune (5)
 - 7 Science fiction's contribution to pepper pot design (5)
 - 9 Margaret turns up with the treasure (3)
 - 12 Favour a candidate of overt stupidity!
 - 14 The tanner's son, we hear (3)
 - 16 Where a capital standard exists (5)
 - 17 Seen as about five, but actually older
 - 23 Old-time dance! (4)
 - 24 But not too self-important possibly to mop spilt soup? (7)
 - 26 Look angry enough to bring a gang leader down (6)
 - 29 The village recidivist? (3)
 - 31 Spaniard possibly sore about a bit of fun (5)
 - 32 Pie aunt made as a bloomer (7)
 - 34 Is carried free, on paper (5)
 - 35 It gets an athlete nowhere (3)
 - 36 Ensnare a girl with love (5)
 - 37 See a silly imitator prance about (5)
 - 38 He's ready for a rhyme (5)
 - 19 Gets annoyed about the little pages making waves (7)
 - 20 Publicity coming quietly to one's ears
 - 21 The maestro may take one in hand (5)
 - 23 Vessel taking a regular part in a circulatory system (7)
 - 24 In history, nothing to take abnormal pride about (6)
 - 25 It's a singular cereal! (3)
 - 27 For instance, possibly all out to be legitimate (5)
 - 28 A better rebuttal (5)
 - 30 One playing the piano in support? (5)
 - 32 For each one, there's a supernatural beauty (4)
 - 33 A pile of green apples (3)

Punjab Governor to attend Samkalp Ludhiana annual felicitation programme on June 22

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ludhiana



Governor of Punjab, Gulab Chand Kataria, has accepted the invitation to attend the annual felicitation programme of Samkalp Ludhiana as the Chief Guest, scheduled to be held on June 22, 2026, at Ludhiana, Punjab.

In this regard, Narinder Mittal, President of Samkalp Ludhiana, met the Governor at Chandigarh along with Harish Saggar and Rajesh Nauharia and formally invited him to grace the prestigious annual event dedicated to honouring newly selected civil servants from Punjab.

Speaking on the occasion, Narinder Mittal informed that during the programme, stu-

dents selected in the Indian Civil Services Examination, including IAS, IPS and other prestigious services, from across Punjab will be felicitated for their outstanding achievements.

Established in 1986, SAMKALP (Headquarters: Delhi) has been working with the vision of guiding and grooming students to join the

administrative services of the country with a spirit of nationalism, integrity and commitment towards human values.

Under the aegis of Sahyog Shiksha Sewa Samittee, a voluntary organisation registered under the Societies Registration Act and dedicated to education and social service, SAMKALP Ludhiana

has been actively conducting various guidance and mentorship programmes for civil services aspirants at school and college levels for the last nearly 10 years.

Through its collective initiatives across India, SAMKALP has benefitted more than 7,500 successful candidates, many of whom are presently serving the nation in important capacities in India and abroad.

The annual felicitation programme of Samkalp Ludhiana has over the years witnessed the esteemed presence of several distinguished dignitaries, including governors, union ministers, members of parliament and eminent personalities from public life.

Khadi-village industries product sales cross historic ₹1.87 lakh crore mark in FY26

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Khadi and Village Industries sector has surpassed an extraordinary journey of growth and transformation over the last 12 years. In the financial year 2025-26, the sales of Khadi and Village Industries products reached a historic level of ₹1,87,105 crore, marking the highest sales figure to date and standing as a powerful testament to rural India's growing entrepreneurship, self-reliance, and economic empowerment.

Inspired by national campaigns such as 'Aatmanirbhar Bharat', 'Vocal for Local', and 'Local to Global', Khadi present-

ly is no longer merely a traditional product; however, it has evolved into a vibrant symbol of the 'New India's' self-reliant, indigenous pride, and rural prosperity.

Creating new benchmarks in production, marketing, and employment generation, the Khadi and Village Industries sector has brought new

energy and direction into the country's rural economy.

While releasing the provisional data for the financial year 2025-26, Manoj Kumar, KVIC Chairman, stated that the Commission has established new records in the fields of production, sales, and employment generation. He highlighted that,

PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY
e-TENDER CALL NOTICE
No./EM/PEP/09/2026
Date: 22/05/2026

No.: EM/PEP/TECH-30/2025/109
Date: 22/05/2026

Name of the work: Maintenance contract of streetlights installed inside Port Township for a period of three years. Estimated Cost: Rs.2,73,71,558/- excluding GST. Last date & time of submission of bid: dt.15.06.2026 up to 18:00 Hrs. Refer our website for details <https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app>.
Sd/- Executive Engineer (E), (PEP-III)
Paradip Port Authority
PPA/PR/11/2026-2027 dtd. 26.05.2026

BRIEFLY

Gauff involved in minor car crash enroute French Open



Coco Gauff was involved in a car accident on the way to Roland Garros for the first match of her French Open title defense. She did not appear injured. "We got in a mini car accident on my way to the site today," Gauff told TNT Sports with a laugh. "We ran into a (pole). You felt a little impact. I spilled my juice all over the car. The car was not drivable. So we ended up taking a taxi," Gauff added after beating fellow American Taylor Townsend 6-4, 6-0. Gauff started her match earlier than expected when there was a retirement in another match on Court Philippe-Chatrier. "And then right before I went onto court, my dress got stuck, so my physio was in the bathroom trying to help me take it off," Gauff said. (AP)

Denmark goalkeeper Kasper Schmeichel retires



Denmark and Celtic goalkeeper Kasper Schmeichel, who was part of the Premier League-winning team with Leicester in 2016 in one of soccer's biggest shocks, has announced his retirement from soccer because of a serious shoulder injury. "When my contract with Celtic expires in June, my career as an active footballer stops," Schmeichel said in an interview with TV2 in Denmark broadcast Wednesday. "I think this is the right time now to announce that I have played my last professional football match." The 39-year-old Schmeichel has been sidelined since February. Schmeichel — the son of former Manchester United great Peter Schmeichel — revealed in March he required two surgeries but that he wanted to try to salvage his career. The former Manchester City, Leeds, Nice and Anderlecht keeper, who played at the 2018 and 2022 World Cups, said "it's not how I would have wanted my career to end." (AP)

India hope to regain rhythm in series against England ahead of T20 World Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chelmsford (UK)

India will look to regain consistency and finalise their combination in the final dress rehearsal for next month's women's T20 World Cup when they take on hosts England in a three-match series starting here on Thursday.

With the global event set to begin on June 12, the tour assumes added significance for Harmanpreet Kaur's side, which has shown flashes of brilliance over the past year but has struggled to maintain momentum consistently.

India's preparations for the T20 World Cup have been a mixed bag. They began strongly with a commanding 5-0 clean sweep over Sri Lanka at home last December before scripting history in Australia by clinching a 2-1 T20I series victory, their first bilateral series win there



in a decade. The triumph in Australia was seen as a major step forward for a side that has often struggled overseas, especially in pressure situations. The batters' aggressive approach and the bowlers' discipline offered encouraging signs in the lead-up to the World Cup. However, the momentum dropped during the subsequent

South Africa tour where India endured a disappointing 1-4 defeat in conditions that exposed several concerns ahead of the marquee tournament.

The batting lacked consistency, the middle order struggled to finish games, and the bowling attack failed to deliver regularly in crunch moments as India looked out of rhythm for most of the series.

Norway Chess' 'confession box' finds its newest fan

AJAI MASAND ■ Oslo

Divya Deshmukh has quickly embraced the famed "confession box" in her maiden appearance at Norway Chess, once again highlighting why the concept has become one of modern chess' most refreshing innovations — even if it is yet to fully catch on among India's other leading grandmasters.

Soon after defeating compatriot Koneru Humpy in the second round here on Tuesday, the 20-year-old revealed with a smile that her visits to the confession box during the game had actually helped her calculate variations better. Divya stepped into the box twice during the



contest, candidly sharing her thoughts while the game was still in progress.

Introduced by Norway Chess in 2015, the confession box allows players to briefly leave the board and speak directly to the camera, offering viewers rare insight into their emotions, calculations and strategies in real time. (PTI)

Sabalenka's necklaces sparkle in French Open

JEROME PUGMIRE/ANDREW DAMPF ■ Paris

Aryna Sabalenka's diamonds sparked in the sun during a first-round victory at the heat-soaked French Open.

The top-ranked Sabalenka looked light on her feet on Court Philippe-Chatrier, despite wearing two thick necklaces in a 6-4, 6-2 win against Jessica Bouzas Maneiro.

"Diamonds, I don't really feel the heaviness, but I can imagine how it looks from the outside," said Sabalenka, the tournament runner-up last year to Coco Gauff. "So I feel pretty comfortable. For me, it's important to look good."

The four-time major winner was initially going to wear three necklaces but said she thought that might be too much.

"It probably sounds a bit crazy, but when I feel good about what I'm wearing, how I look on court, I tend to perform much better," Sabalenka said. "I like to bring a little bit of a fashion on the tennis court. I know the dress that I will wear on the Grand Slam, and I just try to

Women's soccer star Alexia Putellas leaves Barcelona after 14 seasons

TALES AZZONI ■ Madrid

Two-time Ballon d'Or winner Alexia Putellas, who has helped women's soccer grow in Spain and worldwide, is leaving Barcelona after 14 seasons.

Barcelona said Tuesday that Putellas will officially bid farewell at an event at Camp Nou stadium on Wednesday, giving the club a "chance to recognize the legacy created by a player who has become a role model on and off the field and who has helped women's football to grow across the globe."

The 32-year-old Putellas on Saturday helped Barcelona win the Champions League title for the fourth time in six seasons.

There was no immediate announcement about her next move, with speculation in Spain that she may join the fast-emerging London City Lionesses. Putellas attended a Lionesses game in



London in January. Putellas played 507 games for Barcelona — second on the all-time list — since arriving at age 18 in 2012 from Levante, the Catalan club said.

Putellas scored 232 goals for Barcelona, a club record, and won 38 trophies, including four Champions Leagues and 10 Spanish league titles. "The time has come to acknowledge that I've given everything for these colors," Putellas said in a video

posted on her social media accounts. "It's been a perfect story."

She was Barcelona's best player when it won its first Champions League in 2021 and helped put women's soccer in Spain on the global map when she won back-to-back Ballon d'Or awards in 2021 and 2022. Her boost to the sport was considered key to helping Spain win the 2023 World Cup.

When Spain was embroiled in crisis after its then soccer federation president Luis Rubiales kissed a player without consent during the World Cup awards ceremony, it was Putellas who led the player revolt that prompted his downfall.

"We've taken the women's team further than we ever imagined," Putellas said. "At the beginning, being a soccer player wasn't even recognized as a profession. Now I feel privileged to have been part of this change." (AP)

Norway Chess: Gukesh, Praggnanandhaa have awful day

AJAI MASAND ■ Oslo

D Gukesh ran out of steam and surrendered to Wesley So in Armageddon after failing to convert his classical promise, while red-hot Frenchman Alireza Firouzja tore past R Praggnanandhaa to storm to the top on a bruising second day for the Indians at Norway Chess here.

Defending champion Magnus Carlsen was pushed to the brink yet again by German sensation Vincent Keymer before the seven-time champion finally escaped with an Armageddon victory, clawing his way to his first points of the tournament after another fierce battle.

Despite the disappointing second-round Armageddon result, Gukesh stayed joint second with So on 2.5 points, while the rampant Firouzja opened up a commanding lead with six points after back-to-back wins.



Praggnanandhaa and Carlsen, meanwhile, languished at the bottom with 1.5 points each in the prestigious event.

To make matters worse for Gukesh, who will turn 20 in a couple of days, So bluntly remarked after the game that he was "not quite sure" the Indian was as strong as his rating sug-

gested.

Gukesh, visibly shaken by the Armageddon defeat, tried to put up a brave face during his mandatory broadcast duties, but the frustration was hard to miss when he walked away with anger and disappointment written all over his face. In the marathon classical battle

lasting 116 moves, it was Gukesh who did most of the pressing and appeared to be cruising towards the winning line before So somehow escaped with a draw.

The American then completely outplayed the Indian in Armageddon, claiming 1.5 points to Gukesh's one and handing the world champion a crushing disappointment.

Praggnanandhaa appeared to be following a promising winning path against Firouzja early on, but the battered Frenchman — hobbling around in a moon boot, wheeled in by his second and clutching crutches because of a badly injured ankle — once again showed remarkable grit and class to turn the game around and beat the Indian with surprising ease.

The Frenchman later said, "I'm trying to play chess. I have a lot of pain, but it's something that keeps me focused — it makes me not think about pain." (PTI)

Veterans, sons and surprises shape US football team for World Cup

RONALD BLUM ■ New York

Tim Ream was filled with anxiety, right up until 1 p.m. Friday.

"Leaving the training ground and walking to my car with a box full of bobbleheads to take home to my kids," the 38-year-old defender recalled, "my WhatsApp started to go a little bit crazy."

Ream was among 26 players who received a video in a group chat from Sam Zapata, the US national team administrative manager, informing those selected for the World Cup roster.

"Guys, if you are watching that video, it is because you are in," US coach Mauricio Pochettino told them. "I am so excited to communicate that you are going to be on the roster for the World Cup 2026, in the World Cup that you are going to host."



"It made me stop on my tracks," said Ream, hoping to become the oldest US player to appear in soccer's top tournament.

Midfielders Gio Reyna and Sebastian Berhalter, sons of a former

captain and an ex-coach, were picked by along with forward Alejandro Zendejas.

Midfielders Diego Luna and Tanner

Tessmann were left off.

Holding American jerseys with wavy red and white stripes, players were introduced

Tuesday at a made-for-TV event on the roof of the South Street Seaport's Pier 17 with the Brooklyn Bridge as a backdrop. They were announced in the numerical order of jersey numbers assigned by equipment manager Kyle Robertson, taking seniority into account. All were on hand except for defender Chris Richards, in Germany with Crystal Palace for

Wednesday's UEFA Conference League final.

"We want this so bad," said forward Christian Pulisic, the biggest American star. "If you're not a little bit nervous, you don't feel a little, you don't care. So, we care so much."

Defender Sergino Dest, midfielder Tyler Adams and forward Haji Wright were added after missing March friendlies because of injuries. Zendejas was bypassed for the March roster after a knee injury last fall.

A few minutes after the Friday video arrived, emails were sent to all 55 players on the preliminary roster informing them of their fate. Pochettino didn't give explanations to those omitted, comparing the rejection with how he felt when Tottenham executive chairman Daniel Levy fired him as manager in 2019 and then asked to speak. (AP)

"I have my fiance. He's kind of like my security," she said, smiling. "My physio does jujitsu, so I feel pretty secure walking around. If I go somewhere, I don't go alone."

Gauff began her title defense with a 6-4, 6-0 victory over fellow American Taylor Townsend, while four-time major winner Naomi Osaka beat Laura Siegemund 6-3, 7-6 (3) on Court Suzanne-Lenglen wearing a sequined gold playing dress.

Frenchwoman Lois Boisson, who made a surprise run to the semifinals last year when she was ranked 361st, lost 6-2, 6-2 to the 22nd-seeded Anna Kalinskaya.

For a third consecutive day, the temperature in Paris rose far above normal, reaching a scorching 35 degrees Celsius (95 Fahrenheit).

"I'm from Florida, so this is nothing. Shout-out Delray Beach," said Gauff, who kept her spare rackets in a court-side cooler during the match.

Medvedev loses early again: The unusually hot conditions made the courts faster than usual.

Daniil Medvedev usually thrives in such conditions but he struggled in a five-set loss to 97th-ranked Australian opponent Adam Walton. Walton, who received a wild card

invitation from tournament organizers, beat Medvedev 6-2, 1-6, 6-1, 1-6, 6-4. It was Medvedev's second straight first round exit here and third in four years.

"I know why I don't really play my best in Roland Garros, but if I say it, it's (making) excuses," he said. "So I keep it to myself."

Playing in the night session, top-ranked Jannik Sinner routed 171st-ranked French wild card entry Clement Tabur 6-1, 6-3, 6-4 to extend his winning streak to 30 matches as he chases the only big title missing in his tennis career.

Stefanos Tsitsipas, the 2021 runner-up to Novak Djokovic, was leading 6-2, 3-0 against Alexandre Muller when his French opponent retired. Muller injured his right calf, three months after injuring his left calf.

Ninth-seeded Alexander Bublik was beaten 7-5, 6-7 (6), 6-4, 7-5 by Jan-Lennard Struff.

Alexander Blockx withdrew from the tournament with a right ankle sprain, making Alex de Minaur — his scheduled second round opponent — the first player into the third round.

Rising star: French teenager Moise Kouame made the perfect start to his French Open career with a 7-6 (4), 6-2, 6-1 win over Marin Cilic. (AP)

Jannik Sinner discusses his Lego project after win at French Open

ANDREW DAMPF ■ Paris

Jannik Sinner already started building a miniature Eiffel Tower with Lego blocks. Now he's begun his pursuit of an elusive French Open title, too.

Sinner's first match back at Roland Garros after his dramatic five-set loss in last year's final couldn't have been more different than that epic encounter with Carlos Alcaraz. Playing in a first-round night session on Tuesday, the top-ranked Sinner routed 171st-ranked French wild card entry Clement Tabur 6-1, 6-3, 6-4 to extend his winning streak to 30 matches as he chases the only big title missing in his tennis career. "I'm very happy to be back here," Sinner said. "Great memories overall."

To get himself in the mood for Paris, Sinner and his brother started on their Eiffel Tower Lego project when he spent a few days at home in northern Italy after his recent Italian Open title. "We tried to finish it. We couldn't. Because they are always the same pieces together. So at some point it's very boring. But you know we are we are not far away, so I know after this tournament I go back home and then I'm going (to) send you guys a picture when it's finished," Sinner told the crowd on Court Philippe-Chatrier. (AP)



Sooryavanshi, Archer power Rajasthan Royals to Qualifier 2

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mullanpur

The cricketing world once again bowed down to the generational talent of Vaibhav Sooryavanshi following his six-laden 97 off 29 balls before Jofra Archer broke the backbone of Sunrisers Hyderabad's muscular batting to set up a 47-run win for Rajasthan Royals in the IPL Eliminator here on Wednesday.

The 15-year-old Sooryavanshi smashed as many as 12 sixes in his breathtaking knock and missed the IPL's fastest hundred by just a few yards.

Rajasthan Royals slipped to 243 for eight after an ordinary last five overs but the runs proved more than enough for them against a power packed Sunrisers who exited the tournament after getting all out for 196 in 19.2 overs.

Archer removed the destructive trio of Abhishek Sharma, Travis Head and Ishan Kishan in the powerplay to effectively seal the game for his team.

Royals face Gujarat Titans in Qualifier 2 here on Friday with the winner meeting Royal Challengers Bengaluru in the final.

The night belonged to two X factor players, first Sooryavanshi who toyed with the likes of Pat Cummins, and Archer, who ran



through the Sunrisers' top-order with his extra pace.

Put in to bat, Sooryavanshi slayed Cummins and Co. with absolute disdain, similar to the treatment meted out to champions like Jasprit Bumrah and Kagiso Rabada earlier in the competition.

Someone who keeps pushing

his boundaries at such a young age, the left-hander went on a six hitting spree (12 in total) as if the fans were watching a high-lights package.

On a true surface, the SRH and Australian captain and his bowling mates tried everything against Sooryavanshi but the

free-flowing young batter responded by sending balls after balls into the stands.

Not so long ago, he had told Kevin Pietersen on his outrageous ambition of scoring a 200 in a T20 game. With the way he was operating in Mullanpur, a double hundred was very much

on the cards.

Eventually, he narrowly missed out on breaking the fastest IPL hundred record of Chris Gayle (30 balls) by getting caught at third man off Praful Hinge in the eighth over. For the youngest IPL centurion, another record was there for the taking but he missed out by just one hit.

The slow walk back to the pavilion displayed his dejection even though he was applauded by everyone in the stadium, including the opposition.

It was a good batting surface but the ball striking from Sooryavanshi was phenomenal. Anything full was smoked back over the bowler's head, the predictable short ball was slashed over third man and anything on his pads was picked up over fine leg. The fast hands were working wonders.

Cummins, who was hammered for four sixes by Sooryavanshi, had run out of answers and so did others. The Australian is among the wildest operators on the field but discussions with the leadership group after every Sooryavanshi six became a routine.

While hitting sixes at will, the left-hander did break Gayle's record (59 sixes) for most sixes in a season. He has cleared the fence a staggering 65 times this season.

Sooryavanshi narrowly misses IPL's fastest 100

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mullanpur

Rajasthan Royals' star batter Vaibhav Sooryavanshi on Wednesday narrowly missed registering the fastest century in the Indian Premier League history during his team's Eliminator clash against Sunrisers Hyderabad here, but broke Chris Gayle's record of most sixes in an edition.

The 15-year-old Sooryavanshi, playing in his second season of the world's most lucrative T20 league, was just one hit away from reaching triple figures when reached 97 off 28 balls.

But he missed achieving the feat of fastest IPL century by just one ball as he, in the next ball, played an upper-cut off a short ball from Praful Hinge which flew to R Smaran at deep third man. Sooryavanshi walked off for 97 off 29 balls after hammering 12 sixes and five boundaries.

West Indian and Royal Challengers Bengaluru legend Chris Gayle holds the record of the fastest century in IPL, off 30 balls, during his knock of 175 off 66 balls with 17 sixes and 13 fours for RCB against Pune Warriors in IPL 2013.

Coming into this clash,

Sooryavanshi was six sixes behind Gayle, who had recorded 59 sixes in the 2012 edition. Sooryavanshi's dozen hits over the ropes took him past Gayle's record as the youngster accumulated 65 maximums in IPL 2026.

His 65 sixes was also well clear of the season's second-best, Abhishek Sharma's 43 maximums. Sooryavanshi had recorded the second fastest century of the IPL, off 35 balls, when he scored 101 off 38 balls (11 sixes, 7 fours) in IPL 2025 for RR against Gujarat Titans.

The left-handed opening batter also holds the record for the third fastest IPL ton, off 36 balls, hitting 12 sixes and five fours for his 37-ball 103 against SRH earlier this season.

Legendary batter Sachin Tendulkar praised Sooryavanshi's bat swing and termed his innings as "spectacular".

"Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's bat swing has been outstanding. What's even more remarkable is how beautifully he clears his front foot to create room for balls aimed at his legs. This freedom allows him to play the way he does," Tendulkar wrote on 'X'.

Nihal Sarin qualifies for Esports World Cup's chess event



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Indian Grandmaster Nihal Sarin, representing esports and gaming content outfit S8UL, has qualified for the chess event of the upcoming Esports World Cup (EWC) in Paris through the Champions Chess Tour (CCT) leaderboard.

He has joined teammate Aravindh Chithambaram, becoming only the second Indian player to qualify for the prestigious tournament so far. This year's EWC chess competition will have a prize pool of USD 1.5 million (Rs 14.3 crore) and will take place from August 11 to 15.

Overall, the EWC is set to take place from July 6 to August 23 featuring over 2,000 players from 200 clubs across more than 100 countries competing for a record-breaking prize pool of USD 75 million (₹ 718 crore).

The CCT season featured two major events, the Speed Chess Championship (SCC) 2025 and Chess.com Open (CCO) 2026. Nihal narrowly missed out on direct qualification through the CCO after fin-

ishing fourth, just one spot away from qualification, but still secured 100 crucial leaderboard points from the event.

He further added points through consistent performances across the TTGP circuit, including one point in the Autumn Split and four points in the Winter Split.

A standout second-place finish in the Spring Split ultimately helped him accumulate 34 points and finish with a total of 139 points in the standings to secure his berth at the EWC 2026.

The top three players from both SCC and CCO secured direct qualification to the EWC, while players finishing between fifth and ninth in SCC, along with the remaining participants in CCO, earned points toward the CCT leaderboard based on their performances.

In addition to these events, players also accumulated points through the Titled Tuesday Grand Prix (TTGP) circuit, which was divided into Autumn, Winter, and Spring splits featuring 13 Titled Tuesday tournaments each.

RCB's collective firepower makes them a 'complete tea', says Bobat

AMANPREET SINGH ■ Dharamsala

Royal Challengers Bengaluru director of cricket Mo Bobat credited the franchise's "collective contributions" and fearless identity after the defending champions thrashed Gujarat Titans in Qualifier 1 to storm into a second successive IPL final.

RCB, who piled up a massive 254 for five before bundling out GT for 162, were powered by skipper Rajat Patidar's blistering unbeaten 93 off 33 balls and an all-round bowling effort on Tuesday.

Bobat said the biggest take-away from RCB's dominant run over the last two seasons was the number of players stepping up consistently in pressure situations.

"I'm especially pleased that we've got a number of people contributing to wins. We're not too dependent on one or two players with the



bat or one or two with the ball. We've got a number of people contributing and that's the really pleasing thing," Bobat said after the 92-run win.

"If everybody contributes and fulfils their roles, then results should take care of themselves. That's probably the most encouraging

thing to come out of today's game, as well as the fact that obviously you're into the final," he added.

Bobat reserved special praise for captain Patidar, whose explosive innings dismantled the Titans attack after RCB lost a couple of early wickets.

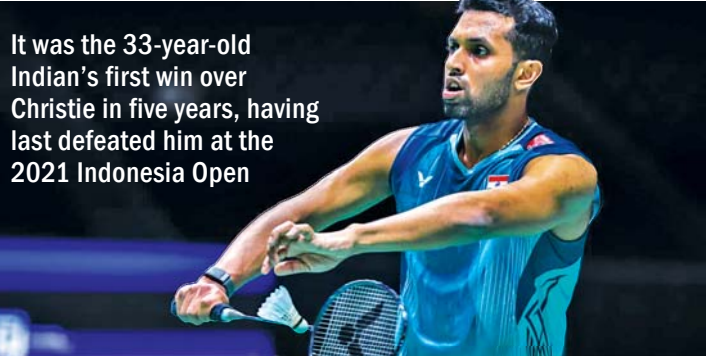
"He's certainly batting brilliantly right now and that was a really special knock today. I'm sure he'll be really pleased about being able to stand up in a big qualifier and a big game," he said. (PTI)

Prannoy stuns Christie, Lakshya beat Lu in Singapore Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Singapore

Star Indian shuttlers HS Prannoy and Lakshya Sen advanced to the men's singles second round with stunning wins at the USD 1,000,000 Singapore Open Super 750 badminton tournament here on Wednesday. Prannoy, a 2023 World Championships and Asian Games bronze medallist, produced a composed performance to prevail 10-21 21-12 21-18 over the world No. 5 Jonatan Christie of Indonesia in just over an hour.

It was the 33-year-old Indian's first win over Christie in five years, having last defeated him at the 2021 Indonesia Open.



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Prannoy, who played epic roles in India's 2022 Thomas Cup triumph and the recent bronze medal win in Denmark, will face Singapore's

former world champion Loh Kean Yew next.

Later in the day, Lakshya, a 2021 World Championships bronze

winner, saw off world No. 24 Lu Guang Zu 21-17 21-15 in 42 minutes to set up a second-round clash with second seeded Thai Kunlavut Vitidsarn.

The Indian mixed doubles pair of Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto also advanced to the second round after beating Malaysia's Wong Tien Ci and Lim Chiew Sien 21-14, 20-22, 21-13 in their opening match.

However, Kidambi Srikanth and Malvika Bansod couldn't cross the opening hurdle.

Srikanth, a former world No. 1 and a 2021 World Championships silver medallist, fought his heart out before succumbing 20-22 21-19 17-21 to local hero Loh Kean Yew, who

avenged last week's loss to the Indian.

Malvika, who is on a comeback trail after recovering from an ACL injury, also couldn't go the distance despite putting up a brave effort, losing 21-11 19-21 12-21 to Chinese Taipei's Lin Hsiang Ti.

In women's doubles, Panda sisters — Rutaparna and Swetaparna — lost 9-21 17-21 to Thailand's P. Aiamvareesrisakul and S. Janpeng in another match.

Prannoy vs Christie: Coming into the match with a 3-7 head-to-head record, Prannoy found himself against the wall again when Christie zoomed past him in the opening game.

Athletics: India to host 2027 Asian Relays and 2028 Asian Indoor Championships



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Indian cities of Chandigarh and Bhubaneswar were on Wednesday awarded hosting rights of next year's Asian Relays and the 2028 Asian Indoor Championships respectively by the continent's athletics governing body during its executive council meeting in Hong Kong.

Association's (AAA) council meeting was held ahead of the Asian U20 Championships from May 28 to 31. "India has got the Asian Relays in 2027 to be held in Chandigarh and Bhubaneswar will host the Asian Indoor Championships in 2028. It's a very proud moment for the country," World Athletics Vice-President Adille Sumariwalla, who attended the AAA council meeting in Hong Kong, said.

Indian sporting fraternity mourns former shooter Randhir Singh's death

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Olympic gold-medallist Abhinav Bindra led the tributes as the country's sporting fraternity mourned the demise of veteran administrator and former shooter Randhir Singh, describing him as a "true stalwart" and a charismatic leader of Indian sport.

India's first shooting gold medallist at the Asian Games, Singh died here on Wednesday after battling age-related ailments.

"Deeply saddened to hear of the passing of Raja Randhir Singh ji. He lived a life devoted to sport as an Olympian, as a sports administrator, and as someone who contributed immensely to Indian and World sport.

"His legacy will remain an important part of our sporting history. My heartfelt condolences to his family and loved ones." Bindra wrote on X in his tribute. Singh's brilliant sporting



journey included five Olympic appearances and the historic trap gold medal at the 1978 Bangkok Asian Games.

"A distinguished leader of the Olympic Movement, Raja Randhir Singh dedicated his life to the service of sport and the advancement of the Olympic values across Asia. The Olympic Council of Asia extends its sincere condolences to

his family, friends, colleagues, and the entire Olympic family. May he rest in peace," stated the Olympic Council of Asia, which Singh headed until earlier this year.

Cycling Federation of India secretary general Maninder Pal Singh described Singh as an administrator of exceptional stature and humanity.

"It is with the deepest sorrow that we bid farewell to Raja Randhir Singh, the most wonderful administrator, a man of exceptional humanity, and above all, a great and cherished friend. His passing today marks the end of an era in sport-not only in India but across the world.

"With his charismatic leadership and unwavering dedication, Raja Randhir Singh carried a legacy of the highest distinction, always upheld with the utmost dignity and grace. That legacy remains unparalleled and will never be forgotten," he added.

Harmanpreet returns to lead India in FIH Pro League's European leg

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Captain and ace drag-flicker Harmanpreet Singh on Wednesday returned to lead a 24-member Indian men's hockey squad for the European leg of next month's FIH Pro League, which will be a crucial preparatory competition ahead of the World Cup in August.

Harmanpreet had missed the Hobart leg of the Pro League in February citing personal reasons. The Indians will first travel to Brussels for training and a friendly match from June 7 to 9.

Following this short camp, the squad will be in Rotterdam in the Netherlands from June 10 for the Pro League matches against Germany and the Netherlands



scheduled for June 14 to 21.

Thereafter, the Indian team will fly to London, where it will face Pakistan and England in the Pro League from June 23 to 28.

The squad features a blend of seasoned veterans and young talent to solidify the core team heading into the World Cup, which begins August 15.